

Ninety-Nine

Reconstructed Editorial Proof

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Internal working proof.

Built from the surviving manuscript plus a modern reconstructed
continuation.

Contents

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Chapter 1

I stood on the corner of Pierce Street looking toward the bay. The wind whipped at my back, carrying off the smoke from my cigarette as quickly as I could exhale it. The day had been long and tumultuous, my mind saturated with memories of her. The city rose to thick clusters of clouds which looked as though they might burst at any moment; the damp, moist air wrapping itself around my bones. I took a long drag from the cig and saw her again in my mind. She'd been haunting my dreams lately, the woman with soft red hair and deep sanguine eyes. Last night I dreamt I was lying next to her, the rain beating on her window like a stranger.

Drizzle fell from the dank sky. I put out the cigarette and shoved my hands deep into the pockets of my coat. Bile welled in my throat. I looked at the haphazard stacks of dwellings across the bay on the Oakland hillside. Azlya, my most recent lover, was there somewhere. It mattered not if I would find her; she had left me—it was over between us. I was so alive with her; now, without her presence, I am dead. I dug through my pockets for another cigarette. I had none. I thought of buying another pack, but since I only had enough money for the bus ride back to the apartment, the idea seemed fruitless. I hated living in the apartment—I wouldn't be there at all if Azlya hadn't left me. My life with Rhindy had hit bottom six months ago; now we were together again, one in it for love, the other for desperation. I tried not to think of Rhindy, it only further depressed me, besides, she wouldn't be home until later this evening. I cherished the idea of being alone, drowning in my thoughts.

I wanted to go to Alameda and see Azlya, forget our horrid fight the day before, and just fuck. I wanted to escape as I had so many

times before—there was no reality with her, time froze. It could have been love, but she hates me now, I know it. I could never satisfy her, never sate her ferocious appetite for weirdness; her burden was my unwillingness to experiment. For I was too consumed with myself, obsessed with depression and letting my anger seethe. Maybe I could have experienced salvation through our relationship. I had hoped so, but she wasn't in the soul-saving business and I wasn't religious. Perhaps I should phone her and we could talk, talk about the old times and the good times and the times I was never around when she needed me. No, I'm not phoning her, not opening my soul to her. Always it is the same. . .so goddamned empty.

The phone rings and I answer it; the line is silent for a second or two and a man's voice comes over the line.

"Is Rhindy there?"

I tell him no and the voice dissolves; the phone is dead. I lie down on the couch Rhindy bought and try to sleep for a minute or two. I close my eyes and see myself standing on a street corner waiting for something. A woman walks by and smiles at me, then she takes my hand. She kisses the knuckles and bites my index finger. A little blood is drawn; she looks at what she's done and drops my hand. I follow her to Union Square into a group of pigeons; the birds disperse—wings frantically flapping—climbing high into the sky. She whirls around, her hair flung in a wave of red. I move closer to her; she is whispering. She draws my ear to her mouth, her voice is pleasantly sweet.

"Ninety-Nine. I am Ninety-Nine."

I open my eyes. I'm gazing at the radio near the television—both are Rhindy's also. I sigh heavily and sit up. I can't stand dreaming about her only to have such bliss snatched away by the jaws of reality. Not a moment passes when she isn't here, dancing and spinning about, coaxing my mind to come be with her. She drives me insane. If I could

only get her out of my head then things would be better; then my life could stabilize.

Rhindy is my roommate/girlfriend in the Sunset district. She supports me, perhaps loves me, and respects my insanity. In some ways I believe I love her in return, but she has too many annoying habits, too many odd friends who insist on calling at odd hours of the day and night. They ask if she's around, who the hell I am, and when she'll be back.

She likes wearing sweats and enjoys her job at a bank in the Financial District—an inconceivable combination when you consider she's not a bad lover. She cherishes me, that's why I go out and sleep with other women. I show my gratitude for her and her money in the most spontaneous ways. It wasn't that I completely neglected Rhindy—I took care of her the best I could; that seemed to be enough. She knew she couldn't expect much from a man calling himself a writer who was away eighty percent of the time. I needed my space; I needed experience, although sometimes it seemed as though I were afraid of it. But I didn't want Rhindy's promises of a comfortable life as a house-husband; I desired to go out and challenge the world and make something of myself, instead of settling for mediocrity. I was too driven to capsize everything I knew.

I find it amazing I get anything written these days, considering all the distractions. If it's not the neighbors and their loud stereo and fucking sounds, it's Nick pounding on the window announcing his ominous presence. And today is one of those days when he has stopped by to see me. We talk briefly about his life. I half pay attention to him and continue with my writing. He smiles and is now telling me about Nadine, an old flame from two summers back. He insists he never slept with her, but fell in love anyway. It's getting harder to write. He discusses virgin women and the hazards of having sex with them.

“It takes you three months to get into their pants, then two years to get them out of your hair.”

I pause and look at the things on my desk—the desk Rhindy bought. There isn’t much use trying to write any more; he has successfully distracted me. I shut off the typewriter and suggest we go out for coffee. He’s got a wide smile cut into his equally wide face; he nods.

Nick talks so prophetically about how he intends to have sex with his women. They are unfinished slabs of clay molded into any shape he desires—it is an art to be exploited. He wanted to write a book about it—The Conquests of Nick—go on lecture tours and have his mug plastered on every other billboard on the interstate. He wanted acclaim for his way of life and plenty of support. I laughed at him and we spoke of experience. As far as I was concerned, experience was as you got it and not how you intellectualized about it. Experience—I got a load of it trying to second guess Nick. Should tell him about Ninety-Nine? He’s spewing his stories. I didn’t think it would be wise. Nick believed experience was solely gauged by sexual worldliness—to date he claimed to have bagged twenty-four women—and from all his talk I had the strange feeling that even though his flings were trite and empty, he found them to be the richest things he’d ever known. In some ways I supposed Nick was an artist; he wanted to tackle the world, strip it bare and force it, like women and sex, to give in to his ways. He was an idealist in the worst sense of the term.

He and I are sitting in a quiet coffee shop on Pierce Street. He’s continuing with the stories. I’m distant and not listening, not watching his thick tongue as it bounces off his jaw rolling out words and words of conquest. I’m looking out the window to the bay. She is there, somewhere, but does not want me, does not need me—hates me. Maybe I hate her for what she did to me; maybe I hate myself for what I did to her. I don’t know. All I know is I have a hard-on under the table

and Nick is messily spewing bunk. I want to masturbate, pretend I'm inside her. I rub myself a couple of times then stop.

"Hey, Chris, I got the big "L" last night."

I pull out a cigarette and light it. "The big "L", huh?"

"Her name was Amy."

"Oh," I gaze out the window and watch the traffic buzz by. "How was she?"

"She was a skank, a whore."

Skank is one of his favorite expressions. It ranks right up with. . .

"I mean we blew it the fuck out."

And, "We drilled."

Plus. . .

"I even said, 'Fuck pig; howl skank.'"

"Must've meant a lot to you, Nick."

"Nah, it was just sex. A fuck. I need it every so often, you know. Once in a while I need to find a skank and fuck her. I have needs."

Nick was getting sappy on me. I put the cigarette out. "I always hear that word, skank, and I'm not quite sure what you mean by it."

"You know," he makes an obscene gesture with his hands. "A skank. A woman who comes out in the morning after a night of fucking, her hair tied up, wearing a robe, bunny slippers, stank breath, and she says to you, 'I want my cigarette, I want my coffee.' Uhh, that sucks."

"Oh." We stare at each other. I try to read him. What he was saying didn't make sense.

"Listen, Chris, she wasn't a skank in the good sense of the word."

"I didn't think there was one."

He smirked. "She was, like, faceless. I can't remember what she looked like. I was so fucked up on Jägermeister that I can't remember. But I do remember dropping a load somewhere in her vicinity, so I do know that I fucked her, but it was so. . ."

Nick is losing coherence. I hear Bill Withers playing over a distant jukebox. I try again to read Nick, wondering what deep thoughts are coursing their way through his head. He smiles. I knew exactly what he is thinking. He's trying to decide what he wants for dessert.

I turn my head and look out the window again. These "skanks" are nothing to him, nothing but an affirmation of his own nothingness and how he can attempt to escape from it. And in the aftermath of this magical union of nothing, there was the end result of realizing he was back at square one—he was hungry and wanted dessert.

"So, do you like Amy or was she just a fuck?" The song on the jukebox floods my senses—"Use Me".

"She was a skank, just a fuck, you lose. Speaking of skanks, how's Gale? You haven't been talking about her lately." He's laughing to himself. It's as if he's hit himself in a weird way and now is bemused by it. He wants to know about Gale. I look crossly at him. Nick, you poor Greenville piece of shit, if you only knew. . .if I could tell you. Tell you all the times I knock on the door to her room in the basement of her parents' house; tell you how many countless times she lets me in and we fuck; how I draw myself in and out in such a flurry with such energy—thrusting again and again until I'm spent. She says she loves it, but it's not enough. We could fuck three times a day and I'd still catch her fingering herself when I leave. I smile at Nick, he couldn't understand and I'm not about to give him the chance.

Azlya is on my mind again. She and Gale feel and fuck similarly; it's hard to get away from a feeling when it insists on intruding into your life. I feel as if I were on a sea, drifting aimlessly, stopping at assorted islands, and fucking—feeling wanted for a finite period of time then moving onto the next island. The time spent on each varied from woman to woman, but the end result was the same—someone left. But now I'm snagged, stranded on the isle of Ninety-Nine, my boat scuttled,

my life in disarray with no hopes of traveling anymore. I am lost, shipwrecked.

During the days and nights when Gale and I weren't fucking, we would visit some friends of hers. People like ex-boyfriends, lovers, past lesbian affairs, losers, jerk-offs, etcetera. One of these was Colin, an ineffectual musician who raved about the poignancy of black magic and grey, industrial music—he fell into several personality categories, and it was no shock to me to find he and Gale had gone out for nearly three years.

Gale spoke of him as if he were a god, on his ladder of lights moving to the top of mediocrity, where he would be greeted with obscenity. And obscenity not in the good sense. When I met him, I wasn't greatly impressed. Gale had done a job beefing his character, but I found him to be another distraught person trying to find himself—an aspect I could identify with. But I couldn't make myself like him. Sure, he had boned Gale god knows how many times, and he probably could do it better than I, but I figured fucking is fucking and we all know how to do it well enough. Especially to Gale, she was easy. Just set her on top of you, tweak her a little and let her go. How hard can that be, right?

Gale is the kind of woman people write about in psychological journals and deviant sexual texts. In fact, while we were having sex one time, I could have sworn having read about her somewhere before. Anyway, she had this habit of calling out other names. Like Scott or Valerie or Kelly—sometimes a Kyle or two. I got used to it after a while. Perhaps she was fantasizing about a past affair. I just concentrated on coming and had a grand old time. Things were great between us, then she started to change.

Sex with Gale only makes the pain easier to swallow, the escape more temporary each time. I need to find this woman from my dreams, my Ninety-Nine; I am safe with her, her nature wholesome and her

energy pure. I don't know how to go about finding her, but eventually some high tide will hit the island and I'll plot a course to the divine Ninety-Nine. And Gale, in a skewed way, reminded me of Ninety-Nine. I wanted to fall into a pit of despair with her, let the world crash in and suffocate us. I'd rather die than live with my fraying soul.

It's odd, once you fall into a rut of feeling sorry for yourself it's nearly impossible to get out. And I've got myself dug in good. I don't feel like doing anything, I don't even feel like writing anymore. Azlya told me once, that my eyes were sad, that there wasn't room for hate, which she found redeemable, but the lack of passion caused her to end our relationship. Perhaps it's true that I fall out of life, let everything go, wallow in failure, and writhe in the manacles of bitterness and depression.

Nick has a broad smile on his face. He motions with his eyes. He's found another woman to scam on. Forget it Nick, she's too good for you, she could never appreciate your baseness like I can. I'm not much interested in a woman right now, I'm feeling too lost. But I try to snap out of it; I look and concentrate on the usual physicality, but it's no use. I can't get excited. If passion is a happy hard-on, I lost it five minutes ago.

Nick seems content with the world. He likes the atmosphere of the restaurant we're in—the women particularly. I sip from my cup; the coffee's gotten cold, but not bad. I wave to the waitress for a refill. Nick smiles broadly.

Hate within me is like a tub of oil ready to boil over. I don't dare spill the scorching liquid, but occasionally the heat's too high and it splashes out, burning me. I wonder if Nick could really understand what I felt if I told him. A friend is supposed to be there to talk to, to vent frustrations and get on with life. But I don't think he could handle my thoughts, or he'd belittle everything I said. I remain silent.

Today is a grand morning in the Sunset! The rain has cleared, the sun is shining, and I feel irresponsible. Rhindy is at work and I have a head full of ideas how not to do anything today. I had a dream about Gale and her sister. It was an odd dream; I was lying naked with both of them. I made a remark that Elsa, the sister, didn't look a thing like Gale or her parents, that maybe she had been switched in the hospital. She looked blankly at me and replied,

"Well, we have the same tits." I looked closely—sure enough.

I woke with a raging erection.

Later in the morning, I thought of fucking Gale. I was still horny from the dream and I knew all the masturbation in the world wouldn't sate me. I made myself breakfast from the little bits of cereal, eggs, and milk I could scrounge out of the refrigerator. Rhindy bought most everything in the apartment, and it was time she went shopping again. Maybe I could persuade her to buy a bag of Oreos for those nights when I kept her awake typing. Rhindy was usually generous in my presence, buying me enough to keep me going, and giving me money, among other things. That's what sometimes made it hard to cheat on her; she was so innocent, so naive. She denied it emphatically, but I knew better—for she had not caught me at my game. I made it fairly easy, too, leaving clues—wafts of perfume on my clothes, notes of chance rendezvous, pictures and letters. All this I did; maybe she'd notice and catch me, that was a facet of the excitement of the game. I read somewhere that a lover only cheats if something is missing from the relationship—something I always believed to be true. Rhindy was kind, stable, and forgiving, but she didn't have the faintest idea what went on in my life, nor did she care. She saw only interest rates, mutual funds, banking, and money. Not much more than that. This is not to say she wasn't warm or good in bed; I felt as if I loved her, but I

couldn't live with her. She was not meant for me and I wasn't destined to have it so easy.

After breakfast I called Gale; she urged me to stop by as she had some important information pertaining to a woman I had been lusting after for some time. Gale and I had an agreement—as long as there was a desire for love (or hate) between us, we could lust after and fuck whomever we pleased. She professed that one day we would get a place together, leave the troubles of the world behind, and live a debauched lifestyle in a pseudo-Utopian society where she and I would be the ruling class. Fucking, screwing, blowing it out; lazing around ignoring the roar of the ocean as it climaxed, the rush of passion, and the indifference of the city. To be away, how about that, Ninety-Nine? If only you could exit my dreams and be with me in this world. We could take long walks by the sea, looking at the water, seeing our lives washing onto the shore, strolling to your house on the beach, its peach facade a haze in the mist. In your bedroom we would lie naked together and create the most magnificent display of gritty passion and divine gentleness two people ever made, and sleep in dreams where we wake as one.

Gale said that I should stop by as soon as possible, but before that I would wander around the city. Gale would be there later, and if she's upset about my late arrival, I'd work it out somehow. Later, I got off the train downtown; hordes of working class people and tourists impeded my steady stride.

A flirtation distracts me. Our eyes meet on the street, in ramshackle bookstores, dimly lit afternoon clubs, and chess cafes, but I don't keep my gaze locked. She vies for my attention; she finds me attractive in some way—perhaps I remind her of someone. There is a glow of desire behind her eyes. I don't look at her; my eyes scan the row of books on the shelf. She is disappointed that I will not give myself freely. I

attempt to resume our game but have lost her—I have gotten interested too late—the dinner’s cold and being scraped from my plate, although I have not touched it. She glares angrily at me; I have insulted her. She is trying to see through me, analyzing my being, hating me for what I am and what I represent. She knows what I’m about—do the remnants of my debauched life, my feelings toward Gale and others of her kind, show in the creases of my face? Does the sin show itself in my eyes? If she or any other stranger looks at me, can they read every experience, every ordeal I’d ever been through? I look at her and see into her dark soul, how manipulative and bitchy she can be—typical of the people living in the grey depths of the city. So full of distrust, so much hatred. . .yes it does show on the face. She tries to figure me out; I’m trying to see if she wants to either love me or string me up by my balls—if she plays like she would never want it from me, or desires to possess me. I hold back; I curtain the window to my soul, but she tries to see through. Can she get a glimpse of what I’ve been doing to Gale and her friends? Does she have a clear picture of the type of life I lead? Does it have an affect upon her? She continues to casually look at me; I am beginning to read her thoughts. I feel as if I’ve known her a hundred thousand years and we’ve made love countless times in countless places in the vast world—she is forever and I want to worship her.

I pass through life seeing the landscape wistfully streaming by as I drive. I have direction, but am aimless; I have a destination, but am unsure of the roadways. I have the ultimate knowledge of the soul, but have lost the reason of the concepts. I have become dumb, mute, with no idea of where I am or what I will become. And there she is, a woman who breaks through the ennui, having me notice her; she materializes on the seat next to me and talks while the miles click, riding with me on the way to a peaceful understanding of myself. I see her standing

on the side of the road, her thumb hooked; I try to stop but the brakes won't operate. The car continues down the gloomy road, its inertia unbroken. I can barely see her through the rear window; her image is fading, she is gone. The game is exhausted.

I'm walking down Powell Street and I see Jay in a bookstore—he is browsing a book by Norman Mailer. It has been several months since we have spoken, when we lived in the same college dorm. It was there that I discovered we were a lot alike. Jay is an artist, photography mostly—his nude black and white stills have netted him several foundation grants. Nevertheless, despite his commercial success, he and I still have the same viewpoint on many subjects—we agree humanity is a sham.

We wander around the shelves and he offers to buy me a drink. We stop in a small bar on Ellis; it is the middle of the afternoon and the place nearly empty. He is visibly tired; he strokes his thin black hair and gazes off.

“Had two women last night.”

I take a sip from my drink—White Russian, heavy on the Kahlua.

“Down in the dorms.”

“You still hang out there?” I watch two men sitting close together at the end of the bar.

“Sometimes, when they let me in.”

Both Jay and I were thrown out of the dorms for a number of reasons. Mostly because of the noise and the people who filed in and out of our rooms at all hours of the day and night. Jay believed that a girl named Stacey got him tossed out.

“She was an anal-retentive bitch.” He said.

“I think it was more because you fucked her and told her boyfriend.”

“Somebody had to snap her out of her fantasy world. Besides, he was an asshole.”

I laughed. “So, what about these women?”

“You should have met these chicks,” he said. “They had a futon; you know, those things are great to fuck on. A little music, some whiskey and sodas; soon, I was making out with one and before I knew it, we were all at it.”

I thought about a couple nights before with Colin and Gale.

“One of them was my girlfriend, did I mention that? No? Well, she seemed to be a little nervous at first about her friend being there and all, but she got over it. It was an interesting experience.”

I smile and take a long gulp of my drink, nearly finishing it.

“Didn’t get to sleep until four-thirty. Had to be at class at seven. That’s the last time I’m taking an early class. Now, I’m supposed to meet the girlfriend down here. I’m so fucking tired.” He rubbed his eyes. “How have you been doing? You still writing?”

“Yeah. It’s going okay.” I lit a cigarette, offering him one. He took it.

“You seem cheerful and bright, what the hell are you so happy about?”

“I’m more content than happy.”

“Why?” He turned on the stool and smiled slyly. “You’ve been fucking again. I know that shit-eating look you get on your face. What is it with you? Every time I see you, you’ve just been fucking. That’s you, Chris, always getting it.”

“Not really.”

He smirked. “Don’t be smug. I hate it when you’re smug. So what happened? How was she?”

“They.”

“More than one? Now I am impressed.”

I told him of the other night; he was amused and took long drags on his cigarette. Exhaling slowly, he became enraptured by my story of Colin and how he and I shared Gale.

For the past six months, in fact since the day I met her, Gale had been telling me of a fantasy she had about fucking two men. The night before last, when she said she wanted to go visit Colin since his girlfriend wouldn't be home, I had a pretty good idea of what was going to happen. As Gale undressed in front of us, I made no motion of resistance.

After he dimmed the lights, she took me in her mouth and he stroked himself. (I remember Gale telling me he had an infatuation with masturbation.) After getting himself excited, he spread her legs apart and lapped at her. I lay back, stacking the pillows under my shoulders so I could watch; Gale panted while I was in her mouth, the sound muffled. As she ground herself into his face, his hand reached up and he stroked me while she licked the head. He moved away from her, kissing her stomach and her breasts until he reached me. They kissed passionately, then turned to me, sharing me between their mouths. I remained relaxed; in the prevailing darkness, I was unsure who's tongue was doing what. I felt Gale take me completely in her mouth, then felt her tongue run down one side. Colin followed up the other. I couldn't see, but by the feel of the roughness of his unshaven face on my balls I knew he had swallowed me.

At first, I felt uneasy fucking her in front of him. I could feel his damn analytical gaze upon my cock as it plunged into Gale. I knew his ego was booming, that I wasn't giving her as much pleasure as could. He was still stroking himself repeating,

"Fuck her. Fuck her, dude."

In an instant I was lost in the fantasy that was unfolding all around me. I looked up at Gale and felt every sexual encounter I ever had. All the limits I had placed on my passions were now released. They flooded my senses.

Do you like feeling my cock, Gale? Do you like how I slam it into you? I could lay you as much as you can take it. We could do it for three hours straight. As we lay together afterwards smoking, my semen congealing to your breasts, the smell of sex pungent, I could climb on you and do it again. And you would never be satisfied. You could have a dozen orgasms in one night and you would still beg me to fuck you. We are so familiar, we know each other quite well; you know what to say to me, how to squeeze me with your cunt so that I might want to come—then you stop, leaving me wanting. We are so good together, we could do it in our sleep and never know our collective passions fulfilled. In the morning you could make me breakfast, the nipples of your breasts stiff in the cold, damp air of the kitchen. I could wrap my arms around you and take you from behind and we could fuck while the bacon sizzled, the oil in the pan popping fiery dots onto our skin. I want to eat you, eat in front of you, and make you as hungry as I. I want you to know the desire to feed, then give into your ravenous appetite, snatching up every morsel I leave inside you.

In the afternoon I could drive you to work in my large automobile, split your nylons and take you in the back seat. Then send you to the office with a slap on the ass, a head full of memories, and a desire to call me the minute you get near a phone.

I could be anything you need, play any role you wished. I could even be your father or your brother for that matter. I could pretend that I loved you with every ounce of my being and want to keep you safe. But then sex would be out of the question; you are so small and I so large. I might split you in two with the long bone in my penis—it might be the end of you—that bone.

You make me fear you. You are so thin, your delicate legs so fragile, your tender skin so soft—so small and thin and well-proportioned. Tell me Gale, what if, in the heat of passion, I suddenly bend you up and

break you in two? What then? It is because of this that I know I must limit myself, I must be gentle with you. I fear you.

I became tired, my member a little sore. Gale climbed off and hopped on Colin; they immediately went at it. I got up, lit a cig, and watched them in the same clinical way Colin had earlier; I did this for a minute then stopped. I lay down and watched the cherry of the cigarette glow in the dim light—the smoke highlighting their grinding silhouettes.

He didn't finish with her; he motioned her to me. I put Gale on the bed and propped myself up, thrusting deep into her. She talked of my length in this position, of my stamina, and of my performance. I wished for my orgasm to come, the skin on my cock might rub off at any moment; I concentrated on coming and pulled out, shooting my warm semen on her breasts, as I had many times before. She rubbed it into her and wrapped her hand around me. I cringed at the rawness of the skin.

Jay nods his head and looks around the bar. "Must've been some kind of night, both of us getting it and all. It's not everyday that happens," he says grudgingly. He's visibly exhausted. The two men have gone. "Have to be going. I'll see you around, since we always seem to be running into each other."

He gets up and leaves me in the bar. I stay for a moment; my mind begins to wander. I think of life, my place here, how I am now, and how I was. I look around the bar and think of the people on the streets; I see the elder people as they were young and the young as they will be old. For a split second, time is out of joint, in flux; I am a transcendental traveler on his way to the realms of nothingness. I am haunted by my future, petrified about the present, and obsessed with the past. I am caught in a void and need to find a way out, torn between my seemingly free-flowing passion and desire for life, yet concerned whether or not I

was living up to my means. A single question remained: was a stable life with Rhindy more important, or did I want a writing career, living by my own vices and perhaps existing in poverty? Despite my clear head and temporary intransigency, I found myself mute and indecisive.

Jay and I were alike in another way—we lacked focus. We could conceptualize paradise, we knew what it could be like; however, we never were able to completely remove ourselves from time and reality. So we reminisced, lived and relived times that could offer the most escape time. Maybe he was more productive than I; Jay lived in the recent past, whereas I dwelled somewhere further back.

And it was this stagnancy that had been getting me into trouble these past few weeks. Sometimes the ability to make a decision is marred by an ineffectual past—I didn't want to make the same mistakes in judgment I had so many times before. Rhindy seemed to be at the breaking point; maybe she was ready to heave me out. If she did, I would have no place to go. Well, I could've moved in with Gale—the debauched lifestyle was on the horizon; she said it would be peaceful and without incident. . . I wasn't so sure.

Nick spits on the ground as we walk. "Gale," he spits again. "I could never fuck that." He and I are walking downtown, stopping at various bookstores, record shops, antique stores, and used car lots.

"You're getting yourself into something deep. Better watch out."

Nick doesn't know the meaning of the word 'deep'. He only sees today and early tomorrow morning, devising new ways to mooch more money off mom and dad so he can buy food and gasoline. 'Deep' to Nick is how many women he has fucked, realizing day to day he's fucked more than he originally thought. It is a brilliant revelation I have the special privilege of hearing occasionally, usually when we're eating, or talking cars and what had been going on in past weekends. He doesn't offer much real advice, just jumbled tales of fucking and spending his

parents' money. I find the noise of the traffic, the stink of the buses, and the people walking on Polk far more interesting than our conversation.

I watch the people as they walk; I note their distinctive San Francisco looks in their faces and in their manner of dress. If there is one redeeming aspect of SF, it's the extreme diversity of its residents. But through all the diversity, I can't find comfort. I begin to walk hunched over, emulating the expressions of people dressed strangely, people purposely making themselves ugly with rat's nest hair, tie-dye shirts, pants, hats, shoes, and the occasional barber pole stockings. A couple are wearing matching glasses reminiscent of Buddy Holly. I think of talking to some, maybe ask directions to somewhere, but they speak in vague metaphors like, "what exactly do you mean by direction?", or "the gods will direct you in your quest for MUNI", and so forth. I decide not to speak to strange people ever again.

Back on Polk. Nick is lolling his head to one side and creasing his brow; he's sensing my cynical thoughts. With every fiber of my being disgusted, I decide that life in San Francisco is pretty cheap. Cheap housing, cheap food at inflated prices, and no public toilets. Cheap whores prowling the bowels of Leavenworth and worst of all, cheap friends. Not a damn fragment of richness anywhere. . .angels clinging desperately to the darkness. I want to tell Nick that we are nothing, stewing on the bile of lost hopes. I want to slap his wide face and say, "Wake up, asshole, this is fantasy you're talking about, your life is not that rewarding! Quit fucking smiling all the time!" I was massaging my pocket of pus and wanted to spray it on anybody who was near.

Pulling myself out of my head, I look at the small rooms above the stores. Such small, quaint little apartments, filled with people living life the way they desire, believing in themselves and their worlds. I feel as if their faith overshadows mine, it is awesome; I have so little faith right now. I look to my friends for support. Nothing. I look to

girlfriends, fucks, lusts, acquaintances, and then whores. No luck. I ask people on the street; they glance at me oddly in their tolerant Bay Area way and keep on walking. Nick, looking very confused, pulls me along, trying to shut me up. As soon as I start on my rampage, I stop. In a flash, I forget about the thoughts I was dwelling on, deciding it really didn't matter in the end. The only thing that did matter was the knowledge that the dichotomy between my thoughts and my actions, between my need for companionship and the result of knowing I was alone, would tear me asunder.

I never went to Gale's; instead, Nick and I went out driving. We stopped for pizza and I talked anxiously about my world and how it was going through so many changes. Rhindy wanted me the hell out; Gale wanted me in. Neither proposal sounded appetizing. I let myself drown in my seemingly enormous problems. I craved some semblance of stability; I fed on fragments of memory, hoping as I relived each that I would attain balance. As I looked around the restaurant, I spotted someone I thought I knew. I found I didn't know her; she reminded me of someone else—a woman I knew last summer.

Carol lived in a run-down apartment building on Leavenworth called The Louard. It was unbelievably hot that summer; the heat scorched the skin and smog choked the senses. It was a time when both bums and dogs could be seen urinating in the same alleyways. A time when Carol called, urging me to come down and help her with her art. I'd go over, inspect her watercolors, and immerse myself in supernal expression.

When I came in, I'd find her painting nude. She said the heat made her crazy; she had all the windows open, but the air was deathly still. A light haze hung about the sills; the paint was chipped and cracked and yellowed. She sat facing the window, watching the city breathe, brush vigorously stroking paper. She was beautiful from the back, the muscles

in her arm flexing as she painted, her body a plethora of smooth curves and angles.

We painted a lot of interesting pictures—nothing that could be either deciphered or appreciated, but it was art nonetheless. We'd paint then fuck, then fuck and paint. She'd cried after we'd finished, the painting hadn't come out as she hoped. It wasn't art to her, just a hastily slapped together picture of misconstrued emotions. She wanted "a memory conceived in the heat of passion". I couldn't console her—she wanted to be left alone. I lay on the floor naked, my flaccid cock leaning to one side, and smoked. She sobbed near the window, holding the painting to the hazy sunlight, her tears falling to the paper. The smoke hung heavy in the air.

Nick kept talking while he ate, I didn't think he'd heard a damn thing I said. He interrupted me and was telling me about his latest. It had something to do with a mansion, a good looking woman, and James Bond. I wasn't interested and shut him off.

Chapter 2

Several months later, all those changes I thought would sweep through my life had passed me by. Rhindy and I were still together, Gale was on vacation in Arizona, and I hadn't seen Nick in weeks. For some reason, Rhindy suddenly seemed to value our relationship more and decided we should spend every waking moment together. She started introducing me to people she worked with. We socialized often; I fell into her ideas, stopped fucking other women, and was exclusive in my time with her. I developed a profound lack of interest in sex. I was scaring myself; was this what married life was like? Would I fall and stifle my urge to be creative? Would I forget Ninety-Nine ever existed?

I started hanging out with more stable people—people like Murray and Jackie. Murray was an old school friend; we usually hung out when I was in one of my more pleasant moods. He was another creative type,

bent on filming. He was good at his art and knew what he was doing, but as far as his story lines for his movies were concerned, they were shit—I guess we all have our faults. But he tries and that's all that really matters. The true artist works and suffers hard, and pits his vices against his talent in the fatalistic belief that his vices enhance his artistic prowess. Murray liked to drink. Whenever we would go bar hopping around the city, he would chastise me for not having drunk as much as he. He would babble on and on about things, but he never talked about sex or women; he was fiercely committed to Jackie. He and I had a roundabout way of discussing things. Unless we were drunk, we talked very little of the meaningful things in life. I could never talk to him like I could with Jay or Nick. Murray and I had our own rapport which, in the long run, was stilted and ductile.

Murray always tells me how much he loves Jackie, especially when I try to tell him about the hell I'm going through with Rhindy. Murray says he has it perfect; Jackie takes good care of him. She is an extension of his mother. A man can't help but love his mother; she weaned him from his earliest days, read him stories, taught him to speak, to walk, to write, so it's not surprising when a man reaches the age of marriage that he tries to find a woman who is most like his mother. He wants a mate who'll wait on him hand and foot, make him dinner, wash his clothes, comb his hair, tell him how good he's been, patronize him, and so on and so forth. Yes, Murray loved Jackie. She was an average Swiss woman—if there is such a thing—quiet and astute with a bellyful of pride. She and I didn't get along; we were far too much alike, our cultural differences too great.

The four of us would go out together—go to movies, dinners, dancing, drinking. It must've looked very cute—two couples ogling over each other, looking like they were in love. In our private conversations, Murray spoke of the four of us as being the happiest people on earth.

We were so content with the security of our situations, how could either he or I go wrong with what we had? He made an allusion to the Flintstones; I didn't feel compelled to ask him which couple was which.

There were dinners at each other's houses, the coffee afterward, the poker nights—all the things I remember seeing my parents and their married friends doing when I was young. I felt myself aging rapidly, my desire as a writer ebbing away. Sure, there were writers who were married, but who's to say what they were like before they became successful. I've heard so many conflicting reports, but the impression I got was that they were hell to live with. I didn't want to imitate anybody in particular, I just wanted to be proud of myself. I wanted to feel like I had done something with my life.

All that stable stuff started to get to my brain. I became uneasy with my new environment; my imagination was stagnating. I needed to write something, something I could hold up and scream, "Hey! This is mine and I did it! I made it over the threshold!". Gale returned from her trip about that time, and I started calling her again after a three-month interim. We went out to dinner and talked about the debauched things we had done to date and how much she had missed them. I started feeling better, feeling my nature coming back to me, the true nature that molded me as the writer I imagined myself to be. For the first time in a month, sitting and talking with Gale, I was at peace. This was the way my world needed to function and there was nothing I could do to alter that fact.

Murray and I frequently hung out on days and nights when I found myself with nothing to do; we'd play pool in the expensive apartment complex he and Jackie recently moved into. And every time we'd play, I would have a burning urge to tell him about Gale and how she had seduced me. He had only met Gale twice, but from those happenstance meetings, he must have had a pretty good idea about

her. I had suppressed telling him about her, keeping the lurid affair to myself, but one day my urge to confess was far too strong.

“What would be your reaction if I told you I was having an affair?”

Murray let the cue slide between his fingers and struck the ball. “I wouldn’t believe you.”

“What if I told you it was someone you knew?”

He poised for another shot. “What are you getting at?”

“Nothing, nothing. I was just curious.”

He shot a look at me and missed. “This is odd, why are you talking about affairs? You and Rhindy not doing well?”

“No, no, we’re doing fine.”

“Okay, what are you trying to tell me?”

“I don’t know.”

“You don’t know?”

“No.”

“What?!!”

“Let’s just say I’m bearing my soul to you. Let’s say I have a guilty conscience.”

“Okay, shoot.”

I got up and steadied myself over the table. “Nine ball, corner pocket.”

He eyed the table carefully. “Which corner?”

I glared at him over my shoulder. “Right.”

“Okay.”

“Shit, I missed.”

“We’ve been playing pretty badly all night, must be the beer.”

I peered into the grocery bag we had brought in with us. “I knew we didn’t get enough.”

“Guess not. So what’s this business about affairs, Chris?”

“You really want to know?” I wasn’t sure now if I wanted to tell him. I had done a good job of whetting his appetite for gossip, but now I was thinking of Rhindy. Murray would tell Jackie, Jackie would tell Rhindy, and I would catch shit. Perhaps I shouldn’t have started seeing Gale again.

“Yes, I want to know.”

“Shoot.” He went to the table and leaned over for a shot. “Tell me Murray, do you find sex with Jackie satisfying?”

He stood up not attempting a shot. “All right, dude, what are you trying to say?”

I paced the small room. “Okay, picture this. Let’s say you meet a woman whom you find attractive, so you want to sleep with her, but you already have a girlfriend so you feel you can’t.”

“Yeah. . .”

“But let’s also say you have no guilt, no morals, and you sleep with her anyway. What do you think?”

“Think about what?”

“What’s your reaction?”

“Sounds sleazy.”

“Sleazy?”

“Sleazy.”

“What the hell do you know, Murray?”

He rubbed his forehead. “Are you trying to tell me that you’re having an affair?”

“In a roundabout way.”

“With who?”

“I can’t tell you, you’d blab.”

“Chris, man, dude, shit. I won’t blab. Don’t you trust me?”

“In some ways, yes, in others, no. I have this feeling you won’t intentionally blab. It’ll just slip out.”

“No it won’t.”

“Okay then, let’s just finish this game.”

Our game didn’t last much longer; both of us were doing pretty lousy. The fourteen year-old bimbo who came in earlier could’ve kicked our sorry asses—if we hadn’t thrown her out. I was now regretting having told Murray anything; I knew he was going to say something. At least with Nick, despite his blundering, he still managed to keep a tight lip. Maybe that’s why Nick and I got along so well.

Sex can feel like a damn dirty thing, but we all have to do it sometime. I liked to compare it to the other things I was prone to do during the course of the day—things like eating, sleeping, drinking, pissing, farting, shitting—it was something you did either out of habit or necessity. I put fucking toward the top of the list, right after eating and sleeping. I didn’t think too much of the term ‘affair’ either. It’s such a republican, WASP sort of word, laden with flat meaning. I preferred to call our encounters the ‘fuck sessions’. The word ‘fuck’ was far more caustic and tempestuous than ‘affair’. It worked better at getting the point across. Life went on.

I’m tired of looking out into the world, seeing it as night approaches. It makes me think of the long walks downtown to try to calm myself when the girlfriend decided to take her frustrations out on me. I hate the city, humanity and all. Rhindy’s friends think I’m an idiot, her house husband who doesn’t do a damn thing but sit in front of his fucking typewriter and hang out with his friends. Fucking assholes, all of them.

Murray and I went back to his apartment and he made White Russians. We sat and resumed our conversation about affairs.

“You can’t say a damn thing to anybody, Murray, not a damn word.”

“Sure.”

I sipped at my drink. “It’s Gale. . .and Azlya.”

“Gale and Azlya?”

“Well, . . . Azlya was three months ago, but I still fuck Gale.”

He looked at the floor. “I know Gale, but who’s Azlya?”

“From our afternoon writing class.”

“Oh yeah, yeah. Both of them?”

“Yep.”

“At the same time?”

“So to speak.”

“Simultaneously?”

“The same day.”

“Seriously, you’re really doing Gale?”

It became painfully obvious that Murray couldn’t handle my confession. He was falling back into adolescence, becoming fourteen all over again when he first heard his friend say he had just kissed Suzy-Q. I regretted having told him anything. I knew I had made a mistake.

“So, how was it?”

“How was what?”

“The sex.”

“All right.” He was sinking even further; now he was twelve and regressing faster than I could keep up. I wasn’t about to give him any gory details, just telling him about it in the first place was bad enough. If there was one thing I had learned about the experience with Murray, it was never to fall prey to telling your uncertain friends about your naughty life and how corrupt it is.

Murray kept his mouth shut and never mentioned our discussion about the affair. I imagined him quivering with excitement at the prospect that he actually knew someone who was having an affair. If he didn’t tell Jackie outright, he would tell some of his friends, who in turn would tell others—eventually it would get to Rhindy. I didn’t worry about it and I really didn’t care.

I tried to sit and relax a moment from writing, but Rhindy tells me the news of the week. Murray and Jackie were going to get married by the middle of summer. He was a tired man, sick of life running the same course—he thought of eating, digesting the same sandwich, not noticing what was dressing it, who had made it, or how long it had been sitting on his plate. He wanted to scream out and wake himself up from his dream. I was screaming, too, but not for Murray.

At their apartment, they're sitting close to each other on a black Naugahyde couch bought on credit from Sears. We're lazing around watching television. I find the scene particularly fascinating; as I watch TV, I keep an eye on them. They appear happy. Murray, who wouldn't be caught dead doting on her was now doing so; he said kind words, hugged her affectionately, and whispered in her ear. The TV offered a movie rerun. I enjoyed watching Murray. He was so tender, never once raising his voice in Rhindy's and my presence.

During the course of the evening, Rhindy snuggled next to me, trying to emulate our hosts. My stomach was uneasy; I wasn't sure if it was because of the undercooked steak I devoured, watching Jackie and Murray kiss each other, or Rhindy's wishing we could be the same. I wouldn't doubt that if we weren't there they would be making love right there on that couch. I fidgeted in my seat. If they had started, I wouldn't have stopped them. I would have situated myself on the floor for a better view and said something sarcastic like, "It's not like I haven't seen it before."

Occasionally, I got a silent thrill out of watching people writhe together—Murray in his Aryan thinness, Jackie in her Swiss plumpness. I had to admit the thought of those two fucking turned me off, but at least it was real—without facades. Most beady-eyed, repressed people would hide their sexuality and when the time was right in their minds to fuck, they would let it loose all at once where inevitably it would

seem trivial and ill-timed. Then they would be rejected and the cycle began anew. I despised people who held back, could never express themselves fully at a moment's notice. In the shadows of their failure, they were consumed with making others pay for their impotence, not accepting the fault as their own. They would take their frustration out on any number or variety of people. They would beat their wives and girlfriends because they couldn't perform—the blood in their veins ice, compassion and desire lost. And yet it continues; the cycle gets more vicious, more destructive, and maybe they should dump their little Hondas, Porsches, or whatever, sell their paper-box apartments or houses, strip themselves bare, and begin afresh. That is the only way to absolve the self from the ills of modern society. I had faith in Murray; he didn't follow the mainstream, and that's what makes him an artist. An artist takes the gristle and gruel society throws at him and makes it into the most fabulous feast anyone has ever witnessed. I had faith in Murray as an artist; I hoped it was not in vain.

My faith, like destiny, carries me down a road where my dreams are to be born and where they are to die while approaching the ineffable.

Chapter 3

My night with Murray left a bitter taste in my mouth for several days. I discovered that questioning what it meant to be an artist led to the conclusion that the answer was multifarious; yet the answer was simple. Practicing one's art for the sole enjoyment of doing so regardless of outcome, was the only direction I could lead myself in. I wanted to experience anything and everything that increased the probability of an artist's life, that perhaps one day I could live as an artist, without the constraints that bound me to my lethargic state. To accomplish my newfound goal, I took long walks downtown gazing up at the buildings. I tried to see them in a different perspective; a

perspective which, as it washed over me, illuminated parts of my mind I had not known ever existed.

The buildings appeared as ladders, one tier being impeccably greater than the last; people living, working, dining, dancing, shitting, and fucking, bemusing themselves within the plasticine hierarchy of floors. Each bite of food, each taste of sex more delectable as they rocketed skyward; those on the single digit floors saw a tiresome, belaboring existence—nothing edifying—while others 10, 20, 30 ate in polite bites and spoke so serenely and wistfully that those below them wouldn't be able to construe their whisperings as conversation at all. But I could. I knew the game, I recognized the ladder, the tiers; the reach toward perfection in the sky. I saw everything and knew nothing and I smiled when those on the 42nd floor would look out from behind their glass cages to the world they could see but never touch for fear of being cast out from the glimmering, chrome tower.

I wasn't much afraid of being cast out, I always had been and was quite used to the idea of being a pariah. This does not mean I didn't relish in my defeat, on the contrary, I gained strength when those of high class and monetary esteem would sneer down their long noses at me. I glowed when shunned by people in shimmery and expensive suits and shirts and shoes which hung upon their meager frames like mannequins in store windows on Market Street. I pitied them, the poor fools; I pitied their money and their esteem—they knew not life and love and sex and wanderlust as I; these desires were pure fabrication in their hollow eyes. They knew not truth but wholly devoured the facade their society had constructed for their benefit. And I did laugh. I belly-rolled.

Now here's one. One, born as I, in low social standing, in polished shoes and neatly groomed hair. He gazed blankly, disconcertedly down the street rushing by yelling into a cellular phone. He thinks mightily

of himself although he's only been on the job for two months and only got his prestigious phone the week before—when his employer on the 59th floor felt he was worth it. He has an office on the 4th floor, but he dreams of rising higher and higher where the air gets thinner and thinner and his head swells so large, he won't be able to pick it up from his desk one day. For now, though, he believes he's on the rise. He has alienated all his old friends and he has estranged his family; he has even cast his wife aside. She, especially so, was not worth the effort. Anything that even remotely was depicted as a burden was discarded by him—especially monetary anchors which, he thought, would drag him down from his leaden throne. By eliminating those things that might hinder him, he thinks he will rise unabashed to the class he would like to see himself in. His greed, which at first only pricked his skin, now festers; it spews bile and filth, seeping into every aspect of his being.

It has ensnared him, he tries to become something he's incapable of; he can't perform, he can't cope. He tries to destroy those who try to love him; he's freed a bitter poison that has already run its course—no antidote. The illness has rooted itself, he is blind; his glass office rising higher and higher: 20, 37, 48, 52, 63—nearly to the roof. The air is getting thinner and thinner, his view of the world smaller and smaller. He appears as a facsimile of God himself, his glory a testament to his puerile genius. Then, peering down upon his creation, he throws himself over the railing, giving himself back to the street from whence he began—from which the disillusionment first gripped him with its sinewy talons.

Gale phoned one humid afternoon inviting me down to her parents' house. Since they were both away at work, she promised we could spend some time together. I had to go to class, but since I never much went anyway, spending the day away from the university seemed a

much better proposal than being mired in the pedantic psychobabble of my literature and physics classes.

When I knocked on Gale's bedroom window and she let me in, we cut to the chase. Our mutual greetings were followed by grunts and groans and it was only when I was coming did she say anything articulate.

"God, Jesus. When will it stop?"

I had completely soaked her, the semen running down the sides of her large breasts, seeping into her sheets.

As we lay together, she stared longingly at me.

"We should take a vacation together."

I tugged on my flaccid penis, squeezing out drops of come. "Like where?"

"Somewhere up the coast, up north. Mendicino county, maybe. Fort Bragg."

"Never been there."

"I went there once with my ex. But I think I'd have more fun with you."

I had met Gale's ex twice. He wasn't much to look at: long hair, unshaven, played in a band, slurred as he spoke, bad breath. Of course she would have a better time with me—I was none of those things. I was entirely dissimilar to any other boyfriend she ever had.

"Probably." I continued tugging at myself. She watched me.

"Didn't you get enough? God, I've never seen anyone come as much as you did."

I looked at her sideways. "Fort Bragg, huh? The coast sounds nice."

"And you could get away from Rhindy for a weekend."

Which was probably the most tempting aspect of the whole idea. Lately I've been feeling burdened living with her, listening her rant and rave about stocks and bonds and CD accounts. A trip to a serene place, a place at the edge of the world sounded like the perfect thing

right now. And as I lay next to Gale, her head on my shoulder, my appetite sated, I knew we would have a good time. A time that would portend events soon to come.

I told Rhindy I was going to stay the weekend with my parents in the valley. With overnight bag in hand and as she kissed me, I felt evil about having lied. And it felt good.

Saturday morning, Gale and I piled our few belongings into her station wagon and headed north. Of whatever consequence the trip had provided, the time passed without installment of memory or provocation. Not even the sex or the evening spent in the Skunk Motel could justify recollecting anything worthy of retrospect in future times.

It was early in March when Gale asked me to move in with her. She went about asking me in a less than friendly way; I shouldn't have been surprised at her approach, in fact, it was as I would have expected. I spent the remainder of the evening sulking.

"Now, Chris, don't depress me by saying you wouldn't like to live with me. You're always telling me your life with Rhindy is so hellish, and if what you have been saying is the truth and not a Capricorn lie, then it should be an easy decision."

An easy decision? Hey look, living with one woman and tolerating her every mannerism is bad enough to have to deal with—but another?! And Gale at that? Nick spit on the ground at the mention of her name; I came on her chest.

"I don't know, Gale."

"Why don't you know? There must be a reason."

She was getting mad. There were times when we jokingly talked about living together and how it would be, but I never once took it seriously. How am I supposed to? This is Gale, for Chrissake—Gale

and her claustrophobic paranoia, generously sprinkled with pedantic psychobabble. If she wasn't on her medication, she was freaking out, throwing things and spewing vague, disjointed phrases like an imbecile, embarrassing me if I was with her. I could already feel the accusatory glances—it sure wasn't my fault she had these problems; I didn't drive her to them!

I seem, lately, to be running into a lot of types who have deep-seated problems. During one of my college classes—a junior literature class—I found myself sitting next to a woman who broke down in the middle of reading a Byron passage. She had violet hair, a phosphorescent floral print dress, barber-pole stockings, and polished combat boots. Initially, as was my habit, I had ambled in and picked a chair near the back of the room where I was sure I wouldn't be bothered. She came in and sat next to me; I said nothing to her. On this particular day, the professor had us choose our favorite authors and read selected passages from their works. I picked something from Dylan Thomas, she chose Byron's "When We Two Parted". Before she had a chance to read it to the class, she poured over it, murmuring to herself.

"It's me, it's just like my life."

She said this over and over again, progressively louder each time. She looked at me, pointed to the text, and again repeated herself. Then she began to cry, sobbing quietly, then loudly. I shifted in my chair; soon people would notice and wonder what I had done to upset her so. All at once she got up and left the room without so much as a word. The class stopped; they all watched her leave, and as the door shut behind her, they turned their confused looks to me. I swallowed hard and shrugged my shoulders. She didn't come back in time to hear me read Thomas. She was young, impressionable, naive, and corruptible—an idealistic fantasy woman, but I wouldn't have anything to do with her.

"Chris? Chris? Are you listening to me? I seem to have lost you."

I was staring out the window, watching the scenery pass by. Gale and I were on our way to a 7-11; she had a craving for gum and cigarettes, and I for beer.

“I need to know if you want to get away from Rhindy or not. You’ve said you want the space to write, and I need a roommate. I never could afford to live on my own. We’re friends and I think we should help each other.”

She went into the store; I stayed in the car, giving up on the idea of having any alcohol. I watched as she paced through the aisles of junk food, scooping up a handful of 5-cent gum. I needed a cigarette. We drove off.

“We can help each other, huh?” I said to her. I took a deep inhale and felt the smoke burn my lungs; I relaxed, knowing I was killing myself. It was ironic that I should be consumed at this moment with killing myself when I knew damn well, one way or the other, I would be moving in with Gale. “I remember reading somewhere that friends shouldn’t move in together, they say it ruins the relationship.”

“There you go again, so fuckin’ pessimistic, fuck.” She hit the steering wheel.

“No, just being realistic.”

“If you don’t want to move in with me then just say so.”

“I don’t know.”

“Well, you’d better find out real soon.”

We kept driving; she got onto the freeway. I glanced at my watch and noticed it was nine-thirty.

“Where are we going?”

“I thought we’d go see the ‘lose’ band.”

Colin and the boys, how fun. And there was that word again, “lose”. To Gale, everything was “lose”. Things found themselves a new modifier—“lose”. “Lose” bands, “lose” cars, “lose” San Mateo. I wasn’t

in this business of life to “lose” out on things; I didn’t want to see Colin and the band, but Gale promised earlier that Valerie, this woman I had been lusting over, would be there. If it weren’t for the prospect of this small, thin, dark-haired woman hiding in the recesses of a warehouse in San Carlos, I wouldn’t even dream of venturing all that way down there to see the “lose” band.

“I’m trying to set you up with her, don’t be such a dick.” Gale told me. Well, I hoped she was telling the truth and not trying to smoke me. All this faith in Gale and the “loses” couldn’t be unsolicited, and I hoped it was not in vain—as with Murray.

A long drive into the mountains, under the tall pines; the smell of jasmine tickling my nostrils, the rush of the wind through my hair. The top of the old black Buick is down, the sun is shining brightly on my shoulders, and the radio is playing some old song of a time long gone, but it doesn’t feel like it. I could be in any time, the fifties, sixties, nineties—timelessness surrounds the car and unfolds as I travel down the road. With every mile that clicks on the odometer, a smile that cannot be resisted creases the face; a smile that is full, a tranquillity that is whole, a peace that is enveloping. You know you could never find such rest anywhere but here, in the trees, in the forest; it is still and vibrating with life—teeming with raw energy. A diversion from the real world, a break from reality; we all need it once in awhile else we’ll go insane; things will snap in the brain and all of a sudden, you’re loony. The quiescent pines, the odor of their pungent sap keeps your senses clear; the mountain tops and field grasses, the bright sun, the beauty of nature is therapeutic, I’d be there for all time if it weren’t for reality—or Ninety-Nine. Maybe I am loony; maybe I dwell too much on escape, wanting to spend every possible moment away from my destined existence, trapped in a city I consider horrid—peopled with sad-faced occupants while the precise act of nothing is the rule

of the day. Somebody wrote that escapism is bad; could it be true? I say no, to escape is to have a vacation in the mind—better to escape temporarily than run away entirely.

I didn't know if Gale thought about escaping as I did; she liked to run away, hoping never to come back or see anyone associated with the old world she left behind. In fact, since she wanted me to come live with her, she plotted to have me run away with her. She had no toleration or patience, she couldn't accept anything that strayed from her plan, and she could never live alone. I was a vehicle, as she saw it, to her new happiness. I suppose I should have been flattered to be the first person in her new world, but I couldn't picture it that way; I only felt distress.

"If you don't want to move in with me then just say so." I heard her voice echo in my head. I knew I should make up my mind, say no, and be true to myself and her so as not to make a mistake we'd feel bad about in the future. I wanted to tell her I don't want to live with her because I know it'll ruin our friendship and we'll end up hating each other—permanently scarred by the experience for the rest of our lives. On the other hand, I wouldn't mind sharing a place away from San Francisco where I could get a better view of my life and how I'm going to go about fulfilling my presupposed destiny. I found myself in a corner, partitioned in, with no place to go but scale the grey plaster walls, claw at them until my fingers bleed. I collapse and see the floor as my face strikes it.

I'm on a bus in the late afternoon riding it to wherever it will take me; the coach is crowded. A kid sits, earphones jammed into his ears, listening to some indecipherable music; a couple sit next to him, their conversation is light. She is fixing her make-up, using a compact mirror; he is holding a bag of groceries. He peers into the bag, shuffles the contents, and starts to pull out a bag of Oreos. She glares at him

out the corner of her eye and smacks the hand holding the cookies; he quickly drops them back into the bag, stiffens his back, and stares across the bus. I turn and look to the back; faceless people aim their heads to the windows as if to peer out, but with empty eyes. I continue panning my vision to the other side of the coach. A young girl just having reached puberty has discovered the wonders of make-up and has drawn a thin line of electric blue eyeliner above her cheek. I look at her for a second; our glances touch. I look away and to the front; my stop is coming up soon and wait at the door. Anxiety is raging in my heart.

She gets up, throws her make-up bag over her shoulder, and stands close to me. I feel her hand in the small of my back. I start to quiver. I am innocent, naive, feeling the caresses of another for the first time. I don't look at her; I feel dirty, caked with putrid desire, as if all the sins of my life are clinging to my young flesh. I shudder and try to wrench away. She moves close and whispers in my ear.

“Will you love me?”

I swallow hard; I am voiceless, emotionless, constrained. Speechless, I am freezing, turning to ice. The others pull their coats in close to try to keep some of their heat for themselves, but I quickly steal it. The people stiffen, frost over—it snows. She reels back and laughs; she grabs my waist and pulls me to her. She whispers again.

“I want you.”

I melt. I watch her get off the bus; not once does she look back at me. I gaze out the open door as she walks; her eyes remain forward, not straying once toward me.

Many stops later, I stumble off the bus and to the apartment. I shut the door and put my back to it, letting out a long sigh. In the living room, I flipped on the TV and plopped down on the couch. I let the glare of an idiotic game show sedate me. They say people relax to TV; I wanted to find out if it was true or not.

A commercial showing two housewives raving about Tide came on; I became disgusted, sat up like a shot, and turned off the TV. I turned on the radio and wandered around the apartment; the worn, unpolished hardwood floor creaked under my footsteps, emanating a magnanimous echoing sound. I wondered if the woman living next door could hear me walking around, since the noises were amplified. On certain nights, when I was quietly lying on the couch, I could hear her next door, through the wall, bouncing on the bed. She'd giggle, moan, and bounce. I wondered what the hell she was doing—was she throwing herself on the bed having a good time, fucking, or what? Maybe lodging her head in the ceiling for a thrill? On other nights I could hear her with her boyfriend. There were loud, reverberating fucking sounds, low moans from a deep pit, the squeak of bed springs, the rush of “ahhs” and “oohs” and screams of passion. Must be an exciting life going on in there bouncing and all. Maybe it alleviated stress to bounce on the bed and giggle. Tried it myself once; didn't do that much for me. Rhindy looked perplexingly at me and told me to quit it.

And that set my mind thinking. If it was that easy for me to hear, was it the same for her? Could she hear Rhindy and I making the bed squeak? I wouldn't doubt it, our bed was notorious for making screeching metallic noises; if she could hear us, she probably got an earful of the pornography we frequently rented. The “ahhs” and “oohs” and “fuck me's” in that were far more intense than I heard coming from her place. I imagine she thought us sick—but at least I didn't bounce on the bed, hoping to drive my skull into the ceiling.

I laughed at myself and went to the kitchen for something to eat. The fridge was still empty; Rhindy had not yet gone shopping. I opted for a tin of uncooked oatmeal; I shoveled it down my throat dry. As I turned to go back into the living room, I saw a note tacked to the fridge. I sat on the couch and read it.

“I hope you find time to clean the apartment today, it’s REALLY a fucking mess, please DO something about it. I don’t want to see it like this when I get home. I’m also going to stop by the store on the way home. Call me and tell me what you want.

Love,

Rhindy"

I tried swallowing a spoonful of oatmeal. My mouth was too dry; I went to the kitchen for some water. The place wasn’t that much of a mess; there were dishes stacked in the sink, bits of dried food on the floor, a little dirt here and there, a few piles of clothes in the living room—yeah, it was a little disheveled, but I was far too busy to spend time doing menial shit like that. I kept my own space clean—where I worked at my desk and the bed where I slept some of the time. I gulped the water down, looked at the note, crumpled it, and threw it into the can. Back at the couch, I lay down and listened to the radio.

Rhindy pisses me off sometimes. She’s constantly complaining about one thing or another—about how messed the place is, my attitude about it, and how I don’t do anything. She’ll come home tonight, see that nothing has been done, and commence the evening’s activity of bitching at me. I just wasn’t enough for her, not the man she wanted to share a living space with. But there were times when she made me feel like I was doing everything perfectly; Rhindy had that ability to shift her moods and either make you feel like total shit or the best thing in the world all in the span of a few minutes. And she called me insane.

Take for instance, our sex life. One would think that after going out for nearly three years, living together and all, the sex would be fairly routine, bland, safe, secure, loving, or anything else along those lines, but Rhindy always tried to make it different every time we’d do it. This frequently annoyed me, her trying to convince herself it hadn’t

become routine. I supposed I should be happy with it, but she wants to fuck like hell; often, I'm pretty tired, but do it and come quickly. More often than not, it ended too soon for her, she got upset and began arguing. I climbed off her and went to work at my desk. I sat before my typewriter trying to come up with something good; she comes out an hour or so later and complains she never gets her orgasm and I owe it to her at that very moment. She usually threw this at me either late—usually around one in the morning—or in the dead of night while I was asleep. I asked her to wait and tell me at a more civilized hour. But during those long nights of fighting, I'd ignore her and she'd fall asleep angry. In the morning, she'd slam things around, yell obscenities, and storm off to work. I'd fall back asleep, not having to be at class or the occasional job until the afternoon; the phone would ring not more than 45 minutes later. It was her—bitching, moaning, and apologizing for the upheaval the night before. She would start quietly at first and ask me what I was doing. I knew I was being backed into a corner; no matter what I said (except "I was just dreaming of you"), she would have something sarcastic to say. It was too early and I was too tired to play the game. I smirked and told her I was sleeping.

"You're always sleeping. You sleep too much. You're very difficult to live with."

"You're no picnic either."

"We never talk, never go out." She says.

"What do you want me to do about it?"

"Nothing, you go ahead and do nothing—you're good at that. Go out with your friends and don't do a damn thing. Don't worry about me."

"Okay." I hung up; I was still too sleepy to give a shit, maybe later I'd call her up and straighten things. I lay down on the couch and looked at my desk, cluttered with loose pages of manuscripts, scraps of

note paper, candy and gum wrappers. I closed my eyes and thought of last night. Rhindy and I had fucked on the couch—about where I was now. I could hear her voice in my head as I was poised ready to enter her.

“All the ones before were practice, a dress rehearsal; now it’s time for the real show,” she mutters.

And up went the curtains, the stage was spread, the players all in a row. The prima donna arched her back and bent in service to her lord. There was much love, much heat, and passion. All this extravagance was a feast for the eyes.

We were sitting in the front row, side by side on the aisle. We were struck with emotion, drawn to tears at the fabulous sight. There were many arms and legs, odors, and appendages. There was an orgasm, a warm juice spewed all over the stage; then there was another. Small double-headed sperm squirmed before our eyes. We stood and clapped, smiling widely. We laughed, wanted to sing, and tried to dance in the musicless theater.

When I returned to the apartment later in the afternoon after having done nothing, there was a message on the machine. Rhindy had phoned, urging me to meet her downtown. I didn’t want to meet her tonight; I was tired, and the memory of last night’s fight weighed heavy on my mind. Besides, tonight Gale had invited me to see her friend Colin and his band playing in a bar on the peninsula. Gale promised Valerie would be there this time—she was nowhere to be seen the last time Gale and I saw Colin and the “lose” band. I felt as if I wasn’t in the mood to chase after a woman; but the thought of the probability of the occurrence of a something was a better risk than knowing the 100% chance of having to listen to Rhindy’s shit later on.

Gale decided to dress up for the occasion. She stood before me, talking incessantly about Colin and the band and how good they

sounded when they played in a bar. She talked so affectionately about him while she was undressing, throwing her clothes around the room, pretending she was in a strip bar on El Camino: “Do you think I could make a lot of money there?” She had dreams; obsessions of having people watch her and think about fucking her.

“Yes, I suppose you could,” I told her. I didn’t think she could make all that much money from what I had seen down at those bars, but she wouldn’t do all that bad. She had the drive and ambition to do it; her raw energy alone would have those old men digging even deeper into their pockets for a five spot that she would truly deserve for her performance.

She put on a black dress, a black strapless bra, black boots, stockings, and a black beret. I had seen her dress like this once before, when we were going downtown to meet an old friend of hers she wanted to sleep with. I guessed now she was trying for the same effect, but she said she probably wouldn’t know too many people at the show; the “just in case” factor was in force, and she had to look her best. I wasn’t as determined as she to announce myself; I wanted to blend in with the crowd—whatever kind of crowd it was. Gale pressed me to wear one of her father’s ties; I put it on and we left.

There are times when I felt I had overdressed for the wrong occasion and never did it ring more true than when we walked into that bar. It was crowded with long-haired rocker types in tie-dyes and Led Zeppelin shirts. I quickly excused myself to the toilet and removed the tie. I left the jacket on; I felt it would set me apart from the rest and catch the attention of someone willing to discuss topics deeper than the importance of leather on a biker or how high school really wasn’t all that much fun.

I was nice to Gale; I bought her glasses of white wine. I had forty dollars in my pocket and felt loose; in a big way I could easily forget

about the troubles at home. I sat down with Gale. Colin and the band were setting up; he came over, shook my hand, and kissed Gale on the cheek. I could see from his fixed gaze that he was thinking of that night with me and Gale, blow-job and all. I gave him a look, showing him I could see right through his shit. He went away.

I had a couple of beers and a couple of cigarettes. I looked constantly and didn't see Valerie anywhere. I turned to Gale.

"You said she would be here tonight."

"I don't know, I just heard she'd be here."

I sighed heavily. Gale was getting intoxicated and began to laugh loudly; the band played on. I let my eyes wander.

She sat at a table near the corner and smoked, her back to the wall and her eyes locked with mine. I held my stare. We played the game; she was shifting uncomfortably in her seat and frequently smiling. I was getting a little excited and hoped it wasn't due to Gale's hand on my leg. I decided to wait and let the feeling settle.

During the break I got up and went to the bathroom again. I looked at myself in the mirror. My eyes were red from the heavy smoke in the air, my skin looked waxy, and my hair was a mess. I wet my hands in the sink and ran them through my hair; I pressed my fingers into my cheeks, trying to put a smile on my face. I pulled at the corners of my mouth, but the smile wouldn't hold. I put a cigarette in.

I opened the door, almost running smack into a large, bearded man and his buxom girlfriend. She smiled at me and thrust her breasts at me as I squeezed by. As I got near the table, I noticed Gale had moved and was now talking to Colin's girlfriend. I searched my pockets for a match, but had lost the book. I started walking toward Gale, not watching where I was going, and I ran right into her—the dirty blonde who had been sitting against the wall. She smiled and I stayed against her for a second longer.

“Oh, excuse me.” She had spilled her glass of beer.

“I’m sorry. Let me buy you another.”

She smiled and followed me to the bar. I pulled out a ten and bought us both a beer. She sat close to me. I fidgeted with the cigarette and searched for the matches again. She held out a lighter.

“Thanks.”

The bartender brought the beers. She at once picked hers up and took a long, slow swig of it. “I like the taste when it’s cold like that.”

She looked at me out from heavily mascaraed eyes. I thought that maybe she had been crying. She seemed as if she had something bothering her; maybe it was the way she sat on the stool with her legs crossed, her shirt unbuttoned one more than I had remembered. She took another drink and smiled.

“It’s not very often I come down here, I mean it’s fun once in awhile, but the smoke gets to me.”

She was young, maybe seventeen. I heard both Colin and Gale’s voice in my head,

“Lots of underage groupies.”

I cringed and wished I were facing the wrath of Rhindy. Her eyes fixed on me.

“I’m Angela.”

Angela and her dirty blonde hair, heavy make-up, thin eyes, short stature, large breasts, jeans, and a Los Angeles Raiders jacket. I began to imagine what it would be like having sex with her, but I didn’t want to get myself worked up about it. Part of me was hoping it wouldn’t happen. She tapped her fingers on the edge of the bar.

“What’s your name?”

“Chris.”

“Hi, Chris.”

“Hi.”

“Do you play in a band?”

“No, I’m a writer.”

“Really? I think that’s really cool. I like to write, but my stuff sounds awful.”

“You just have to keep on practicing. I’m still working at it.”

“That’s your job? Writing?”

“Yeah, I guess you could say that. What do you do?”

“I was in school, but now I just work. I work at the mall in San Bruno.”

I wanted to get her age straight now. Maybe she was younger than seventeen; I had to be sure.

“College?”

“Yeah, I go to Skyline. It’s my first year there.”

I breathed a sigh of relief. She looked around the bar, her eyes stopped on Gale.

“Is she your girlfriend?”

“Gale? No, we just hang out together and have sex once in a while.”

She shifted in her seat and laughed nervously. She set her beer on the bar and looked directly at me. I could tell now that she had had a few; I didn’t know why it wasn’t so obvious before. Perhaps I was too self-conscious.

“Colin’s funny, the way he plays, but he’s good. Don’t you think, Chris?”

“Yeah, I guess.”

We were silent for a long time staring at each other. The band played on and on. I finished my cig and snuffed it out on the floor—she eyed my every move with keen interest. I knew she was missing something; she perhaps needed someone different like me, someone who could care for her for a brief moment, to talk with her or screw her with all the affection of a familiar lover. I knew I was a fantasy to her, the man she

needed most despite my physical appearance, no matter how quickly the moment burned out—a bright flash of light then cold embers.

“The smoke is really starting to get to me.”

“You want to go get some air?”

She nodded and we went out. The night was a little brisk and she drew her jacket close to her.

“God, it’s cold.”

“I have a heater in my car, and it works too.”

She laughed; this time it didn’t seem so nervous. We walked over to my Pontiac and I opened the door for her.

I sat behind the wheel and turned on the oldies station. She moved close to me.

“What do you think of me, Chris?”

“I think you’re pretty, intelligent. . .”

“Thank you.” She threw her arms over my shoulders and hugged me tightly. “I wish I could be a writer like you.” She kissed me deeply, like the way she had been looking at me—probing for something to hold onto, something to read, an emotion she was incapable of.

She pulled herself away from me and, smiling, hurdled the front seat into the back. She laid herself out and I pulled her pants down. I climbed in back. She shook her head at first as if disapproving then said,

“No, don’t stop, I want to be a writer like you.” I climbed on top of her. Music streamed out from the bar.

“Do you think you’ll write a story about this?”

I looked down at her. “I really don’t know.”

“I hope you do.”

She pressed me inside her. She was red hot, the heat from her sex nearly burning the head of my cock as I slid it inside her. She moaned

loudly, letting her hands roam wildly along my spine; she pressed into the small of my back.

“Come. Come quick. I need it quick.” She whispered into my ear. I closed my eyes and let my body tense up; she gripped tighter. For her, I let myself go quickly in a torrent. I had just finished when she quickly pushed me off and sat up, looking out the window as if she had just been caught by her father. She quickly pulled up her pants and straightened her bra. I pulled out a cigarette and offered her one.

“No, thanks.”

I lit a cigarette for myself and rolled down the window. I puffed on the smoke; the speaker was behind my head and the music made me think of another place and time. I relaxed with my pants still at my ankles, while she hurriedly shoved things into her purse and looked at herself in a compact mirror. I started to say something, but she cut me off.

"I'm sorry, I have to go." She picked up her purse and kissed

me quickly on the lips. She lifted the handle on the door and got out; I watched her go back into the bar.

I pulled my pants up after I finished the smoke. Reaching over the seat, I snapped the radio off and returned to the bar.

Gale was still sitting in the corner. I got a beer and sat next to her.

“Where the hell have you been?”

“I locked myself in the bathroom by accident.”

She uttered something under her breath and I took a long gulp of the beer. I scanned the bar for a glimpse of Angela—she was nowhere to be found. She was a ghost who had walked into my life, made me feel alive for a moment or two, then quickly left in a wisp of cigarette smoke.

Floating aimlessly though the dark void, randomly colliding with people and situations, trying to grab a hold of something concrete. I reach out and lay my fingers into a body. I hold on, but only for a second. The shape changes, becomes like water, I lose my grasp—I continue speeding through the pitch black, wind striking my face, to a destination beyond. I am afraid, I am cold, I shiver. I want to be safe in my world. But the darkness won't let me. I think I must fight the abyss and punch a small hole into the curtain about me.

I couldn't bring myself to tell Gale about the fling in the Pontiac with Angela. A feeling of emptiness and depression was overtaking me. I figured, instead of talking, I'd rather sit and let the bile of the encounter settle in my throat. The rest of the evening passed quietly and quickly, despite the noise in the bar. As the alcohol saturated my brain, it had me believe that I really wasn't here; if it weren't for the fact that my cock was stuck to my thigh I would have believed in an instant that neither Angela nor this bar had never existed at all.

As time went by, the memory of those nights of drinking and sex became more fuzzy in contrast to how I was seeing the relationship between Gale and I; I began to see clearly that we really didn't get along, despite the belief we were compatible. We had had respect for each other in the beginning; I remember times skipping classes at the university, dressing up and visiting her where she worked in Burlingame. We usually had lunch in a small cafe down the street and talked about our hopes and dreams. We cared for each other's feelings; she would listen intently to what I had to say. I had believed in her, but something changed. Nick says it's due to the fact that she's so different than I, that she wants a man to serve her, and I would or could not do such a thing. Even sex was becoming a difficult task with her, as with

Rhindy. Maybe I was getting burned out, or maybe I relied too much on spontaneity, or maybe I was getting too comfortable—the familiarity sedating my creativity.

A woman stopped me today and asked the time; she had large brown eyes, blonde hair, a tall thin stature with good posture. I remarked that I was not wearing my watch and must have absent-mindedly left it at home.

“That’s not good, you know. . .” she said. “You should be aware of the time, always.”

She shook her head and walked off. I didn’t turn back to look at her. I thought she was right—that I’m not aware. I’m disillusioned, lost in the chaos of a prevailing storm that had not yet arrived, waiting in a state of nothingness for the time when I would awaken and rightfully take my place in the pillared tiers of the something. In a way she was trying to warn me that I should batten the place down to withstand the tremendous winds and furious rains; in the annals of today’s nothing, the something was coming.

As the difficulties increased with Gale, the awkwardness with Rhindy followed. I found myself torn in the heart as well as in the sense. Gale contended we would have the perfect living arrangement if I would agree to move in. There would be no restrictions, no nagging, and no pressures—the only commitment being the responsibility for half the rent and bills. We talked so animatedly about it, so pleasantly; we could have the world as we wanted it living day to day, immersing ourselves in total debauchery. This proposal was just that, a proposal, but now it reached a tone of seriousness—Gale had found a place on Bellevue Street in San Mateo. She was telling me the news over coffee in a restaurant we usually went to on the El Camino.

“It would be closer to your job,” she said. “I don’t have to deal with my parents and you could leave Rhindy.”

If there was one thing about Gale you could pin down, it was that she felt her problems outweighed mine—hers always took precedent. I expressed concern about leaving Rhindy.

“Look, you have problems with Rhindy, at least that’s what you’ve been telling me, and you say you want to get out. Christ, we went looking together. Now I’ve found a place; it’s settled, and I want you to agree with it.”

I twisted a cigarette between my fingers. “I’d like to look at it before I say anything.”

“I have the keys, we can look at the place tonight.”

I sipped at my coffee and looked out the window. I lit the cig. I was getting angry.

“That’s nice.”

“What’s the matter?”

“Nothing.”

“No, tell me. I need to know what you think.”

“Does it have a garage?”

“No.”

“That’s great. At least the place we looked at in Redwood City had a garage.”

“It’s a lot farther from where both you and I work and I’m sure that old car of yours burns a hell of a lot of gas.”

“Yeah, you went for the San Mateo place because it’s so close to your work.”

“Excuse me for thinking of both of us and not just myself like you always do. What’s your problem?”

I took a long drink of coffee and put the unfinished cig out in the ashtray. “What’s wrong? You went out and not only found a place, but put money down on it like I have no say about what goes on.”

“Look, I don’t want to get into another Chris/Gale fight. You can’t get away from the Rhindy scene.” She looked around and shook her head. “I can’t believe you, why are you being such an asshole?”

“I’m not the one who went behind your back. . .”

“Whatever. . .”

“At least I would have the courtesy to ask your opinion before I made a decision. Fuck, I have to live there too, remember?”

“Yeah, but I know you’ll like it. It’s in a quiet area, larger than your Sunset place, it’s on the second floor, has a deck, and a swimming pool.”

“I’m sure I’ll hate it. I despise it already.”

“She shook her head again. “Let’s get out of here.”

I paid the bill and we left in her car, turning down El Camino. The businesses that were clustered along the sides of the road had been there for countless years; El Camino had been the main road from San Francisco to Los Angeles since the days of the Spanish missions—it was teeming with history. We were on our way to the new apartment ready for a confrontation.

“You really know how to hurt me, don’t you?” She glared at me.

“I wasn’t the one who did all this.”

“You had me believe you wanted out. . .”

“And I do. . .but we never seriously talked about it.”

“You want me to believe that, I don’t know what to think. You act like you care then you quickly change when something doesn’t suit you. I don’t get you, Chris.”

I was getting tired of the conversation, and watched the buildings going by.

“I’ll just have to see the place, Gale. Maybe I’ll like it then.”

“Yeah.”

I noticed as we passed Scherba's Auto Parts that all the neon in the sign was working—the style was a throwback to the fifties. A time where it was proclaimed that life was good if you could prove you were an American. And I could be one of those; just as long as Gale weren't there or if she were, she'd be a Communist.

The new apartment was across the street from a high school. As I got out, I noticed the air was cleaner than in the city and the neighborhood was typical of suburbs. The damp streets reflected our steps. She pointed out the building; it looked like it had been a hotel at one time or another.

“Wow, we're staying at the Holiday Inn!”

The place was sterile and squarish, like a series of shoe boxes stacked on one another and thrown together into a crude 'M' shape. As we walked past the mailboxes, there was a tiled courtyard that had seen better days; there were several empty painted ponds, poorly tended trees, and unkempt grass. We ascended some red-tiled stairs to the second floor. As we walked along the walkway, I could really see how horribly disarrayed the courtyard was; the apartment was in a corner with a view of a pool from the doorway. The door itself had a brass sun design around the knob and I could almost read the Do Not Disturb/Maid Service sign which was now doubling as a doorbell. She unlocked the door and we went in.

Green carpet spread out before my sight. The room wasn't very large, and the smell of fresh paint was overwhelming; I went for the door that led to the deck. The view wasn't too bad; you could see the lights of downtown San Mateo—for whatever that was worth. Although the place could be conceived as adequate, I couldn't separate myself from the situation, of how Gale had gotten the place. It would take me awhile to get used to it. She took me into the kitchen.

“This could be your office, it can be shut off from the rest of the apartment.”

I didn’t much care for the wallpaper; it was beige with brown and gold imprints of mobiles contorted into various sickening shapes.

“Yeah, it’s okay.”

She showed me the closets, the bathroom, and the vanity. She pointed out the tremendous benefits the place had—I was not convinced. We left, and I looked at my watch; it was eight-thirty. We didn’t talk much in the car; I think she was afraid I was going to say something deathly horrible that would make her cry for days on end.

Chapter 4

When I got home later, I threw my coat on the couch and went to the bathroom. I took a long look at myself in the mirror; the changes were taking their toll on me. You look at your face every morning when you get ready, but you really don’t look at yourself. Right now I look alien; I was changing so fast and the times I looked at myself so rare that I couldn’t recognize myself. My eyes had sunk, with dark, purplish patches under them. My face had wrinkled, with deep lines running along my cheeks—my complexion scarred. I looked horrible. The times of nothingness I had been living in had not been kind to me; the signs of the side effects of my attempted debaucheries plaguing me.

I gave up staring at myself and went to turn the radio on; I noticed the light was blinking on the answering machine—it was Murray. He was proposing a night out—an adventure—reminding me that he had told me last week about it. I called him back.

“Murray, I got your message, sorry I forgot.”

“So what do you think about it?”

“What are we going to do?”

“That’s just it, we don’t know. That’s what makes it an adventure.”

“Oh, yeah.” I was really tired, but Rhindy wasn’t home and this was my chance to leave before I would be cornered into talking to her. “You want to stop over here? It would be easier if we took the train.”

“Yeah, see ya in a few.”

I hung up and plopped back down on the couch, hoping Rhindy wouldn’t come home before Murray arrived.

He arrived a half-hour later, talking lively about a new film idea he had dreamt the night before. “It would be based on our adventures,” he said. “We could do one about running across the abandoned Embarcadero freeway, walking through the Tenderloin on acid, the insidious barhopping and the women who always stare at you, insane people handing out fliers, anything at all. Your life is so weird, we could film it.”

We got onto the train to go downtown. I felt like wandering through the Financial District; at this time of night it was empty and devoid of the types in suits who claimed affluence, free of erratic bicycle messengers and frenetic people handing out fliers—all who annoyed the shit out of me. I felt like seeing the tall skyscrapers, dark and ominous, towering above, making you feel as if you’re the smallest, most insignificant thing on the street. My mood was melancholic; I wanted to feel small, tiny enough to crawl into a dark space and hide from the rest of the world. We didn’t make it there. Murray yanked me out of the train on Powell Street; he said he was getting thirsty, and after thinking about it, I decided I was, too.

We jumped on a cable car and rode it to the wharf. Murray sprang from the car and I followed him into a Liquor Barn where we looked through the splendid variety of bottled poisons: liqueurs, beer, high-filtered grain alcohol, cheap vodka. We opted for a half-liter of Southern Comfort—an old favorite. The minute we got outside, I hastily twisted the cap off and took a deep swig; the whiskey burned my throat and

left a trail of warmth as it journeyed to my stomach. I took another. We stopped at a corner store, realizing we had forgotten an appropriate mixer and a bag of pretzels. The alcohol was starting to well in our throats, and we needed something to take the edge off.

We wandered aimlessly through the city, ending up in a park on the side of a hill on Vallejo Street. Murray took a long drink from the bottle and gazed at me through glassy eyes.

“How are things going with you and Rhindy?”

“All right, I suppose. We’re getting along okay.”

“I’m getting tired of that bitch, Jackie. She’s been pissing me off.”

I drank deeply; the bottle was now half empty. “You? No. You guys are the perfect couple. Problems? No.”

“You know, normally I wouldn’t talk about her that way, I love her and all. She’s just so. . .I don’t know. . .bothersome.”

“Bothersome?”

“If I don’t do the dishes the way she wants or wash the laundry right, she bitches. If I drink, she bitches.”

“Think you’ll last?”

“We’ll be getting married soon.” He paused and looked at the lights of the city. “Do you think she’s attractive?”

“Yeah, she’s okay, not my type, but okay.”

“You know sometimes I catch myself thinking that the only reason I stay with her is because she takes care of me.”

“I noticed.”

“I’ve got it good, huh?”

“So you do.”

“Rhindy takes care of you.”

“I guess, just like a mother. Like Jackie is to you. Us men are always on the lookout for that mother in the women we date.”

“It’s kind of nice that way. Don’t you like it?”

“Not really, I always wanted to live by my wits—obsessed. . . .ah shit, I don’t have a fucking clue as to what I want.”

The alcohol was settling into my brain. We finished off the whiskey and dumped the remaining juice-mixer. We got up to walk; it was more difficult than I first thought. Down the hill we wandered toward Columbus, careening through the streets, not giving a damn as to a destination, and without regard for security or if we would be able to fulfill the adventure.

I vaguely recognized the places we passed; we ended up on Broadway admiring the brilliancy of carnival-like lights announcing the many bars selling sex. The Bimbo—live nude show; The Naked Lady, a theater decorated in red velvet; we were yelled at as we passed—vocal invitations. Another liquor store, a smaller bottle of whiskey. An alley seemed like a quiet enough place to indulge amidst the seamy busyness of the avenues.

In that alley a bond of friendship was forged (as it often is in such circumstances) between Murray and I. There we promised to take care and watch out for each other, to believe in our abilities as artists, and try to succeed. The evening was warm despite a chill in the air; it was the alcohol that made the talk easier, the strip just a little nicer, and the world a little more bearable. After finishing the bottle, we decided to wander the remaining strip. A quiet bar caught our attention; a woman standing at the entrance smiled as we entered. The place was dark, with red velvet stuck to the walls. A stout woman was slowly shaking her hips to an inaudible tune on a jukebox. She took off her top, revealing her breasts. I sighed and we sat down. Another woman came to us and said there was a two-drink minimum and that they were \$7.50 each. Murray looked at me and grudgingly handed over his money. I did the same. When she left, I gazed around the bar; there were three other men in the place. Three women in see-through outfits

hung over them like vultures, waiting for them to pass out or die so that they could pick their wallets clean. They seemed disinterested in their present victims and when one cast a glance over to us, I was worried they would come over. The waitress had cleaned both Murray and I out. We had only fare for the train home. But, sure enough, as the stout woman finished her lolling around and the few clapped pathetically, the vultures made their way to us.

Ugly, horrific things can hide behind the visage of a woman, especially one who worked out of a dump like this. The amount of utter hatred they emanate is frightening. Sure, there were the hard luck stories—the dead parents, the sick mother, the desperate children, or whatever intense problem they could dream up and relate to some poor sap—but no matter what the story, the underlying truth remained constant: they hated. And hated fiercely the male sex. Perhaps they had been victimized, were vengeful, or just wanted a taste of complete control; Murray and I were lame ducks in their shooting gallery. The game was serious, I was a pawn, the woman tried to manipulate the loneliness she thought I possessed—why would we come here in the first place? She thought we were desperate, and perhaps we were, but not for any favors she could sell. She couldn't know that it wasn't the place that had brought us here; all this was one big accident.

Two sat with Murray and one with me. They began asking questions; I was hesitant and answered quietly. This sparked the interest of the woman next to me; her eyes widened and she went into a story of her hard life in Hawaii and how she had come to San Francisco, disillusioned and broke, trying to survive. She said she wanted to act; if that were true she was sure doing a good job—I almost believed the story.

“You’ve had an interesting life—until now. But I have no money. I had to give it to the waitress for these things they call drinks.”

She looked surprised. “You did?”

“Yep, all of it. I don’t have a dime to my name. But I must say the conversation is nice.”

She sighed loudly, turned and looked to the stage. Another woman came out and started undressing to a Carol King song. The one next to me sat and watched for a long time.

“It’s too bad you know,” she said not looking at me. “We could have had such a good time.”

“Oh, I don’t know. I’m having fun now.”

She closed her eyes and shook her head. “Yeah. . .”

I looked at Murray; the girl got up and slowly walked away, not once turning back to look. The two around Murray had gone.

“Chris, let’s get out of here.”

We left without paying for our second drink; that meant we still had about fifteen dollars between us. I suggested we get something to eat, so we stopped at a small restaurant and had some eggs and coffee. I noticed it was getting late, close to two; I was quickly tiring and wanted to get to Rhindy’s bed. We made one last stop at a porn shop, got a free erection, and went home.

I awoke next to Rhindy early in the morning, not remembering the train ride home or how Murray got to the couch, but as I got up to go to the toilet, there he was—sprawled out and snoring loudly. I splashed some cold water on my face and went back to sleep.

I awoke again, the smell of bacon tickling my nostrils. I sat up, thinking I was dreaming; Murray and Rhindy were talking in the kitchen. I threw on a robe and followed the aroma. Murray was stuffing himself with eggs and toast; Rhindy was over the stove turning bacon.

“I didn’t want to wake you.”

Murray stopped eating for a second and looked up at me. I smirked at him and poured myself a cup of coffee.

“Are you hungry?” Rhindy asked.

I dropped three spoonfuls of sugar into the cup and stirred. “I suppose.”

I sat next to Murray; it looked like he hadn’t slept well.

“How are you doing?”

“All right.”

“Did you call Jackie and tell you were staying here?”

He swallowed hard. Rhindy looked over at us.

“Yeah, yeah. . .” he said quietly. Rhindy went back to the pan, Murray back to his plate, and I to my coffee. I felt like smoking, but had no cigarettes. Rhindy set a plate of bacon and eggs before me.

Murray was silent while Rhindy was in the kitchen. He seemed like he had something on his mind, but didn’t want to say it. As I finished eating, Rhindy went to the toilet; he sat back and carefully eyed me. I set my fork down.

“What?”

“Did you like last night?” He whispered.

“It was fun, yeah.”

“Did you tell Rhindy what we did?” His eyes darted toward the bathroom door.

“No, when was I supposed to have the chance?”

“Good, let’s keep it to ourselves.” The toilet flushed.

I smirked. Rhindy came out of the bathroom and Murray returned his eyes to his plate. He was in his “I’m feeling guilty about the horrid things I believe I did last night”, moralistic mood. I didn’t much care for him when he was like this; it proved the adventures we went on were only fun as long as they didn’t get him into trouble. Murray called upon the universe for random fortune and when the random turned to its true nature, chaos, he turned tail and hid under the Naugahyde couch on credit from Sears in his living room. I was too tired to tell him what a lousy shit he was. Rhindy looked at us.

“What did you guys do last night?”

“Ahh, nothing. Nothing really.” Murray said.

I looked at Murray. “Nothing?” He fidgeted. “I’ll tell you later, dear.”

Later, as Murray got his things together and I closed the door behind him, Rhindy turned her back and huffed into the bedroom. This action meant she was mad. It was too early to have to deal with her; I was too hung over. I sat at the desk and she threw the door open.

“I hate it when you’re secretive. You really know how to hurt me. You don’t leave a note or message, how am I supposed to know where the hell you are?”

I was trying to ignore her. My head was pounding.

“And you waltz in here at two-thirty in the morning, drunk, and expect me to like it. You have NO respect for me at all, do you?”

I drank my coffee and searched the desk for a stray cig.

“Does it make any difference to you that I might not like it that you come in late? Does it make any difference that all I ask of you is to leave a note saying where you are and when you think you’ll be back? Is that too much? Do you care?”

“I guess not.” I shot a look at her. She glared at me, cocked her head to one side, and contorted her face in some show of anger and resentment.

“I guess not??!!” She stood still, shocked by what I had said. I shut the drawer not finding a smoke and put my head in my hands—my head throbbed. She let out a quick gasp and shut herself in the bedroom. I stared out the window for a moment then fetched three aspirin.

“Thanks for the breakfast,” I said to the bedroom door as I made my way back to the desk. I sat down and swallowed the pills with the coffee; she slowly opened the door and came out.

“Why do you do this to me? Why? What have I done that is so terrible?” Her eyes were starting to cloud up. “I try to give you as much space as you need, but it never seems to be enough. What’s wrong? Why are you trying to pull away from me?”

“I’m not pulling away from you, I’m hung over.” The aspirin left a bitter taste in my throat that the coffee couldn’t wash down. Rhindy looked over my shoulder; she wanted to continue talking, but it was early, far too early. The pressures were building up greater strengths—I wanted to escape.

“Something will always remind you of me.” That’s what Rhindy said would happen if I ever left her. What she didn’t know is I was already haunted by those things she threatened; there was nothing more she could do to torture me.

“You can never be free of me,” she also had said. Wrong again. I was free of her the day we first met, subjecting myself to memories of past loves and ideas of loves present—including Ninety-Nine. She could never hurt me more than I was already hurting.

I finally found that cig I was searching for under some letters from Gale; it was one of the best tasting cigarettes I’d ever had. I inhaled, the taste was so smooth, the nicotine so satisfying. I filled my lungs with the smoke and the tar again and again.

“Gotta die of something,” I always told myself and anybody else who would hear. I thought of life, of death, and of my life with Rhindy, among other things. There was so much bullshit going on around the apartment, so many lies and so few truths. I knew it was just a matter of time before I left. I was ready to spill the ink.

I searched through the desk again, picking out a letter from Gale. I held it between my fingers. Rhindy had just gotten dressed and slammed the door behind her—she said she was going to get some shopping done. I breathed a sigh of relief and continued pulling out

old letters. As I drew out a stack of Gale letters, a stray envelope fell to the floor. It had Azlya's handwriting on it. There had been a time when I thought she was Ninety-Nine.

An hour later, I paid a surprise visit to Gale; we fucked in her parents' basement and I came on her tits. Now I'm sitting the couch and she's trying to shoehorn her ass into her tight jeans. I put on my clothes and reached for the letter from Azlya in my back pocket.

"What's that?" Gale asks, tucking her breasts into her bra.

"Nothing much, a letter from Ninety-Nine." Gale knows little of the story—how much of a whore Azlya was, one hell of a lover she was.

"Did you just get it?"

"It's about four months old." It's the letter she wrote right before she said she didn't want to see me anymore, a time when I still believed in her.

"Wait a minute," she ran downstairs and came back with a couple of books cradled in her arms. They are occult books. "Didn't you say Azlya—Ninety-Nine—was into black magic?"

"I really have no idea."

She opened the book. "Ninety-Nine. . .nine," she reads.

Some people have a deranged way of looking at things; they place such a high value on coincidence and subtlety of extravagance. Gale likes to place value on esoteric things like numbers, and how people are like numbers, and how numbers control everything, and so on and so on. She professes you could figure anybody's personality just by figuring the significance of numbers. Gale liked to read these books; she liked to drive me crazy with them.

"Nine is the number of high mental and spiritual achievement, nines are successes in life with a burning drive to see completeness." She decided to add my name to see what happened; somehow, all came to eighteen when added to nine. She smiled broadly at her conclusion.

“Looks like you and Ninety-Nine have something in common.”

“Too much in common.”

She read on, but I was tired of it. She irritated me.

“So let me get this straight. If we fuck nine times in nine days at nine o’clock each time, we’re destined to rule the universe?”

“Fuck you Chris, you don’t understand.”

“You’re so full of shit.”

“Fuck you.” She strutted over and sat on my lap. “Why are you so frustrated? We just fucked. Don’t you like fucking me anymore—perhaps I should blow you more—or is life on the home front that bad?”

“I like fucking you. . . I think.”

“Fuck you.”

The phone rang and she answered it; it was an old boyfriend. She waved me away. I read through her occult book for a few minutes, took some food items from the cabinets, and left. I thought of nines and their significance, if any.

When I got home, Rhindy tore into me; I had just walked in and not more than three second passed before. . .

“You’re never here for me,” and. . .

“You’re always spending time with Gale,” and. . .

“When you are here, you don’t listen to me,” and most frequently heard. . .

“You don’t care.”

I was in a decent mood and put up with her. I wanted to feel guilty for having just slept with Gale, terrible for having treated her as badly as I had for the past few days, weeks, whatever. But I couldn’t bring myself to. At the same moment, I wanted to strike her to get her to shut up; she was saying the same things over and over again.

“You’re never here for me,” and. . .

“You don’t care. You’re selfish and you don’t care.”

Round robin, I’m going around in a fucking circle with this. It keeps on going like a carousel, it doesn’t stop. But what if I want to get off? Nope, too bad, you’re stuck asshole, stuck and fucked with no place to go. You’re going to have to hang out and live with it, roll with the lack of changes and stay in the rut. Trapped in the snare of your own design.

“You’re selfish and you don’t care.”

If I hear it one more time, I’m going to crack; I’ve put up with a lot of shit until now, but the pressures are strong, they have built higher and higher. Don’t push me Rhindy, please don’t push. I’m going to explode, not one more time. . .

“YOU DON’T CARE!!!!!!”

The lid shot off: things flew about the room—words, accusations, and objects like pens, books, and a chair. I didn’t sit and take it, I stood and chased after her, out for blood. I yelled at the top of my lungs like I never had for as long as I can remember. She cried. I pushed her down on the couch and packed up some of my clothes. She tried to calm me, telling me between sobs to stop. She wanted us to talk like we used to do, but I wouldn’t listen anymore. She blocked my exit; I pushed her aside and drove off, screeching the tires as I raced up the block. I stopped at the beach as my anger subsided. I unfolded a blanket in the back of the car and while staring at the contours of the headliner, managed to fall asleep.

I don’t show my anger to Rhindy or anyone else; I just hold it in and let it build and build until something someone does causes me to release it. Rhindy knew this and was manipulating me, pushing me as far as she could. She wanted me to react, so she pushed and pushed. Well, she got it; I hoped she was happy. It mattered not what I did or said to her. I wouldn’t be living there much longer anyhow; the new

place with Gale was available on the 15th—in three days—I wouldn't have to wait much longer.

It was around the 17th when I finally gave the old SF place the heave-ho. I threw as much of my stuff as I could into the Pontiac and drove south toward a new life away from the city, Rhindy, and stable life in general. Gale professed it would be great and we wouldn't hound each other. I didn't know. The sun was covered by clouds—dark storm clouds—and I felt that the next few months were to be the most troubled and jostled ones of my entire life.

I see myself; immersed in the anger and sadness I possess is what is left of me. It has only been three days since I came into this new apartment, and already I'm feeling a loss of control. I'm beginning to think I'm nuts and constantly on a tirade. Wanting not to deal with it, I let the flow of time and distance take me away from all the shit that is surrounding me. If I were so inclined, I would lose my mind. But to save my precious sanity, I spill ink, waste paper, and chain smoke. I feel I must get something accomplished. I feel like Conrad who hated to write, labeled it as a chore, but turned out literature nonetheless. I must write. I can't not write. Some say if you write to bolster your ego and not for pure desire then you're doing it for the wrong reasons. They tell me I can't write, I say screw them. Perhaps I can't. But at least I can say I tried, tried to make something of this world obsessed with ugliness and destitution. The pressures are building again, they've caught me off guard. They're trying to become more powerful by feeding off the words of the others—people who call themselves friends. Friends are supposed to support each other and smile at the worst trash, but mine, mine would rather throw me into the jaws of hell than pay me any bit of respect by granting a positive

remark about my work. The pressures, the ennui, they're back in a big way.

I dropped my pen today. The world dissolved before my eyes. Everything came crashing down in one heavy thump. Everything—words, phrases, modifiers, sentences, syntax, diction, came tumbling down. I felt as though I were the pen, feeling the force of the blow as it struck the pavement, tasting bile in the back of my throat, feeling the blood ebb from my nose down my lips. I choked on the blood. I choked on the words as they lay on me. As I was suffocating, it occurred to me that I might die. I also thought that I might, if I survived, give up writing altogether—since all that I had created nearly killed me. Yes, I should like to think I could give up writing, burn all my manuscripts, and give into lesser things.

I am depressed, but I try to be cheerful to Gale. We are wandering around a small bookstore/coffee shop on Fourth Street. She doesn't seem to notice how hard I am trying.

"I'm going to the bathroom to check for any replies to my hate list."

Gale liked to write phrases designed to provoke harsh reactions on bathroom walls; she especially liked the tiled room in the bookstore. It is near midnight. When she returns she seems unsatisfied, must have been no response. I smile painfully.

"Don't laugh at me, I don't like it."

So much for trying. Me, I'm ready to give up and sit deaf, dumb, and blind and let the world pass me by. It's not my fault I'm this way. I was driven to it; in the absence of Ninety-Nine from both my life and dreams, I held closer to Gale and my life with her. I quickly learned I had made a grave mistake.

Gale had so much sexual energy for anybody else but me—the person she claimed she cared about, slept with, lived with, and occasionally loved; she took the time to complain about me and rave the achievements

of others. She had the annoying habit of contorting our conversation to make it seem I was the one being rude and obnoxious and selfish. One time, while we were having sex, I was on top holding myself close to her when all of a sudden, like a wave, an overwhelming sensation of insecurity gripped me.

“Am I doing it right? Are you okay?”

She stopped. I stopped.

“You sure know how to ruin a mood.” She sat herself up, reached for a cig then froze. She glared at me. “Just turn me over and fuck me, I don’t care.”

So I did, she was playing her game, I was determined not to let her damn mood swing and subsequent blame on me affect anything. As soon as I started in on her, she dried out.

“See what you did!”

She drew herself away and went into the bathroom. I heard thunder rumble in the distance; it started to rain. I remained, sitting on my legs, hearing her fuss with the toilet and the faucet; I figured she must be wetting herself down to get back at me, to make me feel guilty for inconveniencing her by fucking. She returned, lay on her back, and spread her legs.

“I’m giving you five minutes to come. If you can’t by then, too bad.”

I stared at the wall. A weight settled in my gut; I felt as if I might be sick. I didn’t show it to Gale, she’d get too much of a thrill thinking I was weak. She wanted to play head games, and if I didn’t play along, she would destroy me. I slid myself in. Four minutes left, three minutes—time was unhooking itself from the dock and setting out for sea; I saw the boat leaving and ran as fast as I could for it. Two minutes—she announced the warning—there was still enough room to leap and make the boat; my heart pounded as I neared the end of the

pier. I was going to make it. One minute—my muscles ached; I tried to run faster. The boat was pulling away; I yelled for it to wait.

“I’m sorry if I’m not the best lay you’ve ever had.” I said to her.

She shot a disgusted look and pushed me away; she jumped out from under me to the bathroom again. I had a good run, but time was up. I checked the distance between the pier and the boat; it almost appeared too great, but I had to know for sure. Blood rushed to my head and I took a flying leap; the sunset glared bright in my eyes. I sat up and stared at the bathroom door; I am washed over, as if by cold water. I was so close and she had cheated me out of the last thirty or so seconds; in that brief time I could’ve had my orgasm and made that ship sailing off into the sun. She pulled the door back; she had her pants on.

“Fuck you.”

I got dressed and was silent. I was walking on egg shells with Gale, if I said anything to her she would take it her own skewed way and get angry. She turned on the portable, black and white television—end of conversation, end of encounter, end of evening. The rain poured; I could hear it rapping loudly on the vent above the stove. The storm would never pass, it stayed over Gale and I. I went through the kitchen to a small, carpeted dining area. I had set my desk up near the counter close to the window with a view of town. It was dark, but I tried to see something outside, perhaps a glimpse of something worthwhile. Was there anything out there worth anything? I turned on the radio and shut the divider door. I felt sad; I was trying to hold onto something with needles covering its body. The radio played a long forgotten song from years back. I whispered the words as the song echoed in my head. The rain pelted the window, so hard that I thought it was trying to break through the glass and soak me; it wanted me to know its presence, to be my friend, to give me knowledge of things now and things to come. But I felt that I was already soaked, saturated with the putrid

fluid of a tortured existence. I sighed and reached for the lock to open the window; the rain beat harder, telling me it wanted to come in. I was hypnotized. I smiled at the drops of water and turned the lock.

The kitchen door swung open and Gale burst through it.

“Don’t open the window, it’s raining outside!”

I regained my composure, turned, and looked at her from miles away.

“What’s the matter with you, Chris?”

What’s the matter? Oh, nothing, just talking to the weather. We were having the greatest conversation. I was going to invite it in, but you barged in and shooed it away.

“Well, say something. What’s going on?”

Imagine that. Just a few minutes before she was saying ‘fuck you’ to me, and now she wants to talk.

“I want to apologize for acting like a bitch. I guess I misunderstood you.”

I reached for a cig and smoked with my back to the cold glass of the window; the rain tapped at my back. I was silent.

“Am I bothering you?”

“No, I was just staring off into the world.”

“I wanted to tell you I was sorry, did you hear me?”

“Yeah.”

“What do you say?”

“I accept your apology, but don’t expect me to act nice right now.”

“All right.” She pulled the divider closed. The wind blew water against the glass; I looked out again. My mood was broken, our conversation was over—the cycle repeats itself. This storm was going to last, and I was going to do my damndest to make the best of it.

All the anger I exerted had left me exposed, naked, looking for a companion. During those rainy nights, as I lay next to Gale, I thought of all the women I had spent the night with. I thought of Rhindy and

how warm she was curled up next to me. She put out a lot of heat. Gale didn't put out any. She was almost cold if you touched her. I thought of Azlya; she was not very warm, either. I stared at the dark ceiling and life streamed through me, in flux. I was chasing something—an idea, a perfect woman—but I didn't know what I would gain by such a relentless pursuit. Would I find the perfect Ninety-Nine? Would I see that Rhindy had taken better care of me and that I should be with her instead of here next to Gale? Would I find anything? Thunder rattled the windows. The travesties of this night had left me with a tidbit of realization; I was pursuing a pure ideal, a philosophy, a view of the sincere, a life without flaws. Maybe I wasn't looking for a woman, but the spectacular glint behind her eyes—the precious spark I had called Ninety-Nine.

Chapter 5

The road to the moment of discovery is a difficult one; it leaves you wondering how you got there, where you're going, and where you've been. It's one of those things that will lead you to a goal but will certainly obscure your perception. But when you reach the peace of knowing you've made it through sheer hell, the taste of your victory is sweet. You know you've endured the worst life could dish out. You've tolerated and fought and survived; the peace and unshakable knowledge you acquire is your reward.

I had been on the road for a long time, I was at the edge of a precipice trying to decide whether or not I should throw myself off, not knowing if there were a ledge ten feet down or jagged rocks hundreds of feet below. I was standing in the light of my own bitterness; the debauched life that was promised had not shown itself. Gale was seemingly living it every time I was away. But I wasn't. I was angry, resentful, and perhaps jealous. I immersed myself in hatred. Down below, in the darkness beyond my footing, could lie a better outlook, a better life,

but I could also fall to my death not ever knowing if I had succeeded or not. A sacrifice had to be made. I had to take a leap of faith.

Gale gave me a tarot reading. I asked her not to, but she said, “Indulge me, I need the practice.”

She had gotten the idea to give professional readings in the apartment on an appointment basis; I didn’t mind the idea as long as we didn’t have to discuss my life with these cards. She said I was hiding something and I didn’t want to see how fucked my perception was. She made a good point, but I had the feeling I would only learn what I already knew.

She set out the cards and turned them over one by one, relating the meanings as she went along.

“You’re getting a lot of aces and reverses.”

I was pretty sure she didn’t know what she was talking about and set my eyes wandering. A rush of sexual energy hit me. I panned my eyes over Gale’s body and instantly wanted her; for the first time in weeks, I felt desire for her. The day was clearing.

“What this means, Chris, is you will meet with success both spiritually and materially after a series of sacrifices have been made. The way you see things will alter your destiny.” She gazed at me. “You have to let go of some of the shit that’s going on now and throw yourself into the belief that you need to live a new life. You have many conflicts to resolve.”

I stared at her breasts not paying attention to what she was saying; I thought she sounded like a psychiatrist trying to appeal to my better nature. She sounded so damn silly, talking figuratively. But as the bullshit settled and I really thought about what she was saying and what I had been thinking, the picture became more clear. It had burst its way through the dark clouds that had littered the sky. I knew what

I had to do to usher in this new change. My footing precarious, I shut my eyes and jumped.

The rush of air lifted my heart; I fell and fell. The light dissipated and darkness wrapped itself around me. The moving air dulled my senses; all I knew was anxiety, fear of falling, and fear of striking the ground. I had fallen so many times recently and was pretty damn tired of it. But as the fear nearly engulfed me, I heard a faint voice that could have been easily confused for the passing air.

“Stay if you want, go if you must, I understand your confusion. For now, let me hold the lamp that illuminates a brighter path for you.” A radio played in the darkness. I tried to move. The wind had stopped; my fall was broken. I reached out toward the music; the volume was turned up. Light came from an unknown source, and then I saw her by the radio. The tall, thin figure, red hair, sanguine eyes—it was her, Ninety-Nine. The true Ninety-Nine, and not one I had fabricated. She appeared as a ghost, perfect. Her long hair flowed to her long dress; she smiled. I felt her touch—the light became brighter until my sight was a wash of white.

I felt free, released, away from my body. I was floating aimlessly. I could see nothing, but knew where I was and where I was going. As soon as the sensations began, they ceased. I was back at the apartment. The lights had subsided; I had laid down and was looking at the ceiling. Gale was still talking about the cards as she smoked; I watched the smoke playfully dance around the bulb of the lamp.

The hotel room was cold and Anna was alone. Her lover had left early in the morning. She didn't mind him leaving if she knew he was coming back. He always did, but she knew someday he wouldn't. She felt open, vulnerable and afraid. There was a sense of permanency

between them—a sort of magical bond that no matter what her desire, that which was done could not be undone. Maybe she loved him and maybe he loved her. She wondered what she would do if he did leave her. Would she survive? She had survived many hard times with many others, and she knew there were more hard times to come. She would survive as she had many times, but what kind of life was managing all of the thin technicalities that continually screwed things up? There were disasters and then there were crises and then there was chaos. Genesis, the beginning.

He lay on his side of the bed, not touching her, wrapped in his own dreams, his mind far away. Daylight is appearing on the horizon; soon he will go again. She faces the ordeal of driving back to Ennindale, empty and lonely. She looks at him; no warmth comes through the blankets. Maybe he was dead. No, he moves, but sleeping with him is like lying next to a corpse. He is an inanimate piece of flesh that speaks to her occasionally, usually only when he wants to fuck her. In the small hours of the morning, he would slap her on the ass. She would roll over and he would enter her; she rarely refused, she wants it to be over with. She stares at the cheap decor of the room; they always meet here, when he feels like it. She is tired, she needs something more. She is tired of loving him for what he is not; he is not as she wants him to be. She wants a lover who appreciates and loves her for herself, not what anyone pretends her to be.

It was a warm afternoon, sometime in April. I found myself spending more time outside since the weather was warming; the sun appeared more often here on the peninsula than in the dreary city. I stood on the deck and looked at the landscape that surrounded the building. I took a deep breath and tasted the air; it was a little cleaner than the

city air, but not much. I got the urge to wander about town, maybe take in some scenery and see a few people. I figured I was new in town and had to establish myself. Downtown seemed to be the best place for that.

It is five o'clock; I decided to check the mailbox before I left. There were a few loose things for Gale and a letter for me. I looked at it front and back; there was no return address, but I had the feeling I knew who it was from—an eerie feeling that I didn't like. The postal service had recently taken it upon themselves to raise the rates—around the corners of the letter were twenty-five one-cent stamps, hastily and sporadically glued. It was the trademark of a man I had known in the East. I had not heard a word out of him in four years. I felt as though I should rip the envelope open on the spot, but something told me to wait.

I left the mail for Gale in the apartment, since I knew she would be home soon and didn't have the key to the box. As I made my way up, I sifted through her pile. A few letters from friends, others from the dating sleaze club (I called them newspaper lovers) and the usual assortment of junk mail. I opened the door and the phone was ringing. I answered it just before the machine picked up.

"Hello?"

"Yo, Chris, what's up?" It was Nick.

"Not much. What's going on?"

"Nothing. You doing anything tonight?"

I looked out the window; the sun was just beginning to cast long shadows on the houses behind the complex. I thought about my wanting to walk into town. "No."

"Would you like to come over and meet my new woman? She's making dinner and everything. My parents have gone to Santa Rosa."

"Um, I don't know."

"Are you doing anything else?"

“Not really. I have to run a few errands.”

“Well, stop by. We should be ready in an hour or so.” He pulled the phone away and yelled. “She says sooner, if you want to eat.”

“Okay, I’ll be by in a bit.”

“All right.”

“Bye.”

“Later.”

I hung up and set the mail on the floor; I put the letter covered with stamps in my jacket pocket. Dinner at Nick’s, that meant a drive into the city and maybe a brush with Rhindy—he only lived a few blocks from the old place. I wasn’t going to worry about it, the chances of us seeing each other were one in fifty—maybe less.

I really didn’t want to see Nick right now, but I couldn’t pass up a free dinner; the woman he was talking about must be the one he had mentioned the last time we were out for pizza. Seems like they hit it off okay. I was somewhat curious about her, Nick always talked about his women, but I never met any of them. Nick was prolific at telling stories, but the reality of those stories remained questionable. I wanted to find out if she was intelligent, an air-head, plain stupid, or a pleasant combination. Was she truly something special or was she just like Nick—cruel, insidious, and obnoxious.

Nick greeted me at the door, he was dressed in his usual way: loose fitting pants, button down shirt, and lackluster shoes. His black hair was neatly drawn back.

“Come on in.” The house was in disarray; she was in the kitchen stirring something in a pot over the stove.

“This is Gabrielle.” She glanced at me, smiled lightly, and went back to the pot; she was making spaghetti. Nick and I went into the dining room. He brought in a couple of drinks, putting a gin and tonic in front of me.

"The booze is cheap, it was the only thing I could find in the house."

"I would have picked something up if you would have asked me."

"No big deal." He sat down and took a sip of his drink. "So what do you think?"

"About what?"

"Gabrielle."

"She seems nice enough. Does she like making dinner for you? She didn't appear to like it."

"She's just that way. She's French."

I pulled out a cigarette and smoked. "She has an attitude."

"Yep, that's the way I like them. But she's not a bitch to me, just to everyone else."

"Well, I hope she's not like that to me."

"She won't. I told her not to."

We sat back in our chairs and she brought in the plates of spaghetti. She sat next to Nick. He ate and spoke between bites.

"How's life with Gale?"

"It's okay, better than living in the city."

"Especially with Rhindy, eh?" He turned to Gabrielle. "It was a good thing he got out, I was beginning to worry about him, he was starting to lose his mind. You disappeared good, I had a lot of trouble finding you."

I took a bite, the meal didn't taste half bad. I had some bread. "I appreciate it Nick, you're a hell of a guy."

"Don't I know it." Gabrielle nudged him with her elbow, he stiffened up. I smiled to myself.

"Got some news, Chris, I'm getting my '57 back on the road again."

"What made you decide to do that?"

"I saw this flier at the high school, there's going to be a car show and I figured I can't miss it, got to bring the old beast back."

Nick had blown the engine in his Plymouth several months before, I knew with his ineffectual mechanical abilities coupled with a lack of ambition, the old car would never see the road again—unless, of course, I helped him put it together. I didn't mind the task, it made me feel useful, that I could actually do something constructive instead of destroying everything. I couldn't, however, see a time frame of when he expected to have the heap working; his eyes asked me to volunteer my services. I wasn't about to.

"Sounds like a good idea, Nick." I finished my plate and sat back in my chair. He had a smug look on his face and didn't finish dinner. Gabrielle, who had been nearly silent the entire time, made herself busy cleaning up our places. Goddamnit, Nick, I'm not going to do every fucking thing for you as you expect me to. My life is complicated enough without having to worry about your car repairs. Look, I'm having to put up with Gale's shit, her fucked attitude, her head games and lusty affairs with her magazine men on nights when I needed to talk about my problems. I was there for her when she was going through her ordeal with the ex-boyfriend. She never repaid the favors I bestowed on her and had absolutely no consideration for me when I was going through tough times. She would blow me off, pay no attention, and whine.

"Life is tough, dude, you have to learn to live with it."

That's it. That's fucking it. Not an iota of empathy—nothing. Maybe she had another date that night and couldn't stand to listen. Maybe she had no compassion for others. Maybe I stuck my neck out too far by asking her to understand. I was barren, naked, newborn, in a strange place surrounded by strangers. They coat me in oil and tell me to get through life without injuring myself; little do they know I was dead before I was born. With such a birth my attitude followed: Life as I knew it was a mild form of hell, a purgatory where I was destined

to suffer. I was one demon out of nine—a devil—a variety of god that had not shown itself for an eternity. I wanted the peace of death or the tranquillity of another world—whichever was more appealing. But I didn't want to have to put up with people, be kind to them by helping them out only to have my affections stamped no deposit, no return. It unnerves me, Nick, that you sit there with such a smug look and expect me to help you without any effort on your part. I'm not going to do it and I'll tell you why. I'm tired of working to an end that leads to a dark cavernous catacomb, I'm tired of looking at the weathered faceless statues that litter the twists and turns of the labyrinth. They remind me too much of the people I have met and come to know so well. . .but you know what? Sometimes when I get desperately lonely, I wrap my arms around one of the stone figures and freeze my skin, hoping for some warmth to emanate from them. I'm not asking for much, just a trickle of heat to let me know there is something in there, a tiny fragment, a shred of human compassion. I embrace these things time and time again hoping and believing that some good will come of it, that I will be reassured that life is worth continuing. No, no, no, no. So don't give me any of your bullshit, Nick, I have no tolerance for it. I defile and have been defiled by people like Gale, Azlya, Rhindy and others; they have corrupted me, made me cynical and weary of any smidgen of commitment or dedication. I have lost my purity; I have become tainted so I appear to be pretending to be something or someone else. . .

Gabrielle brought some dessert. I had a piece of cherry pie. I stared at it and watched Nick eat his. She went back into the kitchen.

"Great cook she is," I poked my fork into the side of the pie and folded out some candied cherries, they rolled out in clumps of red gel. I set my fork down.

"Thanks for the dessert but I'm full." She came out of the kitchen.

“You don’t like it? You must. It’s a fitting end to dinner.”

“No thanks, I couldn’t eat another bite.”

“Fine.” She sat down and didn’t look at me. Nick stared off and continued to eat, apparently he didn’t mind the gritty texture of the seemingly carefully prepared confection. I felt tired and wanted to go home and sleep. It was nearly eight, a little early for sleep and too late for a nap; I wanted to be away from Nick’s watching his newest girlfriend shovel food into her mouth. I was beginning to see an ex-flame manifest herself in Gabrielle’s place, a ghost I did not care to see pending an uneasy stomach. It wasn’t a reflection on Nick, but the women he chose to date were not in the best taste; like the inanimate pie on the plate before me, she was gelatin, congealed—soft but firm. I never liked gelatin.

We sat in the living room; she was close to him, he didn’t seem to mind. As time moved on and the conversation dragged, she began caressing him. They started talking to each other; I pulled out the envelope that was in the mailbox today and looked it over. I studied it carefully wondering if I had correctly guessed who it was from.

“What’s that?” Nick asked.

“A letter from an old friend, I think.” I looked at Nick and caught Gabrielle’s stare, her eyes were trying to tell me something; she was yelling into my head, hollering for me to leave. She wanted Nick to herself now and I had become a nuisance. I wanted to be angry but lately I’ve had my fill of it, I smiled lightly and left telling Nick I would call him soon.

There was a note from Gale tacked to the refrigerator that said she was going to spend the night with one of her newspaper lovers—a rock sat in the pit of my stomach. I had hoped that, with all my recent revelations, I could tell my story to flesh and blood, but, as usual, it was too much to ask. Frequently in such times, I turned to the typewriter,

it was the only real friend I had and I didn't mind so much that it was inanimate, lately, I find writing therapeutic. Soon I would have no use for Gale and that would be a wondrous day when she discovered it.

She liked to complain that I spent too much time alone, I wasn't trying to fulfill the debauched life we had agreed on. I told her I needed to settle first, get comfortable, and then I would work on it. Not once did she believe me; soon I would be spending more time with dates than she and she would be feeling like I am now—not a friend around who'll listen to her problems. I wasn't going to do it out of spite, just out of fairness. Only then would she see what things were really like between us.

Things were starting to come back into my life, after the fierce rains, the sun had shone itself down upon me. I felt good, nostalgic, and almost vibrant. The day beautiful, I am free to think and believe in things I want. It's early, I have a cigarette on the deck and absorb the sun; Gale didn't come back during the night and I'm glad she hadn't, I can now enjoy the day. I don't want her hanging over me, complaining that the place isn't clean enough or that she works harder than I, ruining my good mood. I have plenty of things to think about without her adding to the list. Things like the letter. It seemed my friend was trying to track me down for what reason I know not; people of long ago were trying to find me—friends and lovers—wanting me to spend time with them. Perhaps they sensed the turmoil I had recently gone through, felt my anger and resentment, and knew the changes I had commissioned. But then again I really had no idea.

The evening at Nick's left me pensive, disillusioned, and a little pissed. I went out for a walk, the one I wanted to take yesterday—downtown was my destination. People aimlessly wandered the almost immaculately clean streets; the planted trees showed their green, the flowers neatly tended, the grass in the park painstakingly mowed. There

was one bum and many snot-nosed pseudo-intellectual rich people. They must have come out of the hills, the streets were littered with them on this hot morning; they stride into candy stores, wig shops, and hair salons. One woman in white slacks and a flowered blouse has just come out of one on Third Street, she's patting her white hair and glancing in every store window along the block. She stops at one pane of glass and picks at her hair, I pass her and light a cigarette, she glares at me. Oh, that's right; in these peninsula towns, it's unethical to smoke. Forget the crime and illiteracy that stalks the surrounding area, shoot the people who smoke, they're easier targets. I took a deep drag and subtly released it in her direction. I remember hearing on the radio Walnut Creek has banned smoking anywhere in town. I suppose when you get your big money, you get self-righteous and start wanting to manipulate those not as well financed as you. Me, I had ten dollars in my pocket, was only interested in getting a haircut and didn't give a damn what others did. I only found fantastic perm shops, gave up on getting a haircut, and settled in the park near the post office. A man was sitting alone reading the paper and smoking; I felt at home, no frosted albatross would glare at me here.

I extracted the letter and held it in my hand. I turned in over to try to catch a glimpse of the writing inside—the address was typed. Giving up on trying to guess, I ripped the envelope open. The writing was very familiar, it was from Jon Tyler, a friend from the East days nearly six years ago. I figured he must have something important to tell me.

“Chris:

Long time, no hear. Finally tracked you down, got your address from your parents. What have you been doing? I've been good. I'm in California now, in San Rafael. Give me a call when you can, let's get together.”

Jon

415-737-0137

The letter was brief, he hastily signed his name and scribbled the phone number. I lit up a smoke. This was strange, my friend from years ago tracking me down; I felt weird since he didn't give a reason for writing me. We've been trying to disappear from each other for such a long time now, it had been a competition for a while—why this sudden communication? I sighed heavily, he broke the deal. There was this challenge between us, ever since we were teenagers, to see who could do the better job of vanishing. It was easy to find him, he had always lived with his parents; I had moved to Rhode Island, then to California, hid in San Francisco, and now was in San Mateo—it seemed that I had won. But he had found me. I took a long drag and held the smoke in, I released it slowly and looked around me. It was still sunny although a few clouds were rolling in. I wished I had some paper with me, my best thoughts always occurred when I was away from the typewriter and without a pen a paper. Thinking of the past and how easy it was in youth—I was healthy, ignorant, and melancholy. I hoped I had gotten over most of the misanthropy by channeling it into writing but I couldn't forget the people I had come to know.

She's standing before me wrapped in a bed sheet; it's dark and she's chastising me for being so immature and weak. I smile gloatingly at her, impervious to her insults.

“You always try to make me pity you, you're so sickly, you don't deserve anything out of life, not the least bit of success.” She flutters the sheet around her, she's burning up, near the point of combustion from the heat of anger and resentment. She will explode at any moment. Around her I see the universe, far off worlds where I have been; trees, field grasses, rusted automobiles, and endless blue skies reaching beyond

the horizon. I wonder if she has anything good to say about me, if I write well or was a hack—she'll probably invest more in the hack because it was more convenient. It matters not. This woman wrapped in cloth, she's not at all like the woman I dream about; Anna can put up with me, likes my company, is crazy and compliments me occasionally so I won't fall into despair—she cares. But what do I know? Perhaps I'm just an irresponsible writer listening to the wrong people and refusing to feel good about myself, hmm. . .that's what she likes to think, she wants me to be weak so she can continue to degrade me. Sometimes I find I act that way because I'm lazy and don't really care; yes, she's so damn mature and like a rock, she needs no one this woman wrapped in a sheet—not even me. She has no heart, she extracted it long ago; one day she may grow a new one and start to feel, but for now she won't. One thing though, I promised myself that I wouldn't end up like her hating everything around me, doing exclusively what I wanted and expecting everybody to be like me. I wanted to tell her, scream at her that the whole scenario was a bust and there was no way I would be like her—if only I could find the proper words.

I got up and wandered, my stomach was growling at me; I had a few bits of cereal this morning but it hadn't sated my appetite. I thought of buying something since I did have ten dollars but I could eat the canned stuff at home and save the money. There I had a selection of ravioli with a side of bread, a can of soda, and some mandarin oranges. That sounded good but the day was so nice, so warm, there wouldn't be many more afternoons like this feeling no pressures or responsibilities, not having to please anybody—just live. On days like this when I feel good, I like to think about earlier times and the future, how I wouldn't mind saving up some money and moving back to the East coast just for the hell of it. To get the memories out of my system and absolve my being from the tragedies of life.

I talked myself into having a late breakfast in a small cafe wedged in an alley. The meal was sparse and only cost two-fifty but it did the job of quieting my stomach. I was still wishing for some paper. A well dressed woman in a business skirt and jacket was sitting at the table next to me; she took small bird-like bites, ate the eggs ever so gently as if not trying to injure them, not breaking the yolks. She took equal care with the bacon and toast. I sat back in my chair and started to pull out a smoke; I noticed a sign tacked to the wall, it was a sketch of a large billed bird surrounded by a red circle with a line drawn through it; it read No Puffin. How cute. The establishment was concerned with the average patron's health, they had to protect the masses from the dangers of second-hand smoke. By not lighting up I felt a deep contentment that I was not endangering others. I thought about Walnut Creek and the ordinance, I think I'd hate to live there but it would just be a matter of time before this town adopted it. The population is so helpless, they needed so much babying. Their meager lives needed to be controlled.

The woman in the suit looked at me a couple of times, the unlit cig was dangling from my mouth; she was trying to figure me out—I was wearing a tie and fordora. She probably thought I was an office worker in town but picked up the artistic influence in me. I must've confused her, and the cigarette. . .

She didn't say anything to me, got up, and left. I watched her leave. She strutted and glanced at me as she put her back to the door. I suddenly became turned on by her aloofness, it had been some time since I had thought about fucking. When I'm hungry or miserable, I think about eating, when I'm sated I think about sex. I got an erection, the first one in several days. I thought of being on top of Gale driving myself into her, I thought of Azlya, penetrating her, feeling her wetness on me. I thought of Rhindy and how I used to have constant sex with

her. Gale said she didn't like sex but I wouldn't let it wear on me. I thought of answering an ad in the personals, I played with the idea of placing an ad myself. The idea always seemed stupid seeing the main problem was how I would describe my physical and mental attributes; I was good at writing fiction—telling lies—but when it came to the truth about me I couldn't do it. . . I couldn't move my pen.

I went back to the apartment a little later and phoned Jon; I stopped myself three times in the middle of dialing. I didn't know what to say to the man, it had been years. He picked up on the second ring.

"Huh, hello?"

"Jon, it's Chris."

"Chris," there was a long pause. I paced rapidly, my hands moist; I had second thoughts about having called him, perhaps the letter was sent by mistake or was a joke and Jon didn't know what the hell was going on.

"Chris?. . ."

"Chris, the letter, Chris."

"Oh, shit I'm sorry. I didn't recognize your voice."

Yeah right. If there was one thing I remembered clearly about Jon, it was when he was stoned his social skills were shot to hell.

"How are you, Chris?"

"Good, I'm good." I let out a sigh drawing a blank on what to say next. The line was silent for a minute then he burst in.

"I'm still in school, in Iowa, doing good, well, not that good, but good enough."

"That's good, good to hear, at least you like it."

"Not really, my parents want me to go and I'm not sure if it's worth it."

"Why's that?"

“Well, it’s sort of like this. You know I’ve never been the model son, that was my brother’s job. Still, my parents expect something out of me, I can’t see why. They compare me with my brother and when I fall short, they insist on trying to reform me trying to find the teensy bit of a redeemable quality in me. They think something’s wrong with me. I think they’re full of shit. It’s annoying when you try to disinherit your parents but they won’t let you go. They want a piece of me, they want me to be like them—worth my weight in gold. Yeah, I know it’s all that family pride shit but I can’t help but see my father only looks at me in terms of dollars and cents; that he’s invested all this money in me over the years, the diapers, the clothes, toys, school, car, spending money, and now college. They have their hooks in me, I’m cornered and going crazy.”

I heard him inhale and exhale quickly. Must be some dynamite shit he’s smoking for him to spill his guts like that.

“Then why don’t you leave?”

“Impossible, utterly impossible,” he hacked. “Life is too easy here, they pay for everything, food, car, money, I don’t even have to work. I’ve lived in the worst parts of Des Moines, downtown, the suburbs, an apartment by the rail yards with bikers revving their motorcycles at all hours of the morning. I’ve worked fast food, done simple office work, even was a counselor—yes, they hired me as a counselor, for retarded people. It’s hard out there, fucking impossible with all the stress, it’s nice to think that you’ll always have a warm bed at mom and dad’s—with three squares a day and snacks in between.”

There was another long silence and another exhale, he coughed. I heard him cupping his hand over the receiver, talking with someone.

“My girlfriend needs to use the phone.”

I sat on the floor shaking my head. “Okay.”

“Let’s see, what time is it?”

“Almost three.”

“Come up here, you can stay the night if you like. My mom’s making a killer casserole. Thursday is killer casserole night, it’ll be good. I’ve got some green bud you have to try and I haven’t seen you in so fucking long.”

“Yeah, we should have lots to talk about.”

“Get your ass here by seven, that gives you four hours. You up to the mission?”

“Sounds good.”

He gave me some questionable directions. “See you at seven.”

“Yeah, bye.”

I hung up, parted the curtains, and stared down at the apartments around me. I saw the buildings outstretch as far as I could see, they appeared as one huge complex where every person in the area was crammed into and forced to live by someone else’s decree. I could hear their screams as clear as the music on the radio behind me; they faded in and out.

A song came on the radio, a song I had dedicated to Rhindy years before, it said what I couldn’t and possibly never would. I wanted to kick myself for living in a strange place with a woman who was becoming stranger by the day; we were slowly learning the clever art of intense hatred, of head games, letting our collective negativity manifest itself in the most creative ways—and where would I be instead of here? I didn’t want to answer that. What else would I be doing? Probably in an old rut, taking the easy road, like Jon, having someone else dote over me. The picture was becoming fuzzy, the brown rooftops of the complex mixing with the leafy trees growing all about it. The green dominated; the trees were shutting out the remainder of the landscape, they were taking over my view of the world.

There are pines, the odor of their sap choking my sinuses; they line the sides of the road. I can hear the whistle of the wind through their needles as I drive by. I'm in that old black Buick again, driving endlessly to a destination known only to my subconscious mind; I am somehow communicating with the car, giving it direction and speed but I don't know where I'm at or where I'm going. I know the car, I've dreamt about it many times; whenever I'm at odds with the world, it picks me up and takes me to a place where I can relax. I'm not sure but I think I feel something for the elder machine, something that can be defined as love, in a sense. Yes, there are the stories about man/car love but I found it wasn't as simple as that; I didn't love the machine for what it was but more along the lines of what it represented, how it often came to my mental rescue. I respected it; it had weathered the years, survived and was determined never to die. The drive continues, the top is down, I am sitting comfortably under the sear of the hot sun; the warm breeze tussles my hair. I stare down the road and watch it curve before me, the yellow lines fade into the beaten grey of the road, my sight becomes a blur.

The drive to San Rafael went a little faster than I had anticipated, the bridge traffic was light, the evening was pleasant. Jon was out in the yard when I pulled up and parked in the driveway; he looked at me with astonishment and then to the car. I shut it off and got out.

"Cool Pontiac!" We stared at each other for a long moment then shook hands. "Good to see you." He looked at the car again.

"Can't believe you still have this old heap. We did so many crazy things in this car. I remember the first night when I first rode in it, it was the first time I was in a convertible. Shit, that was a long time ago. "Come in."

I followed him in. As I said hello to his father, I had a sudden recollection of a time about six years ago when I was blamed for Jon's

behavior problems; they said I was a bad influence and that he should not be friends with me. I had introduced him to the benefits of smoking pot but what followed wasn't my fault. I didn't know why that thought should strike me now, I found it hilarious that I still had a memory of it. I passed the feeling off trying to keep my spirits high.

"Dinner should be ready soon," Jon said to me and he took me on a tour of the house. It was grouped with others in a gated community each exactly identical to the other, haphazardly sandwiched together; the inside being similar save being symmetrical. I smirked and we sat down in front of the television. Jon and his father sat opposite to me, they began quizzing me about my family and my life. I answered the questions mechanically and without much thought or concern.

I fantasized about writing, writing something wondrous that would make the whole world notice, the great American novel—if there was such a thing then I had to find it, to write it, to have it read and appreciated. It's that, the appreciation aspect that was the hardest to attain. Sure I can sit at a typewriter for twelve hours a day, press the keys and get a piece of writing filled with words; pages and pages of words—words, words, words—but is that going to net me the appreciation I desire? Will that make me happy? It was bad enough having to discover truths about Azlya and Gale, but will it follow the same in writing? Will I quickly be discouraged and not write ever again? I wanted to know what life had in store for me, what fate wanted of me. Did I do something wrong in a past life, some horrid crime; was I now paying for it by possessing a confused life, difficult perceptions, and a continual bombardment from ghosts of the past? I looked to Jon and his father; the years had taken toll on their faces, I knew that things don't stay the same no matter how much you want them to. They were out of the dark past and came to me without warning—I tried to remember that, I was the one who successfully vanished—they were

the ones who had trouble dealing with the past, they had the problems that needed to be resolved, not me.

After dinner, Jon's parents went out to a movie. He and I went to his room, he put on a tape and pulled out a baggy.

"It's good stuff, I think you'll like it. Oh, I'm sorry, you still smoke, don't you?"

"Yeah although it's a little late to ask."

"Social faux-pas, I'm full of them."

"As I remember."

He filled up a pipe, took a hit, and handed it to me; I sparked in and inhaled deeply. We finished it and he filled another; he stared off collecting his thoughts.

"Do you find that some parts of our teenage years bothered you?" He squirmed. "I mean, do things still get to you?"

"I'm not sure what you're driving at."

"Okay, we haven't spoken in nearly four or so years, right? I figured you had gone off to do your thing and left me to mine. Well, I had to live there, in Iowa, for three years longer than you and things changed. The place sort of decayed, lost the mystique it once had. I was getting more depressed by the day."

He took a big hit holding the smoke in for a long time.

"Jon, places never look the same as they did when you were young. You get older and realize things aren't that great, that life sucks but you're stuck here and better make the fucking best of it or get out. It's simple and ironic in that way."

"No, it wasn't like that. It was weird, the place changed. I mean changed."

"What are you talking about?"

"You left right on time," he handed me the pipe. I stared at him, the lighter set to the bowl. I felt as if I was talking to a mirror image

of myself, that from where I was sitting, I was looking at the part of me that would have been if I had not moved to Rhode Island in 1987. I was having a conversation with an image from an alternate dimension, it had grown independently of me, time had weathered it, beaten it, made it weak. It was trying to tell me something, the point of which I could not fathom. It craved my attention, wanted desperately to make it a part of my soul once again—to be reunited. I refused; I had learned (for the most part) to live without my past, to not dwell on the tragedies that scarred the living hell out of my double. I became nervous, I knew Jon was going to exhume things I didn't want to think about. His expression said it all.

“Chris, do you know what happened when you left? What happened to Sheri?”

I took my hit, it was too late to stop him. “Yeah, I know. That was almost five years ago.”

“Five years exactly on July 16th. I suppose you got over it, for some reason I never did. Now that I'm talking to you, the intensity has lessened but when I'm alone, ooh, it's harsh.”

“What?!”

“I went to school in a different city, Des Moines, and won't go near where we grew up on the other side of the state. I won't even say the town's name, it's so strange.”

“Sioux City? I think you've lost it, Jon.”

“Don't tell me what I've lost, you weren't there! You don't know what happened.”

“Yeah, Sheri died. Jon, friends die, it happens. I don't mean to sound cold, but. .”

“She died horribly mangled in a car wreck, died instantly they said. Did she really die like they say or did she suffer?”

“I have no idea.” I let out a long sigh and angrily shook my head. “I don’t want to think about it now. Besides, you never went out with her.”

“Yes I did.”

I reeled back and glared at him.

“I know I never told you, we were almost to the point of getting married. See, she was. . .”

“You never mentioned this. I thought we were to be as honest with each other as. . .”

“She was pregnant, by me.”

I put my hand over my eyes. “Oh shit.”

“Now maybe you understand.”

“You’re parents know?”

“I’m not telling them shit.”

“Jon, I’m sorry. . .”

“Please, Chris. The years have lessened the pain, I’m comfortable with it now, I needed you to know, that’s all. I needed to tell someone.”

“Holding it inside seemed to drive you a little crazy.”

“Not only that, but what happened later, after the accident. Two weeks later, on the 31st, I saw her again. I was out driving alone, I can’t remember what I was doing or where I was going, I was upset and I saw her, I fucking saw her.” His hands were shaking and his eyes darted around. A chill went down the length of my spine, there was something in that head of his, something so intense it had driven him to the end. He cleared the pipe and set it on the bed.

“I was driving along Lakeport Avenue and just past the cemetery I saw somebody walking back and forth across the street. The closer I got, the quicker the figure paced. You’ve got to understand, Chris, maybe people in San Francisco jog back and forth across the road at three in the morning but it just doesn’t happen in Iowa. I was alone,

there wasn't another car on the road, I slowed and as I approached, the person stood on the side of the road and waved their arms. I stopped. In the glare of the headlights, they walked to my window. I started to roll it down but as my eyes adjusted to the darkness, I saw that the person was female, and not only female but Sheri! As soon as I realized that, I panicked, dumped the clutch, and let the tires scream. She smacked her hands on the window and yelled out. I tried not to hear but her voice was clear.

‘Jon, don’t leave me alone. Please help me find our child.’

I drove away so fast, hitting ninety, as fast as the car could go, until I got home. It freaked me Chris, seeing her like that, in the middle of the night, on that road, like that. She was supposed to me dead, buried in the cemetery I passed. Dead for Chrissake!!!”

He caught himself and calmed down. His voice was even.

“That wasn’t the only time I saw her, I saw her four or five times more. I even think I had a conversation with her toward the end of her appearances. But I couldn’t take it, she was supposed to be dead and I didn’t know why the hell she was haunting me. She said she had talked to you over the phone the night before she died. Why wasn’t she haunting you? I know she loved you more.”

I reached for a cigarette, the lighter shook in my hand. “Would it make you feel better if you knew I had seen her a couple of times myself?”

“So you did see her. When?”

“The last time was about three years ago. She stood outside my window at my parents house and waved. I saw her twice like this. The second time she touched the hood of the Pontiac and vanished. Those were the only times I ever saw her.”

“When was this?”

“June ’88.”

He stared off engrossed in thought. He rubbed the side of his head. "I think that was the last time I saw her too. She was in my room and I talked to her, I was fucked up. It was the tenth, yeah. I wrote it down, I think."

I swallowed hard and rubbed the back of my neck. I hated talking about things like this, it made me depressed and overwhelmed. As soon as I felt I had conquered my own past, it sneaks up and gives me more information to process. Jon rifled through some papers and not finding what he was looking for, sat expressionless. I sensed he felt better having got his pain off his chest. I wanted to smile but didn't.

"Life is strange and death is equally mystic, it is the abyss that swallows everything." I told him.

"You know, Chris, being alone a lot gave me the time to think about what was happening around me. Yeah, I may be an emotional wreck, and maybe I take too many drugs and maybe I suck as a son, but I feel I've reached a sort of understanding about myself, you know. Now, I don't think she was really after me in the sense of the word. As a spirit, she needed to hold onto something familiar she remembered in life. She died so horribly, she needed to believe she was still alive, now I wish I hadn't driven away like I had. But you want to know what I think?"

I shook my head and shrugged my shoulders.

"I think she loved you more than anybody else in her life. But you abandoned her, left her, and you still do it to this day."

I bit the inside of my cheek. "What makes you say that?"

"She said you did. She was devastated when you moved and never wrote her."

"She told you all this."

"We had long conversations before and after she died."

I put my face in my hands, it was getting to be too much to talk to him, he wasn't making sense and I didn't want to listen anymore.

“Yeah, okay. Hey, Jon, speaking of conversations, I’m getting tired of this one. Either talk about something else or I’m leaving. You’re talking fucking crazy.”

He looked down at the carpet, this mirror image of me mixed with the insane ranting of one Jon Tyler. What the hell have I gotten myself into again?

“I wrote you because I thought you could understand. I just wanted you to know what happened to Iowa after you left.”

“We never talked about Iowa, only Sheri. . .and you.”

“Yeah, I guess so. But I felt this need to warn you.”

“Of what?”

“You should be careful, I think Sheri’s going to come back one last time to be with you. She said that one day she would and nothing would stop her, not even death.”

I felt cold as if the air conditioner had just blasted on behind me. I shivered.

“Shut up, I’m leaving.” I stood and he grabbed my arm.

“Stay for a second longer, let me finish, please.”

I sat back down, he continued.

“It’s just a warning, I don’t know what you should expect. Let me ask you something. Have you been feeling miserable, vulnerable, living in an intolerable situation where you feel weak and you’re crying out for some sort of savior?”

I fixed my stare on him. I hadn’t told him a damn thing and he already knew what things were like. I gave him the benefit of the doubt.

“Maybe.”

“Do you feel you’re being driven by the times, doomed to a life of doing nothing?”

“Wait, what are you saying?”

“Am I right?”

His accuracy was scaring me. "Perhaps."

"She's wearing you down. That's how it starts."

I looked out the window. "I will admit things have changed, but it's not that bad."

"Chris. . .Chris, look at me. Be aware that Sheri is trying to make you feel your life is shit. So by the time she comes, you're ready to leave this place and go with her. More than anything she doesn't want to be alone, she wants somebody to make the journey with her. She's tried to convince me many times to commit suicide but I wouldn't. You must be strong."

I pulled away from him, I raised my voice.

"You're not making any fucking sense. When you're dead, that's it—blammo! You go on and don't bother with this fucked little world, I'm sure there are better things somewhere else, haven't you though that maybe she was wishing us good-bye in 1988? That she was going on to a better place. You didn't think of that, did you? This other Sheri you're talking about is some sort of demon you've created in your head and I won't be a part of it. Fuck you and all your worth, which doesn't amount to shit. I can't believe I sat here and listened to this garbage. What's your game, Jon? Tell me now, what are you trying to pull because I'm not in the mood for it. It's getting late and I've got to get back home, I've got things to do."

He started to say something then stopped, he slumped back on the bed and looked at the floor.

"Sorry, I was only trying to help."

I grabbed my coat and left the house. He came out and looked at me, his eyes filled with tears.

"Sorry if I made you upset, I only needed to talk to a friend and you're the only one I know. Don't be angry, just keep in touch."

I watched him go back into the house and close the door behind him. I fired up the car and headed for the freeway. Along the way I realized that I wasn't living with Rhindy, that I was independent and living on the peninsula, surviving by my own vices and proud of my accomplishments no matter how meager they seemed. Jon's speech tugged me, at times I felt there was a force looming behind me, more so since I left Rhindy but I couldn't let it get to me. I had to exhibit strength with everything in me; I had to fight the odds and not slump to any destructive powers that soon would notch themselves in my vulnerable psyche.

Chapter 6

I let a couple of days pass without incident; time progressed rather quickly. I attended classes and found a job in a bookstore, saw a few friends, and prayed life would ebb on without any end in sight. I spent more time on the typewriter and on the phone; I talked to anybody I knew or had known. One of them was Theresa, an ex-girlfriend I hadn't seen for the better part of a year. She lived a distance away in Modesto and sounded happy to hear from me, we agreed to meet each other later in the week when she would be in the area. As a part of her job, she had to make frequent trips to Berkeley. Wednesday, we would meet in downtown San Mateo at a little place called the L'Etoile on South B Street; she said she would bring a few interesting things that would entertain me.

I sat down later in the evening hoping to type out a few passages that I could structure onto a larger body of work; some redeemable paragraphs that had the potential to be made into a novel, if necessary. It seemed I was becoming enveloped by the stagnancy of my life with Gale. Whenever she was around, I had absolutely no desire to do anything. She was developing this aura, this bad karmic void that tried to suck up what bits of creativity I had in me. I was beginning to

recognize what it was doing to me and worked against it; by working as hard as I could I was going to beat this thing, this ennuaiatic monster. It was not only trying to make its presence known but take over my world. Gale fed it, kept it healthy and suffered herself, it showed on her face and in her manner; this little beast was on its way to dominating the whole scene. So why don't I get out? Good question. But in some ways I hoped I was wrong and only writhing in paranoia. I figured I could return to Rhindy, she'd most probably welcome me back but that wouldn't do any good—I would have regressed, in the same trap without having learned anything. There was an alternate solution to this problem but I hadn't found it yet. Perhaps Gale was going through a phase and would snap to her old self, perhaps not; or maybe I was on a road to hell, maybe on a path of growing out of my old ways, and maybe I was fulfilling some necessary process of my destiny—then again maybe I was merely losing grips and living in a constant state of melancholy. I had no idea but was quickly gaining ground toward new answers.

I met Theresa as per our agreement at the small restaurant; we had a drink apiece but didn't stay for dinner, she talked animatedly and smiled often.

"It's been a long time, almost a year. I'm glad to see you. People have been popping out of my past lately, do you know what I mean?"

"All too well." I thought of Jon.

"Mark called last month, then Debbie. You remember them?"

"No, I don't think so."

"They got married. Anyway, how are you? You still with Rhindy? How is she?"

I lit up a cigarette and offered her one, she crinkled her nose and shook her head. "Well, I moved out, I live in San Mateo, on Bellevue Street, in a complex with green carpet and mobile imprinted wallpaper.

It's not too bad if you can stand the moaning and fucking sounds coming from downstairs or the grating voice of the guy next door as he sings in the shower."

She laughed. "Sounds like an interesting place, I have to see it sometime."

"We're not that far, would you like to see it now? My roommate shouldn't be there, at least she'd better not be." I looked at my watch. "I think she has a date and she usually stays the night when she does, the place is ours."

She finished her drink. "Sounds like an idea, besides, I've got a surprise."

"What's that?" I put a smile on my face, I knew that when Theresa had a surprise it was usually a good one.

"C'mon, I'll show you."

I paid the tab and we walked to her car. As she opened the door I noticed she had a video outfit in the back seat. She smiled.

"Remember the video camera?"

I nodded. Yeah, I remembered the camera. With it, it was possible to see on a screen, those hidden little crevices where all the sex action took place. I got an erection thinking about the things we had done with the camera and all the things we could do. We drove separately and arrived at the same time. I gave her the tour. She thought the place was "quaint". I told her it was annoying; she said it was "nice". I told her it was horrid, she said I was still "a hopeless sociopath". I couldn't help but to agree with her.

"But I'm getting better," I protested.

"No, you're not. You're getting worse."

I had a decent erection when I first saw the video outfit, now that we were alone and engaged in pleasant banter, my hard-on was raging. We set the camera up next to the mattress, put the monitor (so we could

see—live) in the corner and plugged everything in. I could hardly wait. She lay on the mattress and eyed herself in the monitor, she undressed. I stood to one side and took my clothes off; she made a comment about the nice tie I had on, I was glad to have it off; every time I'd look down at it, the stripes would glare back at me.

I settled down on my back, she lay on her side next to me, her breast resting on my chest. Theresa had such nice breasts, they were a perfect 'B' size with cute firm nipples. I cupped my hands around them and drew her lips to mine. She kissed me hard and moved very quickly. She kissed my neck, down my chest to my stomach—she stopped and looked up at me.

"Is the camera on?"

I looked over at it, the red light glowed. "Yep."

"Good, I want to masturbate to it later."

I swallowed hard and she took me into her mouth.

"I love to suck your cock, I love to have you watch me. I love to be watched."

I turned to look at the monitor, it looked great; all my voyeuristic fantasies came to me in a wave. I thought back to when we had first done this, how addicted I was to it. As she stroked me, I let out a heavy sigh. She pulled her head away and came up to kiss me. I lay her on her back; her eyes were glued to the television as I ran my tongue down her. She moaned slightly, as much as I remember, and whispered incoherent phrases. Her taste was salty and the picture was fuzzy; the room was hot, moist, the images of her body and mine became intertwined. I looked up at the eye of the camera, it seemingly winked approvingly at me. Theresa whispered,

"I love being watched. . ."

She whispered again, I hushed her. I covered her mouth with mine to keep her quiet. I climbed on top to fill her; I thrust myself inside, she

was wet, hot, willing, waiting. I was hard, driven, wanting. The monitor displayed me pushing myself into her—my balls striking her firm ass. I looked at her face then to the monitor, my eyes becoming glued to it. She was caught up in motions; panting, moaning, her whispers progressively louder, turning to screams: I was watching and acting at the same time trying to improve the encounter. In a fantasy, I was performing in a film being shown in a red velvet theater on Broadway; I was also sitting near the aisle watching, my eyes fixed to the screen hypnotized by the movements of the players. It was all too real, the heat scorching, my heart beating so hard and fast it might burst out of my chest. I panted, she sighed—sweat poured from our bodies. The dam holding the pressure was detonated; I released, letting the emotion seethe from me. She felt my anxiety and let out a shrill scream.

Darkness folded about me like an old coat that had been hanging in a closet for a long time. It smelled mildewy and putrid, but it was familiar. I felt her breathing under me, short and quick; I heard the hum of the camera and the whistle of the television. On the screen I observed our quiet spectacle; I looked at her, she gazed at me, there was a haze between us.

“Are you going to come soon?” She asked. “Because if you are, change the camera angle so I can see it shoot.”

I did so and reentered her. We had set the mattress against the wall, she was sitting propped up and watched my cock slide in and out of her.

“I want to jack you off when you pull out.”

My orgasm built. It had been awhile so I knew the pure volume of the fluid would make this tape worthwhile for her. I felt compelled to and let her do what she desired of me.

“I’m going to come.”

She smiled and poised her hand near. I pulled out and she immediately grabbed it, directing the spraying come on her tits and into her mouth. It dripped off her tongue and down her throat.

“Yeah, just like old times.” When I had subsided, she squeezed out the remnants of come and swallowed me moaning. In an instant, I thought of smoking but forgot about it.

She sucked my cock until it was completely flaccid, glancing up and me lustfully as if auditioning for a porn—my come clinging to her chin. She played the moment for all it was worth, I was again the victim. But victim or not, I got mine and these days I could really give a shit. She wiped her face clean with my cock, got up and went to the bathroom. She called to me.

“Rewind the tape, could you?” I got up and shut off the camera. She came out with a towel wrapped around her. I sat on the floor. She attended the camera; as soon as the tape was rewound, she sat beside me.

“I like to keep memories, a scrapbook or sorts, that way I’ll never forget.”

“Do you still have the first tape we made?”

“No, I erased it years ago and later regretted it. I was determined that if I had the chance I would make another. There’s something awesome about capturing raw passion that can be viewed later. Don’t you think?”

I stood and put my pants on. “I suppose.” I was only a trophy to her, a sinking feeling set into my gut. I looked at the clock.

“And your cock is the best,” she tugged at it. “I’d like to fuck it again real soon.”

I smiled and went to take a piss. In the time of forever that it took for me to urinate, I figured that Gale should be home soon.

“My roommate should be here soon, it wouldn’t be a good idea if she came in and saw us like this.”

“From what you’ve said, she seems pretty cool, I don’t think she’ll mind, maybe she’ll join in.”

ADD SEX SCENE HERE—THREE SOME WITH ALL THE FEMALE BANTERINGS!

“You have no idea. . .she’ll throw a fit.”

She looked confused then dressed; I packed the video equipment. My anger subsided, I thought of asking her to stay being Wednesday, Gale would most probably not be home. But I didn’t want to ask Theresa just yet, I imagined Gale in her usual manner, barging in and demanding what was going on.

“I’m a little peckish, you want to get something to eat?”

“Peckish? What kind of word is that?”

“It means hungry.”

“Oh. Sure, food sounds good. Let’s go to the city.”

“But let’s take your car, it burns less gas than mine.”

“Yeah, I was surprised to see you still driving that old thing.” We hopped into her car and headed for the city. As soon as we got onto the freeway, she accelerated quickly as if in an extreme hurry. She drove near ninety at times, passing cars in a flurry; I found a metal grip mounted under my seat and was still clutched to it as we exited at Nineteenth Avenue. How I wished I had offered to drive. She slowed at looked over at me.

“I’ve heard of this place on Fillmore near Lombard, it’s supposed to be good. What do you think about eating there?”

I took a deep relieved breath and sat back. “Yeah, okay.”

“You all right? You look a little pale.”

“I’m okay. Just a little hungry, that’s all.”

“Okay.”

There are times when I find myself particularly hungry, there are also times when I don't feel like eating at all; tonight, as Theresa sat across from me, I felt a little of both. I was hungry in the physical sense for food but not so much for the company I found myself with. The sex we had put my randomly thinking mind at ease, I felt at peace with the world and didn't need the company of others; if I were alone at this moment, I could forget about the shit with Jon, the incessant bitching of Gale and the indecision with Rhindy. I was tired of having to wrestle with life, I wished serenity.

Theresa looked so calm in the restaurant, so passive; her expression gave me the impression that she was willing to do anything for me. She daintily took bites from her plate of fettucini—it was so unlike her, so different from the days when we had gone to a crap place like McDonald's or something similar and would wolf down burger after sloppy burger.

"What do you think of San Francisco?"

She eyed me closely. "I've been here many times before, you know that."

Yeah, but what do you think of it now that I'm here, living on my own."

"Same as before, I think it's nice. What are you driving at?"

"Let me put it another way. How do you feel now that I'm not with Rhindy?"

"Oh," she looked down at her plate. "I don't know."

We ate in silence. She had closed herself off, I said something wrong; we had a bitter break-up and she said she didn't want to get into another relationship with me. And I had opened the possibility once again. I wanted to kick myself and fled to the inner recesses of my mind.

I was alone, stranded in a place where fields open vastly all around me; tall grasses stretching as far as the eye can see. In one direction, to the north, I could barely see the outlines of houses; abandoned buildings where no living being had set foot in for at least a decade. No one would bring themselves to be with me where I was—only I was crazy or stupid to choose such an isolation. On one hand, I needed to get back to the land of the living instead of insisting humanity come to me; on the other, why shouldn't I be at least met halfway?

"Well, Chris, I don't know what to say. But I don't think you've changed at all."

I set my fork down. "How do you mean?"

She swallowed a bite of food and fixed her gaze on me. "Years ago, when you were going out with Rhindy and you would drive two hours to my house, I always got the sense you made the journey for yourself, although you said you did it for me. You had this attitude that you expected me to do something special since you went so far out of your way to see me."

"No, I don't think. . ."

"Let me finish. You were so closed off in those days, holding back your emotions. You shouldn't have. You were so cold and distant and now. . .the same feelings are back. After two years, you're still the same. Yeah, you're living alone but nothing has changed. So don't expect me to be so grateful that you are giving me your precious time."

"You're being ridiculous."

"Am I? Think about it. You're extremely self-centered."

I finished my plate and ordered another drink. I stared at her.

"If I'm so much of an asshole, why did you drive all the way out here to see me?"

"I had to drive here for work anyway. Besides, I wanted to see how you were doing."

“And have sex with me.”

The image of me being a trophy assaulted my brain again. She shook her head and quietly sighed.

“I don’t want to get into any arguments with you. I came here to get away for a little while. I came to visit a friend, if you still are one, and not an ex-boyfriend trying to jump into a relationship with me.”

I felt extreme anger, I was not caring if I would ever see her again, in fact, I hoped I wouldn’t. My thoughts were consumed with insults. I didn’t need anybody, I was a loner and a damn good one. As far as I was concerned Theresa, Gale, Rhindy, Jon, and anyone else I could think of could drop off the face of the earth. I was wandering into the darkness at the end of the corridor where I knew there were no doors, no windows, and no exits. All I could think of was, that bitch, that whore, cunt, sleaze, harlot; that slut came here to only use me the prissy whore. The urge to be away from her was so strong I could taste it; I almost burst out in the restaurant, the pressure had built nearly reaching the point of explosion; I felt dizzy, all of it bottled up inside me, the cork shoved into the neck tight. It was tight, very tight and wouldn’t give. I had to be away, to be home, alone; I was deserted, abandoned, living in a state of destitution—decayed, ready for burial by society and the world. The soil was moist, the grave fresh and unfilled, I stood on the edge and peered into it, I could faintly see bottom. The green grasses growing about my feet wrap themselves around my ankles trying to trip me up and have me fall into the ground so faceless mourners could shovel dirt over my body. That way they would never have to hear from me again.

I always tried to separate myself from the world and be totally alone, it seemed no one could accept me for what I truly was; maybe total solitude wasn’t for the best, but to preserve my sanity and temper and to relieve some on the pressure in the bottle, it was the only thing

to do. . .the only thing rational. Life would not be the same from here on in; the world would have to be different when I came out of hiding. I wanted it to be more kind, more forgiving, richer. I didn't want any of the shit that had been clouding my senses for the past few weeks. I wanted life to be free and easy, a place where I could live as I pleased—only when these requirements were met would I ever come out of hiding and function normally.

Night had fallen about the city, the moon rose just above the skyline. I found myself wandering Union Street gazing in the brilliantly lit stores watching people mill in and out. It all was so empty, devoid of any richness, so unlike the world I wished to find myself in. I walked past old Victorian houses converted to bars, coffee shops, and boutiques; past buildings with darkened facades and apartments on the upper level; dark, their windows open, curtains fluttering out in the light breeze of the night. I saw places, their names etched on glass, a large round 'For Sale' sign pasted to the window; their black floors having not seen traffic to disturb the thick dust that covered them. I walked on and on down the street, finding myself in a place, a street, as grey like other places I had visited. It was similar to the streets on Polk or Market or California or even Haight. All were quiet, void of conflict or struggle, passive. . .weak. I remembered Gale telling me I was weak, I laughed at her now. I could name a hundred or so places and people far more helpless than I.

I was smiling as I sat down on a bench in a small grove of four trees planted in spots chiseled out of the sidewalk. The night hung heavy on my soul; I thought about Theresa, Gale, Azlya and my promise to the life of debauchery. It all appeared to be slipping away, I was losing grip and questioned what I truly wanted out of life. I wanted to be myself, express my real nature but I knew I didn't know myself. Did anybody? I remember somebody once telling me there would come a

day when you will look to the sky and ask, why the hell am I here? What the hell am I trying to do? My thoughts were sounding like a bad television show or a broken record. I could see quite a number of clichés forming on the horizon. I thought about Rhindy, how much I had hurt her and how much she had hurt me. Could any of this ever be settled, maybe corrected so that I could actually be proud of myself for having accomplished something I considered good? Maybe. . . maybe not.

The air was getting cooler, I pulled my coat tighter around me but it didn't do much good. The wind picked up. I took a long look at the nearly leafless trees in the parkway, got up and walked back to my car. I passed the shops and bars, some shops were closed and some bars less populated; my thoughts a blank, only gut feelings remained. They told me life was about to get worse, much worse, that I would soon fall into the deepest depths of despair and eventually come out again—when I felt I was ready. They also said I would have to instigate a change in my life if I was to enjoy any measure of success. What type of change, I didn't know—my mind would not interrogate my heart. All I found myself doing was wandering through life, like on Union Street, and living to see what happens not having anything to go on. God, I hated that, not knowing what was coming around the curve, blindly driving in the left lane hoping no one would speed around and lay into me head on. It wasn't a good way to live but there wasn't much I could do about it. I got into the Pontiac and held onto the wheel, I saw the road unfold before me; I felt like driving and driving until I could go no further. I saw many places, revisited many landscapes, railroad yards, and fields of rusted automobiles. I wanted to be in these places but it seemed impossible. I looked at the car's odometer—79,869. A sudden feeling wrenched in my stomach, I saw it turning 80,000 and going not a mile more, not able to take me to the places I so badly desired. I

felt betrayed, the car not wanting to see my peace of mind. But it had not broken down. I turned the key and the motor started. I let out a relieved breath and forgot everything. I put the car in drive and went home.

Chapter 7

Here I am again, lost—a diversion.

I'm walking along an abandoned street. It is late afternoon, and the sun is wrestling with the clouds to shed its rays down onto vacant houses on either side of the street. The buildings are in various stages of decay—some with broken windows, others mere burnt-out shells that were once filled with people who struggled and failed to keep the dwellings that housed them. The air is heavy with moisture. There is no wind; I have difficulty breathing the still air. I look to the sides of the street, trying to figure why the houses were abandoned. What caused the people to suddenly leave? What fate had befallen them?

I meander further up and amble into a small, rectangular park. The grassy area is nearly the length of a block; the houses surround the park, towering over me like monoliths emanating time long passed, forgotten and dead. I search my mind, trying to find the architectural term for a park encircled by a street surrounded by tract-type houses. I can't.

I step into the tall, unkempt grass of the park. I walk toward the opposite corner. I stop and listen—nothing, not even the chirp of a bird or the humming wings of insects. The sun finally breaks through the clouds; it beams down on me. I gaze around at the houses; their glassless windows glare blackly at me. I resume walking. The temperature is increasing. I reach the corner and look down the block; I find myself sweating. In the distance, I see a small theater; it is wedged between houses and seems to be in better condition than the other buildings. I make my way to it. As I come closer, I can read the faded

letters on a sign dangling precariously above the entrance: PARADISE HIPPODROME. I see there were once many lights around the sign, many brilliant colors painted discontinuously about the letters and on the facade of the theater; the colors are now hueless, washed out by the punishing heat and unbearable humidity. Sweat runs down my face and stings my eyes; I have to get out of the heat. At the entrance, the doors are ajar, and only a couple of boards are hastily nailed to the frames. I walk under the awning, stepping on shards of glass that once belonged to advertisements set into the walls announcing the newest feature coming to town. I pull at the boards across the doors, and they come free without much effort. Taking one last look at the scorching landscape, I duck through the entrance—the cool musty air inside is far more tolerable than the sticky air outside.

The light within was faint. I had to rely on the sunlight behind me to illuminate the path of worn and decayed crimson carpet that lay in the long hallway before me. The walls were decorated in lavish red velvet wallpaper and mahogany paneling. I squinted to see the exquisite detail in the paper; I traced my finger along the designs and a cloud of red powder fell on my hand. My eyes became more adjusted to the darkness and I noticed a feeble light ahead of me; I walked toward it, using the length of paneling as a guide. A room opened before me, a large arena with a high ceiling, dangling several crystal chandeliers. Rows of seats stretched out to a greyish screen suspended over the stage; torn scarlet tapestries hung in long strips. The light I had seen was coming from behind the screen; it proved bright enough that I could see what was around me. There was a balcony, but I couldn't see above the baroque paneling that ran along the front of it. The air was cool and settling, with a hint of mildew. I wiped the remaining sweat from my brow, paced down a row of plush seats, and sat in one near the middle of the theater. It was comfortable.

I soon felt tired, as though I had not slept in days. I gazed lazily at the screen; the light behind it faded. The emptiness of the theater settled around me like a blanket, leaving me secure, but also wondering what might lie in the vacant hall, the desolate balcony, or the frayed seats around me. I opened and closed my eyes several times, checking to see if there were any change in the stillness—there was none. I felt at ease. The light behind the screen seemed to become brighter, shining around it; images appeared on its greyish surface. Dusty speakers crackled with distant sounds as they came to life. My eyes focused on the projection and my mind was convinced it was seeing a movie.

A field opens away from you, distant and reaching. The blackened sky touches it on the horizon. You look as far as you can see, and there is nothing, no matter what direction you turn. You are short of breath, swallowing hard—thirsty. A slight feeling of nervousness sweeps over you, but you can't seem to place the source. Why so uneasy? Can it be the landscape you find yourself in? Is it because you know you've wandered here alone and know not how to get back? No one would miss you, you know. So, you relax and let the tension go—breathe.

The stale air chokes you; it is filled with pollen from the tall wheat-like plants that are all around, as far as the eye can see. You breathe again. The air is easier to take in; you find you are getting used to the environment. A light breeze blows from behind; the pollen dissipates, and the plants sway gently. You notice as you look to the horizon that they form a vast wave which seems to hypnotize. You close your eyes. The wind seems to lift you; you feel your feet dragging along the tops of the plants—they strike at your ankles. You're afraid to look, but as the air becomes cold you slowly open your eyes. The ground speeds quickly under you, going by in a blur. You close your eyes again. The wind seems to slow; you stop moving. You're standing on firm ground; the air warms slightly, and the chill leaves your body. You feel around

with your feet, and you can tell you're standing in short grass. Slowly you open your eyes to see where you are. Something dry forms in your throat, and you try to swallow it.

You find yourself in the middle of a cemetery on a hill. The day is bright and the sun beams upon your shoulders. The headstones are glacier white, and the pines growing about the graves are deep green. The sound of crashing waves can be heard in the distance. You walk toward the sound and see the ocean far below. The surrounding hills are barren; only a few scrub grasses manage to survive. You turn and walk back toward the cemetery. You notice the meticulously clipped lawn—whoever did it even managed to trim around the tombstones. The cemetery widens, and in the distance you can see somebody kneeling before an open grave. As you walk closer, you see that it is an old man. His long, thin silver hair waves in the breeze; it seems to hypnotize, like the field grass you saw earlier.

You quicken your pace down the hill. He notices your approach. He gets up and shuffles to a faded black hearse; the old car has running boards and free-standing headlights. He pulls a shovel from the back of the dilapidated machine.

The grave draws you. You peer down into it; a closed coffin lies within. You don't know why you're here or why you're attracted to this grave, but the energy it emanates intrigues you. The old man walks over to you and puts his hand on your shoulder.

“Family?”

You try to read the writing on the stone, but the letters are too faint.

“No, not family.”

You look at him; his features are as weathered and pale as the stone. His eyes are hollow, without a glint of life in them. He stakes the shovel

into a mound of dirt next to the grave. He leans against the handle and looks in the direction of the ocean.

“Died in a car wreck she did. Out on Crystal Springs Road—horrible.”

You quickly look around you, toward the sound of the ocean and the barren hills. You try to recognize the place, but you can’t.

“Terrible when they go so young. . .” You look back at the writing on the stone. The old man starts shoveling dirt into the grave. Your sight catches one engraved word—Anna. Dust billows up and blinds you; you shut your eyes and try to rub the dirt out.

Darkness forms around you; the earth stings your eyes.

I opened my eyes and noticed I was back in the theater, staring at the screen. The lambent light was still there behind the screen. I shook my head and tried to swallow; my throat was parched, my muscles numb. I stretched my legs and felt the heat of blood coursing through my veins. I looked to the ceiling; a large chandelier was dangling just above me, its dull crystals glimmering, catching the light from the stage. I tried to stand, but I couldn’t. Losing my balance, I fell back into the seat. My eyes fixed again on the screen. I felt as though I were in a trance, manipulated by some force that needed to show me something.

The light glowed; the screen faded.

The sun shines blazingly down onto an estate. Your feet are set on a road heavy with dust. You are walking toward the gates of the estate; the paint upon their surfaces is a faded peach. As you walk closer, you see there are letters engraved upon the posts. The characters are fuzzy, unclear, and weathered. You climb up the posts to trace the letters with your finger to decipher the words; the resemblance of these letters to the ones on the tombstone bothers you. But you can’t climb high enough, so you give up and walk through the gate to the grounds of the estate. The road is dry, your throat burns. The sun is blazing.

You continue on.

Your steps are becoming heavier; exhaustion is taking over your body. You reach the base of a long, unevenly ascending hill and put what energies you have left to scaling it. As you walk your eyes are fixed to the horizon; you can see the pinnacle of a roof. Your steps become quicker. As you approach the crest, a house comes into view. It is Victorian in design, and is the same faded peach color as the gates. You kneel for a minute to rest. A light breeze encircles you; it whispers in your ear.

“Continue on. . .”

You quickly scramble up and look around; there is nothing, no source for the voice. You assure yourself that it is coming from the house. You take a deep breath of hot, dry air and resume your pace toward it. The walking seems easier now; the wind cools you. You feel very comfortable, as though you might be able to do anything. The voice has made you confident, proud, almost arrogant. You smile, thinking about the sweet female voice that has renewed your strength. You stride down a long hill and come to a deep ravine. Your confidence doesn’t falter; you keep your quick pace. The washed out gully is deep—it stretches to the left and to the right as far as you can see—but you are so close to the house. Giving up is not an option. You peer down into it; a small pool of stagnant water lies at the bottom sixty or seventy feet below. The sides of the gorge are steep, the walls choked with protruding dried roots of decayed plants. There is no way to cross. You shake your head and sigh loudly.

“Continue on. . .”

You try to scale down; no, it’s too steep. You’ll fall and break your neck. You stand and assess the ravine—nowhere does it become more narrow. The faded peach house looms in the distance; it’s only a ten-minute walk away. You have a burning desire to get to it.

The voice whispers to you.

“Continue on. . .”

You frown, still peering into the gully.

“Forget it.” You turn your back to the house.

“Wait. . .continue on. . .” The female voice is pleasant, she wants you to go on. Her tone is siren.

You huff and bow your head, retracing the way you came. The sun is bright and hot. Your body burns with fatigue and disappointment.

The light on the screen faded out. I was again back in the theater. I had the feeling that something was very wrong. I was being manipulated, and I sure didn’t like it—anger grew inside me. I stretched my legs and stood; the arena was still, as quiet as when I had first entered it. I walked up the aisle to leave, having had my fill of this crazy place. The “movies” left me feeling queasy and light-headed. Keeping my balance was an effort. I parted the dusty red velvet curtains and noticed that the front door was now closed. There weren’t any signs of the boards that earlier had been nailed to the frames. I put my weight against the door and shoved. It didn’t budge.

Somewhere in the dark recesses of the theater, I heard a voice, a woman’s voice. It was the one that had whispered from the peach house. It couldn’t be, I had heard that voice in the film. . . I shoved the door harder. The voice repeated a continuous phrase.

“You abandoned me. . .left me. . .left me. . .left me. . .”

Fear gripped me. The voice was becoming louder, moving closer. I set my shoulder into the door and shoved as hard as I could. Soon I was racked with pain. What had once been a sweet voice was now bitter and vengeful; it moved toward me. It was almost to my ear. I shoved the door one last time; it burst open. I stumbled and fell onto sidewalk. As I was face down on the concrete, I heard traffic passing and people mumbling to themselves—someone nearly stepping on me.

I quickly stood and looked from where I had come. The lights of the Strand Theater beamed at me, with STRAND in blazing red neon letters and LIVE NUDE GIRLS spelled in cool blue. I backed toward the curb. My head was spinning. The doors were shut tight and bore no resemblance to the Hippodrome's—then I heard it.

The disembodied voice was emanating through the crack between the doors. It repeated the same phrase.

“. . .left me. . .left me. . .”

I turn and run as fast as my legs can carry me. I have no idea where I parked the car, but I know it's around here somewhere.

Chapter 8

A few mornings later, the sun shone brightly through the windows, waking Gale and I simultaneously. She squirmed and looked at me; our eyes met for the first time in nearly two weeks—it scared me. I quickly sat up and looked about the room. The phone rang.

It was Gale's mother. She spoke softly and clearly. There was intense anger in her voice. I set the receiver down.

“It's for you.”

“Who is it?”

“I don't know.”

I went back to the mattress and lay down. Gale began yelling into the phone and she slid the door closed to the kitchen. I watched the sunbeams playfully dancing on the ceiling; they formed interesting shapes, mostly indecipherable lines that required a lot of creativity to make them into anything recognizable, but it was fun nevertheless. And that's what had been bothering me lately—here are these lines that to the naked eye are nothing more than what they appear, but to a trained eye, an artistic one, those lines can be put to good use. I could bend them, twist them, have them take any shape I desired and breathe life into them. My mind was the noble creator—if only I could translate

the images into motor coordination to give them substance. I think of so many things that I could do; I could paint wondrous canvases, if only my hands could translate. I could photograph the most breathtaking scenery, if only my eye knew what to look for. I could write the greatest American novel of the late 20th century, if only my fingers could convey the emotion. I lacked in some capacity. I couldn't see my cranial creations to completion—perhaps I was listening to too many people point out what was wrong with me instead of finding strength in my awareness and unity.

I discovered other nagging questions: Am I an artist? Is my job as a mechanic indicative of my true interest in autos? Am I destined to not see anything beyond a collection of unfinished projects and sour memories? And if I am an artist as I think myself to be, wouldn't it be better to expend my energy doing something constructive, instead of lying on this mattress staring at the ceiling? Perhaps I drove myself too hard, with some insecurities thrown in for good measure. I felt there was no way I could write about the sunbeams and their many colors—words are too trite and constrictive—large blocks of twisted, blotted ink, resembling some confused language; painting would be a far better approach. But, hell, it was far too late to start playing with that now, I had ingrained myself in writing for so long—I didn't have the time. Still, the conflict within me was as clear and loud as the argument between Gale and her mother. It was an all out war, with Hades' arsenals at fire, and there wasn't any end in sight. It had dragged on for so long the fighting became innate. The ennuiatic beast that Gale was feeding had grown exponentially, it was swallowing her life, her family's life, and trying to devour mine. One thing, though, had kept me going, keeping me a safe distance from the insatiable monster. It was a simple quote by Fitzgerald: "Intelligence is the ability to keep two opposing ideas in one's head at the same time while able to thrive

on both.” If it were true and I could believe and find strength in it, there was an avenue to beat the hell out of what was after me.

It was Wednesday. The radio died shortly after Gale left for work; I managed to get a few simple ideas written down without once turning on the typewriter, then decided I was too out of it and went for batteries. The trip turned out to be a little longer than I expected, and I found myself heading for the city. The car ran fine but that feeling I had last week returned; I could almost feel the car hesitating on the journey. It would be fitting that my only mode of transportation from San Mateo to the city would give out on me. I knew that if it ever did, I would be fucked, game over, end of program. I would be stuck in the apartment with Gale, having to listen to her incessant ravings, babblings, and bitchings about how life isn’t treating her well and that I’m selfish for asking her to shut up. It would quickly turn into a Chris bashing session, how I lacked far more than her, was a sorry artist (if I was one at all), and couldn’t do a damn thing for myself. Gale was a good liar, a perfectionist at story fabrication, and a gossip aficionado; she possessed a biting persuasion that made you think you were at fault—always. She wasn’t much good at anything else, well, maybe decent at fucking. And fucking is everything these days.

Early fall had come to San Francisco. Nick and I renewed our friendship, spent time again talking endlessly about moot subjects, and gawking at women. We hadn’t seen much of each other since he had Gabrielle and I was stuck with Gale, depressed and all. Now, with Nick, things were starting to look a little different. Life, instead of appearing as an ominous black depth, was taking on a modified shade of grey. I felt alive tapping into energy I had generated in the past while hanging out with him. I was trying to weave the thread from the present to the past, trying to bring my scattered memories up to date. He was telling me a story about a brunette he had met on one of his trips up north.

“You’ve gotta meet this chick, she works in a hardware store, she’s hot.”

I took a long drag on my cigarette as we walked along the beach. The ocean’s waves were crashing against the shore like a woman rolling over me, poising herself just above me, giving that look that she gives. Only such a woman as her with a whole life’s experiences knows exactly what she desired in a good fucking. A kind of woman that I had been dreaming about for as long as I can remember, not the damned Gale or Rhindy “I need the encouragement” line but a full fledged woman without compunctions or hang-ups. The way I figured it, if we were heavy into the act, making out and the like, and she says something like “you’re going too fast” or “I’m not sure if I know what I want out of this relationship”, I had the right to question. Gale, for instance, I remember we made out in my car on a night when the rain poured down heavy. I had known her for almost a year, and up until then, we had done little. She made the moves that my hands were in the right place and that I should continue, so I returned the advances, put my hands on her back and slowly slid down to her ass. It was then she pulled back, looked at me and said,

“You’re going too fast.”

For Christ’s sake, she was sitting on my lap putting weight on a hard on that I believed was my most throbbing to date. Then she said I was going too fast. Both of us were adults—in our early twenties—with our own thoughts and opinionated views on life. It was at that moment I discovered the extreme adolescence in her; she was giddy at my arousal.

I supposed Gale was an isolated case since there were other women who didn’t act in the same manner. I had met others—older women who were the exact opposite—leaning toward the kinky, cheap, and occasionally nasty. And I say that without an ounce of criticism, I support it 100%. If, as a human, you realize life and people finite and

that you might as well be hedonistic, then you have captured the secret of life. To enjoy sex is to live life to its fullest. I felt that I knew what I wanted out of life; I was passing from one pleasing experience to another, elated to meet others of the same caliber.

So now, Nick was telling me about the woman he met up north while visiting his parents. He and I are sitting in a small cafe on the main drag through Berkeley. I'm having a cafe du chocolate and he's sipping a beer.

"This woman, how can I describe her? She was something else, that's all I can say. A great fuck, you have to meet her."

"I need to get a better picture of her in my mind."

"Come to think of it, you're just her type, you two have so much in common. You're perfect." He drank half of his beer, gazed about as if to see if anyone was close enough to hear him. He stuck his head across the table, whispering,

"The things she did. . .she could fuck." He sat back in his chair and had an oafish grin smeared across his face.

"Great, when did this happen?"

"Over the weekend. I went to the hardware store to get some fish bait and there she was. She said she knew me from when I used to race my Plymouth and always wanted to meet me. She asked me out. She had a great ass and tits."

He made a motion with his hands.

"And she was pretty old, too. Guess how old."

"Twenty-seven."

"Nope, older."

"Fifty-six."

"You sick fuck. Not that old."

I smirked and he put his tongue in his cheek. "Thirty-eight, do you fucking believe that? Thirty-eight! She was dirty, it was great. I can't

believe it. On the first date—that night—she went down on me and we ended up fucking in—get this—the cemetery. I should be fucking ashamed of myself.”

I nodded in agreement.

“I drove out there, we had some beers and the radio’s playing. She says, ‘Do you mind if I tell you something discreetly?’ I say ‘No,’ and she says, ‘I really want to have sex with you.’ Shit. Has any woman ever asked you like that? Tops your stories.”

“Sounds cheap,” I finished my chocolate.

“Fuck you,” he falls back in his chair and flips me the bird. “You’re just jealous. I’m the fucking baddest. As always.”

“Whatever.”

“And what about Gale? Now there’s someone I think is dirty and cheap and you’re fucking her.” He laughed, his tumultuous frame jerked. It was my turn to flip him the bird.

“Face it, she’s a thrift-store whore, as cheap as they come. And not only are you FUCKING her, but you’re living with her! Ha-ha!”

I sat back in my chair and looked around. No one seemed to take notice of the increasingly obnoxious conversation. I hailed the waiter for another chocolate. Nick ordered another beer although he hadn’t finished his first one. He continued.

“You remember when you, Gale, and I went driving around in your Pontiac and we stopped at that Arco on Market Street? While you were putting the gas in, she and I were making out.”

“Yeah, I knew that.”

“And later when she and I went out, we almost did it on that hill overlooking the college.”

“You told me this already, this is the third time.”

“I could’ve done it with her, that night. I could’ve fucked her right there.”

“So, what stopped you? Besides the fact you just told me you think she’s disgusting.”

“Exactly. Stanley wouldn’t stand at attention.”

“Stanley, huh.”

“Yeah, Stanley,” he smirked and pointed at his crotch below the line of the table. “Like the power drill. He wouldn’t get excited about going inside her, that’s when I knew she was a cheap slut. It’s a wonder how you can wake up next to that shit much less thinking about fucking it.”

“You’re so deep, Nick. Anyway, that’s not going to go on for too much longer.” The waiter brought our drinks. I sipped the hot, sweet coffee and stared at the wall.

“Go on. Are you thinking of unshacking?”

“Yeah.”

“When’s this going to take place?”

“ASAP.”

“So, Chris is thinking of going indy. Where to? Rhindy? Shit, bad to worse. I don’t know what drives you. First you fuck them then you live with them. The ones I go out with I would never dream of living with them, you can’t trust them. There’s something about them, the way they walk or talk or something. But I must say they’re good for a lay. . .like the one I was telling you about. Her name’s Maggie, you’ve got to see her. She’s good for a lay, check her out and tell me what you think. I’d like your opinion on this one.”

He sat back and eyed me carefully, he was on a roll trying to set me up with this Maggie person. I used to take this treatment as trying to find sex for a desperate man but once he said,

“I know you’re getting it but see it as a favor to me, take her off my hands, show her a good time. You never know, maybe she’ll fall for you. Hell, maybe you’ll go live with her.” He laughed. “You don’t have to fuck her if you don’t want to but I figured since you were a writer

and all, you could get something out of the experience. . .and thank me for it.”

“Sure, Nick,” I wanted to slug him, but something in his wide face and thoughtless eyes convinced me not to. “I’ll take a trip up there one of these days and meet this woman of yours.”

“Go as soon as you can because she’s hot. She reminded me of the women in James Bond books. She had flair and class and came across well, especially so since she was so old. I could tell, she had done a lot. Go and ask her about fishing or something, ask her what is the best lure to use on a day like this and if she asks what you’re trying to catch, look directly into her eyes and say nothing, well, maybe something. . .I don’t know. You’re the writer, you should be able to think of something.”

“Here’s a better idea. I’ll tell her I’m a friend of yours and heard she was a good fuck, that I drove all that way to find out what she was like.”

“There you go. She’d like the publicity and that you’re an artist. She gets off on that weird stuff.”

The more he talked, the more I became immune to his bantering. This experience made him feel as if he were on top of the world, that he had topped my stories. But he wasn’t so cruel, he wanted me to share in the spotlight, but I wasn’t willing. So naive, so immature; if he only knew he was dead, like the rest of us, floating endlessly through the rot and decay of the cities, trying to pretend were unaffected by the wanton abnormalities. The world was a beautiful, serene place to him, a landscape where the sun shined every day, the money flowed freely, and pleasures came easily. He never saw how the dirt slowly collected under his feet, moving up his ankles to his knees, continuing upward to soon engulf him. We were all dead, I sitting on a mound of earth watching the world writhe below. People tried to make something of

themselves, clinging desperately to the marred belief in success creating a small world—a bubble—where they could believe they were happy, destined to live the rest of their lives accordingly. I'm sitting on my throne; I neither help nor hinder the toiling, I am impervious, isolated, I don't give a shit. I am content and that's what is important, content to have the dirt fall through my fingers to the cold ground beneath me. Nick saw numbers, I saw actions. Gale strove to dig a deeper hole for herself, she believed by doing so she could extract some sort of revenge on others. I would stand as she dug, watching the dirt being shoveled—sometimes it was thrown far beyond the pit depending on how much energy she was putting into it. Frequently, she would ask for help. I'd glance at her despondently. She accused me of being lazy and selfish, wanting to sacrifice myself for no one. And, to a point, there was truth in what she said. I felt a little like God at times and a little like Satan; I was both powers wrapped into one, opposite hemispheres coexisting. A world of sex, penises, vaginas, and discharge was what I watched over, a kingdom that stunk of sperm—not an ounce of passion or anything else redeemable lie anywhere. I ruled the machine, the technical aspects of fucking, the physical in and out. I was a foreman in a factory walking through the plant with a clipboard making sure all was in order. I kept the machines working but did nothing to aid in their operation. I came into no contact with them. If something was amiss, I called the mechanic. My duty was to watch the wheels and gears turn round.

We finished our drinks and went walking. The sidewalks were fairly busy with people languidly pacing in one direction or the other, people from all sorts of venues with all sorts of experiences who had more than one story to tell. Nick walked slowly, glancing about him.

“This place looks familiar, Gabrielle and I came here to shop once. She thought it was fun but it’s just like San Francisco. Sometimes I’m so sick of it. One of these days, I’m going to move up north.”

“Yeah, okay.” It was an empty promise to himself.

“That reminds me. Gabrielle’s getting weird, she’s going to move out of her mother’s place and live with some friends. She tell me she needs some time to herself. I don’t know. . .”

“Oh shit. . .”

“Man, she was the greatest in bed, the way she’d be on top of me, her tits bouncing. I remember lying next to her after we fucked for the first time, I looked over at her and thought, ‘I just had my dream woman.’”

“I can’t believe this. What is she doing here?”

I finally had Nick’s attention.

“Who is it?”

“Azlya.”

She saw me, our stares locked. She seemed calm, not as nervous as I was. I stopped walking. She strode gracefully, a smile on her face.

“Hi, Chris.”

“Hi.”

“How have you been?”

“Okay.”

“Haven’t seen you in a long time.”

“It’s been about seven months.”

“I wanted to talk to you about the last time.” She shot a look at Nick. I introduced them. “I’m on my break now, I work down the street at this magazine where they print up papers for the homeless. One of those helping hand things.” She laughed as if she couldn’t believe she was working there. I tried to smile but still was in shock.

“I don’t have time to talk now but I want to. Let me give you my new number.” She scribbled on half of a torn voided check. She suddenly looked up at me.

“I’m having a party at the house next weekend, the 20th, won’t you come? We can talk then. Only if you want to.” She handed me the paper.

“Okay.”

“See you then, or call me. Sorry I can’t hang around. Bye.”

We smiled at each other. She walked between us and I caught a smell of the perfume she was wearing. It was as I remembered it, as if I could forget. My mind was a torrent of images and emotions—the thread successfully connected between the present and the past—I wished Nick wasn’t here. I needed to talk to her now, I didn’t think I could wait. There were so many questions unanswered. What happened to her? What happened to us? Why did she dump me like she did? Apparently she didn’t hate me like I thought she did. After the last argument, I never called her again. And she never called me. It ended like that. I never knew how much I cared about her and how I would be constantly thinking about her still after seven months.

“She’s not bad,” Nick said to me as she glanced back, smiled and disappeared around a corner. “I’d do her.”

He cackled to himself, the sound echoing off the buildings. I scowled at him. His smile was plastered to his face.

Truth, I find, is stranger than fiction. You could sit down with the most creative crowd and ask them to brainstorm out a plot for a novel or screenplay and not even come close to what you could find in everyday life. Characters derived wholly from your imagination would be bland and the plot—you’d bore the reader to tears. You pull from life, from situations you see on the streets or read in the papers, exaggerate just a little bit and bingo, you’ve got something there. Maybe have the

setting even stranger putting it in the most colorful part of town or country, and you've got a Pulitzer Prize winner beneath your fingers. It's hiding within the recesses of the pen or typewriter. For myself, I wanted to be with the oddest, most socially inept people and take them to the most active parts of town and see the reaction—that way I wouldn't have to fictionalize too much. I preferred pure experience without default.

I sat at the desk and scribbled a few lines in a notebook. I tore the page out and reached for a cigarette. More lines on another page, pure experience—outside of the Gale and Chris love/hate relationship—nothing. The torment of life in the apartment on Bellevue Avenue weighed too heavily on my mind—another page torn and thrown into a corner already littered with two dozen balls of paper. I reached over, opened the window, and stared out at the clouded sky. From where I was sitting I could see into a window of a building set close to the apartment. A couple of kids ran from room to room, their mother chasing behind them. One of the kids backed into the window, nearly breaking the glass; a large peel of paint fell from the frame to a tarred roof below. I followed the line of the roof to the fenced yard beside it, pieces of tile and clumps of grass in disarray. Someone at one time had tried to landscape the yard but apparently without much success. There was a broken wall of cemented bricks which formed a little path along the far side of the fence; in that path grew a small evergreen hedge and an old rose bush. A weathered bicycle had been tucked behind the rose bush many years before and the moist salt air had rusted the bike into one solid piece. The grass was tall in the miniature garden—brown and exhumed in several places—the empty patches gave way to several ferns clinging to the brick wall. There appeared to be much harmony in such a decrepit place. The dank sky hung heavy above it, a chilled breeze buffeted the ferns and raced through my

window flipping a couple pages of my notebook—the pen plummeting to the linoleum floor with a sickening clanging steel sound. I watched the pen roll back and forth and looked out the window again. I wished to be free and climb out, then I could explore the tiny area I saw. But it was impossible and I knew it. I was only able to explore with my eye and mind, which seemed to be the only means of travel these past few weeks save the one or two nights when I saw Nick or Theresa. As I sat and stared, I realized that I would have to get used to doing things this way, seeing things in my mind. Say if I wanted to see a part of the city, perhaps south of Market or North Beach, I could only go by way of memories, using my imagination as a guide. I found that I would have to get used to living alone, being totally alone, if I was to accomplish anything; spending hours sitting at the desk in front of the typewriter hammering out a soliloquy that perhaps I would have the ambition to put into a readable work someday. I had to learn to thrive on change and reflection. Well, I had a pretty good start; I had moved away from Rhindy and was living with the most incredibly boring soul who wanted nothing to do with me except argue endlessly about pointless shit, wishing I was nowhere within her sights. Maybe it was a mistake leaving one woman for another keeping living arrangements similar, but I knew I wouldn't be here much longer. Gale seemed to be getting restless again, perhaps she'd go live with one of her many newspaper lovers, or find herself a new sap who'd feel sorry for her and feed her selfish desires. To tell you the truth, I didn't much care what happened to Gale. But I did secretly hope something bad would happen. I was certain it was evil to think in such a manner. Tomorrow. . .tomorrow I would have to go to the housing board on the university campus and find a new place in the city, that way I wouldn't have to rely so much on driving. It sounded like a good idea, but the only snag was that I had to carry it out, and I was feeling particularly lazy. Something

else I seemed to have an abundance of. I looked at my watch, it was nearly seven; I decided to go out and get something to eat since there wasn't anything in the place. Gale had hidden most of the food saying it was hers and I wasn't going to get a scrap of it until I stopped being selfish and started listening to her problems. She wanted not empathy but sympathy, pity; it wasn't in my job description to perform such tasks—so I didn't eat.

I managed myself to sleep around midnight. Shortly afterwards, I dreamt.

Walking along a dusty, abandoned road. The air is hot with no wind—I don't feel the heat. A couple of cars pass on the road, and up on the left I see a small house with a barn. There are two cars sitting in the driveway end to end, the one I see first—a late 40's, peacock-blue Packard—has a large For Sale sign hastily taped to the windshield. As I walk up the drive, I notice it is a convertible.

I hear the door slam at the house. A man came out to greet me, a large man in casual white pants, blue plaid shirt, and white hat. He has his hands in his pockets. He was about five feet six and weighed at least 300 pounds. He walked confidently.

“Yeah?”

I nodded. “This car's for sale?”

He looked to the car then to me. “You gonna buy it? It's a '48, one of the best years for Packard. Nice, huh?”

“A little beat up. . .”

He put his hands in his pockets. “What makes you say that?”

“Well, the paint's faded and the roof. . .” his expression turned harsh. “. . .and, well. . .”

“What do you expect? It's pretty fucking old.” He smiled. “But she runs like a top, I tell you.”

He pulled the keys out of his pocket and got behind the wheel, I climbed in the other side pushing fabric from the roof out of my face. He slid the glowing key into the ignition and turned it. The engine cranked but didn't catch.

"This baby can make all your dreams come true." He turned the key again and it fired to life. "Let's go for a little ride and you'll see how good she is. He set the transmission into 'D' and pulled the enormous car out of the drive into the street. I could barely see over the hood. He stopped and put the top down, the motor whirred pleasantly. A phone rang in the distance, the wind blew hesitantly.

"I trust you, take her out and bring her back when you're ready."

I slid to the driver's seat and put my hands on the wheel. He shut the door.

"Anything you think of. . ." I watched him through the rear view mirror as he went back into the house. As the screen door battled up against its frame, the wind became listless. Laughter roared from the house, I put the Packard into gear and turned onto the road.

The dry air felt good, I flipped a switch and put all the windows down and let the wind rip through the car.

—AD SECTION—Theme of section: A cascade effect was now in process, both our fates sealed and our lives given direction from this time forth. No longer alone to wander in the darkness, she turned, walked down the beach, and vanished.

Chapter 9

It was nearly three weeks into October and I found myself, for the first time, worrying how I was going to pay the rent. Gale insisted I needn't concern myself about it, since we were going to be moving out at the end of the month. But I wasn't too keen on the idea of following her around, living in one place or another with her in all her insane bitchiness—playing the role of her little playmate and resident target

for abuse. Right now I'm not in the mood for worrying. Things seemed to be okay, maybe getting better; my job was becoming more bearable, and I had faith in the future. I wondered if things were turning, that I was finally out of the woods. . .so to speak.

The day was bright and the air was clean, a brisk breeze shook the trees; the scent of eucalyptus hung in the air. I breathed deeply as I walked to my car. It fired right up, and I put down the window. The traffic was light and for the first time in months I didn't purposely slam the car door as I walked into work. Now, I realize I hadn't been at this job for very long, maybe six months or so, but I knew that there was never reason to worry about losing it. I could not show up or forget to wear the proper uniform (disgusting navy blue pants, oil soaked boots and a matching blue shirt with my name tackily embroidered across the breast), and they would still love me just the same. It was a sight to say the least. I kept trying to convince myself that this place was only temporary, a weigh-station, and soon I would have some sort of success where I wouldn't require a job, and move on. I tried to hold on dearly to that way of thinking; the people I worked with only enforced the need to achieve something better. I would be asked continually:

"How long are you planning to stay?"

And I would reply with a simple,

"I don't know."

And that was the truth.

"Okay, so you don't know," a co-worker, Steve, would say. "What the hell do you want to do?"

I smile broadly. "Well, I've always thought of myself as a writer."

Steve smirked. "A writer, huh? Working on anything?"

And that was the snag. I could tell him anything I wanted. I could say, 'Well, I'm working on my second novel', or stretch the truth a little bit, 'I'm finishing a short story now, and think it will be published

soon'. Or perhaps that was an out and out lie. The problem was I thought of myself as a writer before I actually achieved it; but then again the central drive for an artist comes from within and if you have faith, then success is an unavoidable consequence. And I had plenty of faith, a whole fucking truckload of it.

On the other hand, maybe I should tell these people the truth about my situation. Yeah right. Tell these unappreciative clods the truth, bear out all my insecurities so in their simple minds they'll have something to give me shit about. Scenarios would unfold like:

"Oh, yes, Chris wants to be a writer (mockingly); he's just so intelligent. Oh, Gale, you prophetic guru, let's go to the library and talk about literature". . .yeah, I need more of this shit in my life. I need these loser assholes, doomed to a meager existence, telling me what I should or should not do. And although Steve really hadn't said anything, I found myself hating him. I was sick at the sight of his gaunt face. In an instant I could have smashed all his teeth out with the iron bar I had in my hand, but I figured that would be a little too dramatic. I opted for a better approach. I lied to him.

I may say that I like my job, that it pays the bills; or that I like cars, or that I am more financially secure, but it's bullshit. In reality, I hate everything about it. Sometimes, though, I find that through all this hate, a glimpse of understanding emerges. Yeah, the job is simplistic and dirty, but I do get to be alone most of the time and am allowed to think of things other than what I'm doing. Things like, what does life hold for me? What do I hope to achieve? What in God's name am I doing?! Thoughts deep; so deep sometimes that I find myself dying to get away from them. Escapism is a simple art, one does not necessarily need to do the mainstream method like driving long distances, stealing money from the estranged wife or girlfriend and hopping a plane to France, or even walking away. The true artist can merely explore the

recesses of his mind, find himself in different situations, and try out different lifestyles. For me, I find the companionship of others a release. . .but only under the right set of circumstances. I feel the need to control the situation, be at the helm, the captain of the ship giving orders to the others, knowing they're responding to me the way I desire them to. They must obey my every whim. But these days, I find the ship has gone, the others have deserted me. I'm nearly alone and moving toward complete desolation. So, at times, escape has its drawbacks, but that transcendence toward emptiness is a road I cannot veer from. I know I set the course in youth, and through my stubbornness am destined to that end. I didn't know when, but soon I would disappear from this life, and perhaps that was the crux of feeling little care for the job (not that I loved it in the first place). If they fired me, I couldn't care less. If Gale threw me out on my ass, I didn't give a shit. If someone shot me or else I committed suicide, I wouldn't give a damn. But all this was moot, the weight of life's drastic changes rarely fell on my shoulders. Anything that happened did so on my own accord, and the residual negativity was for others to bear.

The car I was working on had been frustrating me for some time. My thoughts were not so playful as they had been at the start. I was becoming increasingly irritated. Grease was caked to my hands, and smeared across my face; dirt hung loosely in my hair which dangled before my eyes and poked them. A frozen bolt pushed me near the breaking point, I was swearing and fighting the damn thing. And the inevitable happens: the wrench slipped and my hand went into a twisted mass of metal that, of course, had many sharp edges. My hand ached, the blood ran mixed with the grease and I yelled. The wrench went flying across the shop and landed in a loud series of clangs.

I had the chance to take a break later in the day. I lay down on a vinyl couch in the basement, and closed my eyes for a few moments. My

hand throbbed, the pulsing pain a metronome; I let my mind relax and wander. I couldn't wait to be out of work, driving away, but then again I had to face Gale and I hoped she wouldn't be home tonight. Maybe she had already gone out with one of her newspaper lovers—perhaps Bruce. I could see her with him in his ranch-style house, drinking wine, on her knees worshipping his small penis, hearing him talk about his recent trip to Africa. Gale would smile and tell him she loved to blow him, that she loved all artists' cocks no matter what the size. It was all an act.

I remember arguments with her about Bruce's "art".

"He's a writer, Chris, just like you."

"Not a writer and most certainly NOT like me."

"C'mon, me writes, he's had a few books published. He's better off than you."

"I don't think travelogues count."

"Well, he's more successful than you."

Now it was starting to hurt. "How old is he? Late thirties? So what? He's got a small dick and comes in thirty seconds. He's not better than me, and not even close to being my equal."

"That's what I like about him. He gives me all this free food—nice dinners, nice wine—and when it comes to sex, he has me face the wall, and he comes in his condom. Half a minute and it's over with, unlike you. You just have to make it last so long—asshole."

REWORK: Time for my mind to wander onto something else. It was Thursday, I had to work tomorrow and had the weekend off, what was I going to do? Anything? I could go driving out of town. . .any parties. . .yes! I sprung from my seat and thrust my eyes open. The party at Azlya's, it was tomorrow night! Oh, shit, how could I forget about that?! I would have totally forgotten if I hadn't relaxed and thought. I

knew that when I got home I would have to find the directions she had given me to her place. And yes, maybe Gale wouldn't be home.

But my hopes were dashed as soon as I arrived at the apartment.

"Somebody called for you, the number's on the desk."

The sound of the television broke the stillness of the early evening. She was yelling the answers to Jeopardy as I picked up the torn, hastily scribbled upon piece of paper. I made out the name Theresa and a number.

"Theresa called?"

"Yeah, about an hour ago. Who's that?"

I smiled to myself. "Someone I used to fuck."

"I don't want to hear about it."

I picked up the phone and dialed the number. The line was busy. I tried again in a half-hour—busy. And then a couple of hours later, no answer. I gave up on the idea. Theresa had been a bitch to me the last time we had gone out. I thought we would have a pleasant evening, but she couldn't get into the debauched lifestyle. She had no idea what life was about or how to function in it. No sense in trying to teach her, she was unable to learn.

(Note: Rework the parts in this that reference his job.) Bookstore!

I let Friday pass without incident. Gale came by telling me there was a gathering at Colin's house. A grand old pseudo black magic bullshit-fest. I told her that I wanted nothing to do with it. She smirked.

"Probably have a chance to get laid."

"I've already had you, and Colin, too, come to think of it. Where's the challenge, the spark of something new?"

"Well, there'll be some other girls there, friends. All you have to do is act like you're into magic and shit and you'll have them all over you."

A guy from work walked by Gale's car. He noticed me and waved.

“Great.”

“What are you going to do tonight? Sit in the apartment and sulk?”

“No, I have something else to do.”

“What?”

“I’m going to Alameda to a party.”

“Oh, I see, hmm. What time are you off?”

I looked at my watch. “In about forty-five minutes or so.”

“Let’s have dinner tonight. I’ll go over to the mall and wait until you get out.”

Gale was plotting something, she was never this nice to me. Or maybe it was something else.

“Okay.”

“I think we should talk.”

“Sounds fine, but I have other things to do.”

“It won’t take long. I promise.”

Although I still felt trepidation about meeting Gale, I found myself sitting across from her at a Chevy’s restaurant. She was quiet and distant; like, when she went to the mall to wait, she had a change of heart and decided not to talk. She sipped her drink and took small bites of food; she twisted her fork and poked at the beans, rice, sour cream, and guacamole on her plate. After a half-hour of silence between us, she spoke.

“I feel bad about what has happened to us. We used to be really good friends then we moved in together and it messed things up. We weren’t ready. I wanted to get away from my parents and you wanted to get away from Rhindy. We jumped into something we never should have.”

“Um, hum.”

“It’s not like I didn’t want to but. . .god, my hormones are running crazy these days.”

“Apparently in a bad way.”

She glared at me. She was serious.

“I’m sorry. How are they running crazy, as you say?”

“You don’t want to hear about it.”

“You’re probably insane, that’s all.”

“I have this terrible feeling. . .” She set her fork on the table.

“What?”

“I know you’re all pissed at me because I haven’t wanted to fuck you for the past, well, weeks. But there is a reason.”

“I’m all ears.”

“There was this one night with my ex, he was so insistent on having sex. . . I only stopped by to pick up some clothes.”

A rock was suddenly dropped into my stomach. Or maybe it felt like someone laid their fist into me.

“I think he might have gotten me pregnant.”

I swallowed hard. “Are you sure? When did this happen?”

“Sometime in August.”

I thought and thought, for how long I did not know. I tried to place in my mind all the pictures of all the times Gale and I had been together—the images flipped through my mind like a deck of cards. I knew I had never let myself go inside her (although she had wanted me to several times), but I couldn’t reassure myself that I wasn’t a part of this “gene pool” if indeed she were pregnant. But I definitely knew that I and her ex weren’t the only candidates in the running; there was also Colin, Bruce, and who the fuck knows how many others. My thoughts scared me. I knew she had no conception of who was the true father, who would be called “daddy”. I shuddered at the thought. I really didn’t hate children as I so often professed, but the thought of having one with Gale was completely nerve racking. It was

impossible, only because the idea of Gale and I together with a child was incomprehensible.

“So what are you going to do?”

“Have the kid of course. I already had one abortion, that was enough.”

“That’s right, that was Colin’s.”

“He didn’t want it anyway. At the time, I was the fourth girl he’d gotten pregnant. All abortions.”

“What about your ex?”

“I don’t know what I’m going to do. Maybe I’ll move back in with my parents.”

“I see.”

Her tone changed. “Oh, don’t worry about it, Mr. Selfish. The rent’s paid until the end of the month, but be warned that I won’t stay for the next month. If you are going to stay, then you’ll have to fork all the money yourself.”

“Thanks.”

I felt as if there was nothing more to talk about. We got into our separate cars and headed our separate directions. Her to wherever and me to home, then to Alameda.

It would’ve been the normal thing to worry about what the outcome of Gale’s pregnancy would be. But I knew I wasn’t normal—nor logical for that matter. I tried not to think about it driving to Azlya’s party, I couldn’t let the Gale matter wedge itself in my mind. I was going to a party, the first one I had been to in months, so I knew better to relax and enjoy myself. Besides, I remember the class she and I had been in, the way she sat across the table from me, her hair tied back, lips full with lipstick, breasts perked out, nipples firm, legs crossed—her tight jeans caressing them. There were times she’d wear a white T-shirt and I would get a full look at her. While the class was busy critiquing

asinine stories hastily written by fools, I was dreaming of her. What did she smell like? What did she taste like? How would we have dinner together? How would it feel to be inside her? I'd look to her face for the answer. She was good at what she did; I had the chance to read some of her work (she said she was working on a novel) and it wasn't all that bad—definitely better than mine. And I think that's what truly attracted me to her. The others in class were faceless blobs, expressionless in form, immature in style, sterile in technique—a waste of human life. But she, she had flair, energy, and a willingness to work at something until it was perfect no matter what the consequences. This is what we writers are put on this earth for, to discover the undiscovered, to disclose the undisclosed, and explore the territories of the mind and body that no one would dare transverse.

“Chris, I'm glad you could make it.” She put her arms around me and hugged me. I quickly glanced at my watch, the dinner with Gale had set me back quite a bit, it was near ten and the party had started at seven. Oh well, fashionably late is always good form.

“It's good to see you again. How's life?”

“It could be better, but I have no complaints.”

“Guess who showed up.” She laughed to herself and whispered to me; I could smell alcohol on her breath. “That asshole, Ben. Remember him?”

“Maybe.”

She laughed and went to the kitchen. She poured herself a glass of wine and handed me a beer. “He's in the living room professing himself again. I don't know why he came, everybody hates him.”

“Yeah, the place is kind of quiet.”

“I didn't invite too many people, that way nothing gets broken or stolen.”

We walked into the next room. “Art is such an elusive object, only a few can catch its essence. . .we have to work long and hard to have our art. . .we must transcend to limitless planes of consciousness. . .”

“Is he on his martyrdom kick again? He always did that in class. Bothers the shit out of me.” I said.

“He’s been going on like that for nearly an hour now.”

“Sounds worse than I remember it.”

“I think he’s drunk.”

Music was coming from down the hall. I motioned toward the sound.

“My roommate’s friends are down there.”

“Lucky them.”

We sat on the couch, she folded her leg under her and gazed at me, frisking her hair out of her face.

“How have you been doing?”

I took a long drink out of the bottle. “Good.”

“Still writing?”

I chuckled. “Always. How about you?”

“I’ve been working on that psychological piece, you know, the one I told you about. The one with the woman who’s committed to an asylum and how she’s treated.”

“Working out well?”

“Yes. I’ve been doing more research, filling it out.”

She looked at Ben and the three or so others who were sitting with him, then to me. I smiled.

“He looks like a goddamned reining Buddha or something.”

I laughed. “He does.”

After our laughter died, we sat in silence. She got up twice, once to go to the kitchen and once to the bathroom. I half listened to Ben babbling and the stereo in the next room trying figure out what songs were playing. Whenever people came out of Azlya’s roommate’s room,

they were always laughing. The ones in front of me looked stoned, asleep, or really bored. I had to admit I had little respect for Ben; sure he was an artist (I guess), but he always talked about it as if it was some sort of clinical experiment. He expressed no passion for it; he tirelessly tried to tear it down in his analytical frame and as far as I'm concerned, that is the absolutely worst thing you can do. Art is comes from the heart and not the mind. It is an expression, not a science. One cannot merely lay his art on the table before him, don a glacier white lab coat, a knife in one hand, and tweezers in the other and dissect the damn thing. And apparently, according to him, each piece that's extracted is supposed to bear some lofty truth about life and the world around. It's supposed to give an insight into the self and the reasons for doing what we do. No, no, no, Ben. You have no fucking idea what your proposing. You tear something as delicate as art apart and you end up destroying it. You end up with a handful of nothing, a wisp of air. Yes, it's elusive but that's the point of it. That's why you chase the damn thing, it piques your curiosity and keeps you running; it was insists on life, it's what requires passion. There is no edge, no secret answer. Every individual expresses themselves individually according to their principals and values and views and their art is a reflection of their dedication and expression. It's what drives them to their ends whatever those ends may be.

The women gathered around Ben seemed to have bought into his bantering. I just hoped Azlya hadn't but by the look on her face and the number of times she looked at him spewing his diatribe, I would have to guess that she had. No sense in saying anything, don't bother arguing, punching holes into his majestic purple tapestry, it would only serve making me look like an asshole and him a god. But since everyone considered me an asshole, there was nothing to lose. Azlya shook her head and looked at me.

“I think I’ve had one too many of these things.” She shook her glass.

“How many?”

“I’m not sure, but I started around four or so this afternoon.”

I made a face and looked at the fabric on the couch. All of a sudden I felt as if I didn’t belong in the house, that suddenly the voices and faces were completely alien. Yes, I didn’t know a soul in the place, save Azlya, but the others’ features were distorted, inhuman, their mouths twisted, their torsos bloated. They screamed accusingly at each other in a language unknown to me. I wanted to approach one, its lanky arms in the air, its thin tentacle-like fingers outstretched, and break them off one by one. I wanted to destroy the beast more than anything else, its voice was annoying, biting, the tone grating on my nerves; it seemed to draw on my very emotions, it wanted me to act. I turned my eyes from it and looked to one of the others surrounding it; it could have been female, its arms were in the air like the others but its fingers reached to the ceiling where it clawed at the plaster sending down showers of dust. The others in the circle picked up the tiny white particles and dropped them into their misshapen mouths.

“Are you okay?”

I nearly jumped in my seat. “I’m okay.”

“You want another drink?” She handed me another beer. I took it and noticed Ben. He was chewing something and talking incoherently; the others were eating too, they passed around a blue and white-striped plastic bag. I tried to read the writing.

“You don’t like Ben much do you?”

I tried desperately to catch a glimpse of what the bag contained.

“I don’t know.”

“Why?”

I saw the writing on the bag as it was passed. They were Oreos.

“Hmm?”

“Never mind. What are you thinking about?”

“Nothing. . .really.”

“Okay.”

“Well, I guess I have a few things on my mind.”

“You still writing?”

I took a long drink of the beer almost finishing it. The cold of it chilled me. “You already asked me that.”

She laughed. “Well, I suppose I did.”

I smirked. “And you’re working on that novel, right? The one. . .”

“The one about the woman who gets put into an asylum by her discompassionate husband.”

“You mean the one who falls in love with the comatose guy?”

“He’s not really comatose.”

I laughed. The main thing I noticed about Azlya was her raw drive to accomplish anything—no matter how stupid it sounded—be it writing, her job, her personal life, whatever, but what I also noticed was that her drive was often misplaced. For example, she always spoke very highly of this Ben guy—who by now I knew was a complete fool—which I could never understand. As I sat quietly observing him, I couldn’t see what was so supposedly great about him; he wasn’t even an artist; he talked too much and did very little accomplishing. I mean, if an artist practices his art then this guy was rusty; in fact he was one piece of solid corroded iron which the shape of the one intricate machine now frozen together rendering the thing completely inoperable. A machine for which there was no hope. I knew it and wanted everybody else to as well. But then again, I didn’t want to be like that useless scrap, emulating it by talking too much. Becoming as it had already become. Now, Azlya’s novel, that was interesting. She worked heart out of it, I thought it great, but by the tone in her voice whenever we talked about

it, she didn't think too highly of the piece—which is typical—the worst critic is yourself.

"I mean the story is strong, she learns through her husband's abusive treatment that the peaceful life that David (the comatose guy) has is better. Through her dreams she falls in love with him, they form a strong bond which is something she never had before."

"Are you telling somebody else about your novel, dear?" I looked up and Ben was hovering over us. "If you don't be careful, dear, someone might steal your ideas." He looked at me and I shook my head.

"Don't count on it, Jack."

He introduced himself.

"Ben Preston. And you?"

He apparently didn't remember me from class. It was no surprise.

"Chris."

He outstretched his hand as if to signal that I should reach out and touch the hand of this mortal god. I waved. He looked with furrowed brow to Azlya then to me.

"You're a friend of Azlya's."

"Yeah, we have a class together. At the college. Remember?"

He offered me a blank look.

"Creative writing."

He snickered. "Oh yes, now I remember. How silly of me. You're the one that writes those morbid stories. The ones about death, decay, cemeteries, ghouls, and all that."

"That pretty much sums it up. You got me pegged."

He looked at me blankly again. "So what do you think of yourself? Do you consider yourself an artist?"

I had to laugh at that one. I burst out right in his face and that burned him. His eyes widened and his nostrils flared.

“How about you, Ben, you secure with it? Be careful now, it’s a trick question.”

I chuckled a few more times. Out of the corner of my eye I could see Azlya, eyes wide, shaking her head.

“Well, I’m not going to play any games with you.”

“Why not? They’re so much fun. Won’t you stay and play?”

“No thank you. Excuse me.”

With that he left us. Azlya giggled.

“You’re such an asshole. It takes a lot to piss him off like that. Usually most people sit and take it but you. . .”

“I guess I know how to press the right buttons.”

“I’ll say.” She finished her wine and smiled at me. “Would you like to take a look at my novel?”

“Sure.”

We went into her room and she shut the door behind us. She went to a desk and extracted a file folder that bulged with paper. She set the folder on the desk and flipped through it. She frowned and I could see that she really didn’t have a compiled novel but merely a stack of notes. I still thought it admirable.

“Oh shit. I’m too tired to dig through this now. Later.”

She got up and stood by the door as if she had the sudden urge to leave.

“I liked how you did that to Ben and I’m glad you came to the party and I’m glad you like my writing. . .what little you’ve seen of it. What are you thinking about?”

I smiled and looked at my lap. I put on my best thoughtful look.

“How we are so alike in that we strive as hard as we can to make our lives work. That we are artists, writers, who really don’t give a damn about anything but ourselves and our work. That we feel free to make our own choices.”

She smiled and turned out the light. I heard her shuffle across the floor and turn on a small lamp on the end table. She sat next to me.

“I’m thinking about you and me and how close I feel to you right now. You were the only one who got the point of my stories. You understood, you saw beyond the facade. You saw my soul.”

She kissed me hard, I tasted the remnants of wine on her tongue. We lay down on the bed. I saw in the feeble light of the lamp, the woman who I respected more than life itself. If it weren’t for my own drive to succeed, I would give everything to her. If it weren’t for my intensive individuality, I would worship her. I would be everything she ever could possibly dream of needing. I would be the man who waited on her hand and foot, the man who obeyed her every command—her servant, her ally, living only to see to the fulfillment of her happiness. I would die for her and her ideals. She is an aspect of Ninety-Nine.

Her body was sweet, so peasant lying in the aglow light. I felt at peace, the world at that moment was a beautiful symphony of sight and sound and smells where her breath and her life were the food for my starving soul. I needed to devour her, unite with her before I withered and died away—a mere dusty scrap of paper, faded writing chiseled into its surface falling victim to disintegrate on the onset of each zenith. She was my anchor, my cord to life, having me deep inside her, her knowing my every twist and turn that we were one. The two: but if two can be one, who would we become? If there were any answer then it could be found in the instants of these moments we shared, the emotions expressed, the pure unadulterated passion. She was warm, a splash of red; I was responsive, a splash of blue; she madly passionate, a rush of green; me hard and driving, a stroke of violet; together we created a collage of colors rivaled only by an electric rainbow. But we rivaled it, spit into the face of the gods who created it. We made them

see that we mere mortals were endeavored to do the same and would destroy them if we had the chance.

I looked down upon her; her eyes were fixed with mine—her lips pursed and her breath quick. I felt her struggle beneath me. It was at that moment the fantasy quit and the reality set in; the bubble had been burst and she had made the turn. I felt uneasy, found myself looking at the clock and noticing it was late. I think that and the fact that she had been drinking dampened her like it did. She became impatient, dug her nails into my back, and pulled my ear close to her mouth.

“Come, come please.”

It wasn't as easy as that. I tried to hurry, but didn't want to lose the moment although it was probably lost anyway. But coming fast was not something I did easily. As time progressed, I felt her impatience growing greater and greater, as if I was putting her out, interfering with her life. Yes, she had wanted me but as we started actually fucking, she suddenly realized the profundity of the whole experience and wanted to turn back but knew she couldn't. In some ways I meant what I thought of her, I felt that way with almost everybody I had slept with but this time the moment held the record for being the shortest. As I looked at her now, she was visibly irritated; she wanted me to pay homage to her awesome body. Why was I holding out? Perhaps, she wasn't that great, but she did have a nice cunt nevertheless.

It was later; the sex of the evening led to the silence of the night. Azlya lay next to me, her leg over mine. She was very peaceful, she was very warm; I turned on my side to watch her. Her dreams seemed so halcyon that there was nothing in this world that was bothering her—I envied her. She seemed to have it all so together: her novel, her outlook on life, how she handled herself; she seemed all so content. I couldn't see what she saw in me. I was always edgy, pessimistic, putting feelings

into her that were not true just to satisfy some sort of vice of mine. In the depths of that night I wondered what was wrong with me. I knew I was cynical, but how far had I taken it? Was I doomed to be this way forever? Why couldn't I control this hatred I had, this need to blacken everything I touched? Why couldn't I feel comfortable knowing I was alive and doing something with my life? I knew I was better off than most people. Questions and more questions, but so very few answers. If there was only a way to see into the future, how successful I might be, how peaceful I might become; perhaps I could take stock in those feelings and be patient.

"You work yourself too hard." Azlya had said to me one time during class. I wanted to believe her, but knew better.

"You should take a break once in a while and look around, you're too consumed." Gale had said on another occasion. I knew I couldn't do that. I knew Gale was totally wrong. My time on this earth was finite, only so much time to achieve the things I desired. So making the best of the time I had was the most logical approach; it's what seemed right to me. I lay on my back, the ceiling was black. I tried to find some shapes in the darkness to help me sleep—there were none to be seen.

The landscape opened before me, spacious and dusty. Tall grasses tugged at my legs, the sun was beating down. As my eyes became adjusted to the light, I saw a peach house with white trim in the distance. A porch ran the length of the front of it; I noticed a swing and a couple of chairs on it. There was a small table with glasses resting quietly on it. There wasn't a hint of wind. I looked around me and noticed I was on the edge of a gorge, on the better side toward the house. I wiped the sweat from my forehead and walked in the direction of it.

The architecture was decidedly Victorian; the building was asymmetrical, three stories and an attic with a sloped roof. A turret ran up the side above the porch to the attic. It formed a spire at the top. Bay windows were on each story, the glass curved to meet the shape of the turret. The whole place was covered in mild peach paint with neat white trim along each of the windows and along the length of the porch—including the railing—which I set my hand on as I ascended the stairs. Everything was so neat and clean, there wasn't a spec of dust anywhere. I found it surprising since the dwelling was in a place whose staple was a generous dose of sunshine coupled with mounds of dust.

The front door was open. I walked into the entry way. Upon pushing back the doors, I came upon a magnificent hallway with a curved stairway on the right. I wandered into the living room on the left—it was filled with plush red velvet Victorian furniture: Tiffany lamps, a rolltop desk with an ancient typewriter on it, and a stylish chandelier in the center of the ceiling. I was set to wander through the rest of the house when I heard someone shuffling upstairs, a person walking between rooms; the footsteps echoed above my head. I stood at the base of the stairs with my hand on the banister. A voice called out.

“Chris? Is that you?”

I was frozen to my spot. Not knowing what to say, I pursed my lips and was silent as if afraid of having been discovered. The footsteps moved across the ceiling and as they approached the head of the stairs. I was struck with fright, a fear that was undaunted. It was a woman I recognized, an image out of a dream. She had long red hair and sanguine eyes. She smiled.

“Anna?” I whispered.

“Well, don't just stand there. Come upstairs and help me put these clothes away.”

I swallowed hard and ascended. She was in the far room down the hall, on the left. As I entered the room, she was standing before a large mirror next to the closet. She was thin, of tall build—maybe 5'10" or so—a long face and fair skin, reddish hair, and deep sanguine eyes that ring so familiar.

"Is something wrong with you? Are you feeling all right?" She set the clothes down and placed the back of her hand to my forehead.

"You don't feel warm." She turned and went back to the bed and picked up a pile of folded trousers. She set them in the closet and pulled out a long black coat.

"Come here. See how this fits on you."

I put the coat on and stood before the mirror. I noticed I was wearing cream colored loose-fitting pants and a grey shirt.

"It looks pretty good," she said.

I looked at her reflection in the mirror. She was beautiful—her fire red hair shimmered in the afternoon light. I put my arm around her; she embraced me sending a waft of flowery perfume into the air. I closed my eyes. When I opened them, she was smiling, her head against my shoulder, her face masked by her hair. I stared at us in the mirror; I seemed older, maybe around thirty. A glow shimmered around our bodies, we were eternal. The moments we had embraced throughout time were renewed in this place. I felt good—again—better than anything else I had ever known in this lifetime. I was at peace, a feeling quite unique yet familiar at the same time. We were together again, time had separated us but we had beat it; our passion and love knew not death.

Sunbeams ushered in through the window behind us; the light blinded me for a second. As I regained my sight, I found myself staring into the mirror out the window. The vast landscape that was once sand and dirt was now soaked with oil, black sooty oil that extended beyond

the gorge that ran a channel around the house. The land was black as far as the eye could see to the horizon; a huge greyish pipe on stilts ran from one side of the horizon and snaked its way into the distance. It appeared as if it had no beginning and no end. I tried to release our embrace to look around and get a firsthand view when she grabbed me tight. She pulled my face down to meet hers and whispered,

“Don’t fight it. It’s not so bad once you get used to it.”

Azlya stirred next to me, I opened my eyes. It was morning, a clock sitting on an end table displayed 8:30 in squarish green numbers. She struggled up leaving the covers on the bed.

“Good morning.”

“ . . . morning.”

“How’d you sleep?”

“ . . . okay.”

She put her arms behind her head and stretched, pushing her breasts out.

“That’s good because I slept very well.” She smiled at me, her dirty blonde hair fell before her face. She leaned over and kissed me on the cheek.

“Last night was wonderful,” she smiled again, this time more lustfully. “Want some breakfast?”

I nodded.

“Good, ’cause I’m starved.”

She got up, I watched her put a robe on, her buttocks firm under the long cloth. She left the room and I looked at the ceiling. Although I had just woke, my mind was running at full speed asking questions about my character; questions like, how is it that I can tarnish just about everything I touch? Azlya was so nice, so sweet; I was beginning to think thoughts I had the night before were some sort of specter designed to distract and disdain me. She wasn’t feeling any of those

things I had thought. How disgraceful of me. My gut wrenched, I knew I was a putrid shell of a man, something less than human, a monster sucking every vile feeling out of the world. I had to admit it, I liked vileness—the taste of bile a pleasing elixir to my hollow existence. I knew I couldn't face Azlya, I was ashamed. I couldn't find the strength to forgive myself, how could I expect her to forgive me?

I got dressed. She was just finishing bacon and throwing eggs into a pan. I sat down at a small table tucked into a corner of the kitchen.

"Coffee's ready. Help yourself."

She handed me a mug with blue hearts on it. I slowly poured the coffee adding teaspoonfuls of sugar and cream.

"How do you like your eggs?"

My mind was trapped between sleep and wake. "Oh. . .over hard please."

She cracked the egg and spilled its contents into the hot pan; she looked around the kitchen, partially empty bottles littered the surfaces of the counters. There were multicolored spills of strawberry, cherry, raspberry—blues, greens, and yellows. A blender in the corner near the stove had traces of a hardened froth on the rim, its surface glimmering in the morning sunlight.

"God this place is a mess." She ran her fingers through her hair. "I wonder where my roommate is."

My mind was drifting. A glass stained with remnants of a peach margarita reminded me of the color of the house in the dream the night before. I could see the woman as clear as if I were dreaming now. I was trying to figure who she was, where I might have seen her before to find some sort of semblance to the outside world. Recognition was futile. I gazed at Azlya, her long blonde hair hung over her robe. She was too nice, she seemed eager to do things for me, but she knew she wasn't mine. We did not belong to each other—although not for lack

of trying on my part. I had hoped she knew I did not love her nor did I think I ever would, why was she doting on me? Guilt is not an option. Now that I thought about it, I really didn't love anybody I came into contact with. I didn't think I loved Rhindy, I had no feelings for Gale, none for anyone. Over the past few months, it was becoming just a little too clear the only woman I would ever begin to love with was the one from my dream. And she was certainly not real. A lot of time would have to pass before I got myself straightened out.

"Breakfast is served," she placed a plate before me and seated herself. I was still staring at her, she blushed slightly.

"Eat up, it'll get cold."

"Wouldn't want that to happen." Because where's the fun in anything if it's cold? The heat, warmth, that's what we humans strive for, that's why I found myself with Azlya; she was warm, kind, hell she even smelled good—even in the morning, especially so. She had a personality you couldn't shun. There would always be some sort of smile upon her face, oh how I envied her; a face so warm, a smile that could melt me in an instant. . .yet I couldn't love her. And I think that's the only thing that saved me, the only thing that made it easier when I had to leave. As I finished my breakfast, I told her that I had to leave, that my roommate would worry if I didn't check in. A lie—albeit a bad one—works when you wish to hide your true feelings. And I made use of it often. Also, I didn't want to hurt her with the truth. I could be kind, the cost of pain transferred from her to me. I could be the most sensitive person in the world when it came to hurting someone—I would try to avoid it—but I couldn't wait for the next opportunity to hurt myself. I'd like to say I lied because she had been so kind to me, but alas that is a lie, too. I didn't want to say anything, didn't want her to know what I was thinking. I didn't want to say that I despised

her for being so carefree and happy—or that I wanted nothing to do with her.

It was near noon when I got back to the apartment. I woke Gale as I shut the door behind me.

“Hello.”

“Hello.”

I sat at the small desk in the kitchen. I stared for a long time at my typewriter. Gale stirred.

“Nick called. It’s important you call him back.”

I sighed and picked up the phone. He answered after two rings, it sounded like he had something heavy on his mind.

“I need to talk to you.”

“What about?”

“A lot of weird things have been going on. Meet me at my house and I’ll tell you then.”

“Okay, see you.”

Boy, he thinks a lot of weird things are going on. But my mind wasn’t concentrated on weirdness, just survival; I get reminded every time I step into this apartment that the end of the month is coming and I didn’t have enough money for rent. I had been toying with the idea of moving back in with my parents but so far that idea seemed stupid. I hated living at home. Sure, my parents are great and all but I couldn’t stand the idea of staying with them. But as time progressed, I saw little hope for much else. At least at home I could save some money.

I reluctantly picked up the phone and dialed, long distance, my mother answered. She was quiet, listless, and asked me when I was going to come down and see her. She asked if I was through with school. I said I go fairly regularly and would like to finish. She thought that was a good idea and was the first to suggest I live down in the valley

with them so I could get back on my feet. Even though I had been thinking this option, it still hit me in the gut when she said it. I was staring out the window when Gale slid back the kitchen door. She yawned.

“Is that long distance?”

I ignored her and continued talked. But to avoid a scene, I decided to cut it short. I gave my mother my number and hung up.

“Just talking with my parents.”

“Oh, what about?”

“Nothing important.”

I got up and lay on the mattress. I could hear Gale tearing around in the kitchen. Blocking out the sound was easier than I thought and I quickly fell asleep. When I woke, she was standing out on the balcony smoking. She offered me one.

“Nice day.” The sun had just come out chasing away the morning fog. “It’ll be a shame when we have to leave this place.”

She lit the cig for me.

“Yeah. Too bad it didn’t work out.”

“You know, I think it would have been okay if it hadn’t been for me getting pregnant. My stupid boyfriend, he wanted it so bad. I had to let him have me so he’s shut up. Asshole. But when you’re pregnant, your hormones go crazy. And I get vicious mood swings which make me irritable. . .”

“So they say.”

“Well, that’s what happened to me anyway. I want to say I feel awful about the shit I put you through. I’m sorry I’ve been such a bitch.”

I looked at her, she smiled. This was the first time in the whole time I’d known her (at least as long as I could remember)—a first time I noticed her being sincere. No facades, no implications, no

sarcasm—pure sincerity. I felt a little warm inside something a little like love, perhaps admiration; there were times when I thought Gale and I could have a relationship, maybe someday be in love, wholly and unadulterated—but this was obvious fantasy. She and I could never get along—we would kill each other first—she was pregnant, mostly irritable as she put it. I knew this moment was temporary like most things around me, soon it would be back to the way they normally were, fighting and clawing like we do. Still, I was feeling good and needed to hold onto the moment.

“Don’t worry about it, it wasn’t all that bad.”

She smiled again, this time longer. We looked to the horizon; to travel so far is a wonder, to regress is suicide. I thought of the future, so much to look forward to if I could just get through today. We both took long drags on our cigarettes, the smoke playfully curled above our heads.

It was a few hours later when I arrived at Nick’s house. I had to pound repeatedly at the door before he answered.

“Chrisman, I’ve got some news for you. Let’s go for a drive, my mom’s home.”

We got into his car, he immediately spoke.

“Weird shit’s been happening, this friend of mine at school say her mother’s seen some shit.” He got quiet and scratched the side of his head.

“Like yesterday, her mother was sitting at the dining table, she was looking at a wall, it opened up and these demons walked out. They were wearing this rusty metallic armor, carrying lances, walking in twos. These things were only two feet tall, they jumped into the air and passed by the side of her head. She said its a sign of something coming into this world, some kind of evil.”

I was staring out the window, he hadn’t started the car yet.

“And about two nights ago, I was backing out of the driveway and turned toward there.” He pointed in the direction I was staring. “And as the headlights passed I saw a woman in, like, forties clothes with her arms folded in front of her, palms up. It was like she was in the corner of my eye, then she lifted her arms above her head, there was this fetus in her hands. She said her name, it was the woman who owned the car before me.”

“What’s with the fetus thing?”

“Well, Grenadine’s had some strange dreams, that she was not supposed to be born to her parents. That she was supposed to be the daughter of this woman, but she miscarried twenty days before Grenadine’s real birthday. And something else. The last time we were in Santa Rosa, she was sitting in the ‘57 Plymouth and she saw the woman. She said ‘the domination must end’. I don’t know what the fuck is going on.”

“I don’t know either, but it sounds like you’ve got some big problems.”

“I’ve been seeing a lot of ghosts lately, in the house, out here, and when I look at them directly, they vanish. And I’ve been having dreams too.”

He put his fingers on the ignition key as if to turn it but let it go. He stared out the windshield.

“Last night, I dreamt that I was driving on this highway, there were sands all around. As I drove further, the sand was oil soaked—deep black—there were these pipes that ran along the road, they were dripping oil into the sand. A little further down the road, these phone booths appeared on either side. People were standing in them, they were being torn apart, wires pulling their skin. I saw these drills going through their heads. It was pretty gruesome, you think?”

I said nothing. I was still staring.

“I can’t figure what all this shit means, these ghosts and dreams, this friend (the one with the mother who saw the demons) seems to think all this is a sign of Armageddon. When the dead rise, that’s the end.”

“Well, you know, it’s written that Judgment Day happens on the turn of a millennium.”

“What’s that?”

“A thousand years, like 2000.”

“Yeah, I can’t picture those years. It’s like it’s unrealistic 2003, 2007, doesn’t seem real.”

“I bet you a lot of other people think that too, that’s why the turn of the millennium is such a big deal—like in 1000. All this anxiety about it, fear building and becoming more powerful. It just invites other forces into the world to feed on it. That’s probably what’s been going on.”

“And what about this place I dreamt about? Is it some sort of hell?”

“There is no hell just as there is no heaven. This place you dreamt of is a sort of purgatory, a place where the souls are cleansed so they can pass on—if you believe in reincarnation. When someone dies, in some ways they still hold on to the memories of their existence, they are still attached to the earth—and life—although they are dead and far from it. The souls go through the landscape you see, where they are tortured, where the remnants of their past life are beat out of them. They are in turn enlightened and are ready to meet the challenges of the new life without any hang-ups on the old. Why don’t we have any memory of a previous life? I mean you might have a feeling about it, but you don’t really know for sure. That place makes sure. We don’t remember our past lives because we’re punished not to remember. It’s the way of things, the natural progression. We don’t remember because it’s natural for us not to. And the landscape with the oil and pipes,

I've dreamt of a place like that too. It houses, it holds all the energies that are stripped from the soul: the jealousy, the hatred, the arrogance, the sorrows, the worries, the anger, the fear, the pestilence, all the shit in your life that you ever did—it is there. We'll be there one day. . .”

“I already have been.” His grip on the steering wheel was tight, his knuckles white.

“Well, I wouldn't worry too much about it. Have you talked to Grenadine about it?”

“I haven't told her about the dream, in fact, I haven't seen her in a while.”

“Oh. . .”

“Nobody knows where she is.”

“What do you mean?”

“Last week her roommates told me she went to go see her mother up north. I knew she was going, but she said it was only for an afternoon. It's been three days.”

“Maybe she got hung up. Maybe she decided to stay.”

“I guess. But she's missed school. That's not like her except when we skip together.”

“How romantic. But I wouldn't worry about it. She's okay.”

Nick was visibly disturbed about what was going on around him. He was near panic. I felt I should do something I never thought I would do for Nick. I consoled him.

“I got a bad feeling about her, Chris.”

“Which is wrong, take it from me. Don't think like that Nick.”

“Yeah. . .yeah. But I think she's. . .she's dead.”

I stared out the window again, in the same spot I had been for the past five minutes. Nick sighed a couple of times and rubbed his eyes. He turned on the car and we drove endlessly.

Chapter 10

The days keep on quickly moving by. In a few days I will have to leave this apartment. Apparently Gale is going back to her parents', I don't know where the hell I'm going. Yesterday, I talked to my mother again, she insisted on me moving down to the valley. I thanked her but I found that I'd rather stay in the city. Although I was in a state of financial hardship and chances of my survival seemed pretty slim, I still liked my freedom away from my parents. I liked it even better that I have been living on my own. . .but I don't have enough to keep going here. I have a feeling that soon Gale will move back in with her boyfriend/father of her child someday, she says that they have been patching up things lately. It doesn't seem like it in the way she talks to him over the phone, but for her it is the only thing she can do—at least that is all she will tell me. She also told me last night, in one of her fits of crying that she was upset with me that I hadn't gone with her on the second Ft. Bragg weekend (Where is this mentioned before?!); she said that since neither I nor Nick went with her that she, in a fit of depression, went to see her boyfriend. It was on that night she felt she got pregnant—I had nothing to say except that I agreed.

Today had been long, I didn't go to school. I sat around, went out for a walk and debated seeing Rhindy. I seemed to think it would be a mistake, but more and more it seem that the only option I had was to move back in with her. God did I hate life. It seemed so unfair to have to struggle and fight to get on your own only to go screaming back. Something was going to suffer, I was sure of that, but what it would be was a mystery. There was a little voice that said I should prepare, for it just might be my writing that would suffer. . .but losing that didn't seem so bad right now. Survival is of the utmost importance. And I was in deep, fucked beyond all recognition.

It was near nine and Gale wasn't home yet. I knew she worked (where is this mentioned before?!) until six or so and the commute

wasn't very long, perhaps she was with a newspaper lover or hanging out with her parents. Either way I really didn't care, I was pissed at the world for handing me a bad deal and ready to pounce on anyone close—including and most especially, Gale.

I searched the refrigerator, the room was dark and the light spread liberally across the floor. There was nothing but a bottle of water, some dried leftovers, and half a carton of rancid milk. I left the door open and in the cabinets lay a can of Mandarin oranges. I pried the can open and stuck a fork into the small slices. The taste was welcoming. I used to eat these a lot when I was a kid; it made me think of my mother with an electric can opener, tearing the can open and plopping the contents into a plastic bowl. I thought of being so young, having to be taken care of. I thought of the way the grass smelled in the back yard, and the evening sun warming the kitchen table. So many sappy sweet childhood memories, there was comfort then, if I could only transfer a little of that to my life now then I would be better. Moving again struck my mind, but having your mother open a can at eight has a far better effect than having her do it at twenty-three—at eight, you're practically helpless; at twenty-three, you're supposed to know better.

A key turned in the lock and the door was thrown open. Gale yelled into the dark apartment. I shut the refrigerator and greeted her. She flipped on the light and glared at me.

"I hate coming into this place when it's dark and you're here. It's scary. What if someone broke in. . ."

"It's only me."

"Some protector you'll be if somebody did break in here. You'd probably let them rape me and steal the stuff."

I looked around the barren apartment; there was only a mattress, a pile of clothes, a desk, a typewriter, and a refrigerator devoid of groceries.

“There’s nothing here to steal.”

“Yeah.”

She threw her purse on the floor and shut the door.

“Have you been here all day?”

“Yep.”

“Anybody call?”

“Not that I know of.”

“You have been taking messages, haven’t you? There have been some calls that I haven’t been getting. Like Bruce.”

“Haven’t talked to him. He hasn’t called here.”

I went into the kitchen and turned on the radio. I closed the partition and sat at the desk. She yelled through the door.

“I’m taking a shower. Work was the shits, didn’t you work (should this be mentioned earlier and in what capacity?! Bookstore) today?”

“No.”

“Better do something, dude, we’re moving out of here in a few days, you’ll need money.”

“I don’t need to be reminded.”

She said something else, but a good song on the radio drowned her words. I heard her turning on the water. I flipped on the typewriter and hit a couple of keys, but the writing wasn’t coming out. I was stressed and a little angry, the fact that I didn’t have any money and Gale was being such a bitch got the best of me. I wasn’t sure if I was ever going to be able to write again, I had to eliminate the things that distracted me. The typewriter glared, it was waiting, wanting to create but my mind was a blank. I opted to write a letter, but to who? I had lost track of most of my friends since living here and alienated everybody else; I was totally and completely alone and even that I wouldn’t mind so much if I was living with someone that didn’t hassle me every waking moment. If I were more psychotic I would have killed

somebody with a straight razor. Starting to scare myself. Maybe I should write a short story about a guy who moves in with a woman he can't stand, maybe because he got her pregnant, and she's a total bitch to him. He snaps and kills her. Nah, I had my little fantasies about murder, but putting it into practice was a whole other issue. Besides, I wouldn't be able to stand getting caught. I would be one of those 'if the cops come down on me then I'd snuff myself because I can't stand prison' types. I put the idea out of my head and tried thinking about more wholesome things. Like sex. If Gale was better with me, I would get into the shower with her and seduce her, but the way things were, if I did that I would be greeted with a frown and a hearty,

"Get the fuck out!"

I hit the keys a few more times. Something was starting to come—letters formed words—I waited for them to become phrases then paragraphs, but it didn't go that far. The water was turned off and I heard the bathroom door opening. She tore up the living room—moving the mattress around—and opened the partition.

"Want to have a smoke on the balcony with me?"

I turned my head slowly and smirked. I walked out with her grabbing the Camels (where is it mentioned what brand of cigarettes he smokes?!) that were patiently sitting on the counter. I lit her cigarette for her.

"Thanks."

I nodded.

"Man, what a hellish day. I think I'm going to quit once I get back to my parents'. Did you get any writing done today?"

"Not really, only a few sentences."

"Writer's block, dude. I'm glad I don't get that."

She didn't write enough to get a block.

"If there's no water flowing in the riverbed, why dam it?"

"What?"

“Nothing.”

“Oh, I get it, funny. I don’t have the time to write. I’m working full time unlike someone around here.” She shot a mean look at me. I ignored her.

“Whatever.”

“That shower was good. It was too fucking hot today, the office was stuffy, just like the guy I work for.”

I looked over the lights of San Mateo, the haze looked picturesque, bathed in sodium street lights.

“Going to be weird leaving here, just as I was getting used to it.”

“You can stay.”

“I can’t afford both rents. Six-hundred dollars is a little much for me.”

“Get a roommate.”

“And put them where? There’s only one room.”

“You going to go back to Rhindy?”

“Probably.”

“If that’s what you want to do. I wouldn’t. She probably won’t even take you back.”

“Who knows.”

“Have you talked to her?”

“Not recently. But it’ll be okay. I think.”

“I hope so. Looks like it’s the only thing you can do.”

“Yeah. It’s depressing.”

“Well, at least we’re suffering together.”

I looked at her, she smiled at me. She got some sort of thrill seeing me suffer. It made her feel better, that her life wasn’t as bad as she thought. I passed it off as an insecurity of hers.

“Yeah. But life will be all right someday. God knows when. Maybe when I get the book finished.”

“By seeing how little you write, it might take a while.”

“Someday.”

“It’s cold, let’s go inside.”

It wasn’t that cold, but since she was in her robe, her nipples hard, they might have been a better indicator of the temperature. I followed her in. She sat on the mattress, her robe opened slightly.

“I don’t think I can stay up too late tonight. I have to be at work early, I’m going to go to bed. Don’t make too much noise.”

“I’ll try not to.”

I went into the kitchen and sat at the desk. The typewriter resumed its glare, it was starting to piss me off. The scene of the lights of the city proved to be more interesting than the machine and its brilliant white blank paper sticking out of it. I felt heckled. I turned the switch off and on, then decided I probably should go to bed as well since I was feeling a bit tired and there was nothing else to do. I had to work at the bookstore (B Dalton downtown SF) at ten tomorrow and it would take a lot out of me just preparing for the ordeal of it. I was starting to think that all the money in the world wouldn’t be worth having to spend the time there. There had to be a better way.

I shut off the light and stood over the mattress. Gale was still awake and she watched me undress. I lay next to her and she put her hand across my chest; ordinarily it would be comforting, but her touch seemed to mock me, as if she were doing it for my benefit. Her hand moved and she was caressing me. She leaned over and whispered in my ear.

“Do you want to fuck?”

Direct and to the point.

I didn’t think, I didn’t feel. I responded mechanically. “Yeah.”

“I don’t think I can go through the whole ritual. . .”

Which meant, no blow job, no foreplay—just fucking. She got up and knelt on all fours, I set myself behind her and entered. As soon as we started, I detected impatience in her, as if in only the few moments that I had been inside her, she wished it to be over.

“Why can’t you be more like Bruce? It only takes him thirty seconds.”

“I’ll try.” But the orgasm seemed far off, I would need at least five minutes, maybe longer because of the pressure to finish. *Deja vu*—She pulled the digital alarm clock around so she could see it.

“Five minutes, no more.”

I gripped my hands around her waist and thrust deeply, she started to talk then stopped. She was obviously disinterested in what I was doing which didn’t bother me but by her impatience I was feeling, I wouldn’t have five minutes. I tried as hard as I could, I was forcing my orgasm which wasn’t fun but it was all I could do. She stopped me.

“I have to turn over, I feel sick.”

She did so and I reentered her.

The red numbers of the clock glared at me,. I felt like stopping and telling the bitch to go back to sleep and leave me alone, masturbating was far more fun than this. Another minute clicked over, three left. I was getting close; a small knot formed in me, my release was close at hand. She looked off into the dark room.

“Sorry if it’s not as good as you like.”

She put her hands on my waist and pushed me out. She rolled over and pulled the covers around her.

“I’m tired of all the talk. Fuck you.” (Didn’t this scene appear earlier?!)

I sat on my knees, dumbfounded.

“I still had two minutes, what the hell Gale?”

“Forget it, you fucked up.”

I had experienced too much excitement, too close to orgasm. I got up and masturbated into the bathroom sink. As I finished, I thought to run the water and clean it up, but decided to leave it as a token for her in the morning.

I had a lot of ground to make up, many things to do. I had to talk to Rhindy about moving back in, there was no way in hell I could pay rent next month. As soon as I finished a frustrating day at work, I made my way into the city. It was late and she wasn't home, I went to a small bar down the street and waited.

There was enough money in my pocket to buy a couple of beers and I finished my cigarettes. I let an hour pass unnoticed and on the return trip the lights were on in the apartment. I was going to timidly knock on the door and play the sappy, destitute guy, but decided on a more direct approach. I let myself in. She was sitting on the couch and was startled at my presence.

"Hi, Rhindy."

She offered me a seat and we talked. At first, the conversation was stilted, but it improved and we talked for more than an hour and a half. I smiled frequently and found I said things I normally wouldn't have. I needed a place and quick, yes, but there was guilt in my soul for approaching her solely for the purpose of moving in. I had difficulty getting over it.

She asked me to stay the night. I smiled to myself as she led me by the hand to the bedroom.

She quickly undressed herself and sat on the edge of the bed. She pulled down my pants and took me into her mouth. She blew me well—better than I remembered—she skillfully used her tongue to tease me; she sucked on the head almost to orgasm then stopped when she knew I was close. I climbed on top of her and quickly entered her. Her orgasm was quick and so was mine. I pulled out and shot my come onto

her chest and face, she ran her tongue around her lips and squeezed the remaining from me into her mouth. I went to the bathroom for some tissues to clean her up.

“I know you don’t like it in your face, I’m sorry.”

“Usually I don’t but this time it seemed appropriate.”

We lay next to each other, the blackness of night faded into the fibers of my soul. I looked to the ceiling and found a strange, welcoming feeling in me. It was forced, not entirely accidental, and demeaning. I never thought I would commit suicide, I never thought I would be desperate, I thought I had a gift to do wondrous things in my life, a perception that I believed would not only remind me that I was special, but something that would assure me I was worth a damn. Everything was a lie, my life, my writing, and my existence; nothing but blackness surrounded me—as far as my eyes could not see. I had sacrificed myself for a moot cause, I became the martyr of mediocrity; I was the patron saint of less than nothing. As my arm was around Rhindy, I hated myself, hated what I had become and what I was to be. Yet, it seemed to be my destiny; if I was to exist, I had to live with it. My hollow eyes glanced at her, the image of her face burned into my mind—I had been defeated, not by her, not by Gale, not by Azlya, and not by Ninety-Nine. I died not for them but because I hadn’t the courage to fight. Suicide. Rhindy’s breath was on my neck, I conceded. For the first time, this broken shell of a man whose dead eyes were upon her, found that he missed her. He missed her dearly.

I ended up staying with her for two days. I had insisted on leaving after the first night but she said she would feel better if I at least stayed a second. As the door closed, I had the feeling the living situation was straightened out. It didn’t feel as good as I thought it would. I felt as if I were using her, I hope she couldn’t read my mind.

In the late afternoon, I ventured to the apartment on Bellevue. It was near to the end of the month. Gale was getting ready to leave; she had an easy life ahead, she was going back to her parents', which is always a safe and sure bet. I heard voices in the back lot and the door was open. The place was pretty cleared out, not that there was much in the first place. She was in the kitchen putting dishes into a box.

"You picking up your stuff?"

"What I have."

Colin and two guys with long, dirty hair came in. They might have been in his band since they had the same distant, blank looks as he.

"What's up, Chris?"

I nodded as they went over to the mattress; the sheets were already gone. They picked it up and hauled it to the balcony. I looked at Gale.

"What the hell are they doing?"

"Watch."

I followed them out only to see them huck the thing off it, apparently the truck was down below. Their aim was bad.

"You missed."

Colin smiled. "Planned it that way, dude."

"Great."

"So what are you up to?"

I reached for a cigarette, only to realize I didn't have any.

"Not much." The two guys left the room.

"Do you have a smoke, dude?"

I dug into my pockets again. "No. Sorry."

"It's cool." He left me in the room and I went to the balcony to see them try to pack the mattress on top of the other junk in the back of the truck. From the looks of it, it was a case of extremely bad planning. I figured it probably would have been a good idea to drop the mattress first but. . .

“Can you give me a hand with the dishes?”

I gazed at her, wrinkling my nose at the audacity of the thought. The memory of the last time we had sex (if it could be called that) was still fresh in my mind. I wasn't about to do anything remotely nice for her. I said nothing and went to the closet grabbing several racks of clothes. I left her standing by the balcony speechless.

—Life can be tortuous at times, and damn mean.

I went back to the city and put what little I had taken in their old places in Rhindy's apartment. The process took me but a half an hour, after realizing how little I had accumulated in my life, I found the reflection simultaneously comforting and irritating. I supposed I should have more things yet I wasn't materialistic; I was glad to have so few things because it was easy whenever I moved yet I wanted more. I felt pleased to see my things in and around the apartment; they reminded me of where I had been, with who, and how I came crawling back—regressing, locked into anti-time, the future held nothing. I was running backwards.

I lay on the bed. A turquoise cockatoo I had gotten as a Christmas present from Theresa years ago was still hanging from the ceiling light—its porcelain smile was cold and twisted. I tried to sleep, but found myself restless. Television was a joke, and no book or piece of music could entertain me; the only thing I felt could relieve me was to take a drive, besides, I should check the place one last time just in case I had forgotten something.

It was dark when I arrived; the room was vacant, there wasn't any sign that we had ever lived here, save a flat spot in the carpet where the mattress had been. The desk was gone and the curtain were off the windows; I stood where I used to sit and type. On that spot I fought and wrestled and cried as the paper was stained either with fortuitous sentences and paragraphs depicting art in its purest form, or else blank

whiteness, which laughed at me, mocking, restraining my thoughts and beliefs in my abilities as a writer. Although I hated Gale on her own terms—for the true piece of shit that she was—the place wasn't all that bad because I had gotten a lot of work done; more than I had ever done to date, for which I would always be glad. I heard footsteps in the hall and, for a second, I thought Gale might throw the front door open at any moment. I took the key off my ring and set it on the counter, tapping it once with my finger. So many dreams, so many aspirations, so many disappointments.

I turned out the light and lay in the flat spot on the floor. Light from somewhere streamed through the window. It cast odd colored shadows on the wall. I set my hands behind my head and watched them. They never moved. Not once.

Chapter 11

Time has been a thief once again, creeping in the dark of night stealing the bits of life I hold onto, fading the memories changing them from vivid color to black and white to a blur. A lot of time has passed—God only knows how much—but I find I have to look at the calendar to see when the ordeal with Gale ended. The result is never pleasant. Only recently I've been discovering why I left this apartment and Rhindy. Today I feel repressed, mute, without as much of anything to say to do or write about. The days are dull, even at work (B Dalton, downtown SF), and the night can sometimes be torture; but I've learned to deal with it, to ignore my mind's cries for release. I occupy it with other duties, like car shit or something else equally as boring. Anything that takes me away from having to realize that I'm not producing, not creating, not doing the thing that drives me. Anything that will make me forget that I slit the throat of the part that is truly me. Yes, I'm still an artist, I haven't completely killed it off, I'm sure of it. I guess being in this safe, closed, sterile environment has made me realize that.

If I could only find a way to work in such a place then all would be well, but I have tried and failed miserably. In fact, I find it strange that I'm writing now, but the words seem to flow today, my head is full of Dostoyevsky. Things continue on a straight, constant line; I am probably dead, but won't let myself believe it.

Rhindy attempted to make a dinner the other night. It didn't agree with me, I didn't like my casserole so well done, but I tried to eat it to please her. I still felt guilty having hurt her when I left, so I shouldn't make any nasty comments. Christ, what the hell was happening to me? I was never like this, I never thought to fold to others, patronize them. It's these sterile walls with the same posters I hung two years ago; it's the cats in baskets on the bookshelf, and the pewter wind-chime cats hanging in the window, slowly, slowly driving me insane. It's the damn porcelain cockatoo glaring impetuously down at me, pushing me. One day I will smash it's cold smile, I will destroy it. One day I will huck the pewter cats out the window, like Colin did with Gale's mattress. And when it happens and Rhindy wonders what could have ever inspired me to do such a thing, I will say,

"Planned it that way, dude." And I will smile and laugh.

I rubbed my forehead. These thoughts were not entering my head, they were not going to overtake me again. I'm finally stable, becoming normal; I'm not going to jeopardize my relationship with Rhindy. I'm going to settle this seething duality if it kills me. Oh, and one other thing.

I dreamt last night.

I am standing on a dirty road, a faded peach house is in the distance. The road is straight and clear, there are no obstructions. The sun is hot, it beats down on me. There is a sweet, pleasant voice in the air.

"Come to me. . ."

It is from the house, I know it. Perhaps someone in a window is calling out. I walk toward the estate, the house is alone on this barren dusty landscape, there is nothing else: not a hill or an outcrop of rock as far as the eye can see. I remember this place, I first saw it in the theater and in another dream. The wind picks up and dust chokes me, my view of the house is blurred; I rub my eyes trying to clear the dirt. Something is touching my face.

I am holding a cold cloth to my face, it is moist and it feel comforting. As I open my eyes, I see that I am on the porch of the house. There is a lounge chair and a pitcher of lemonade with two filled glasses.

“Help yourself.”

The voice again. I hear footsteps in the house, they are light and delicate. The screen door is opened and a woman in a tan summer dress comes out. I know her, her features are familiar: her round face, light skin, full lips, red hair; she is tall and thin and as she comes closer I see that her eyes are the same color as her hair, they are a passive reddish color—sanguine. Her gaze is fixed with mine.

“I am Anna.”

At this point in the dream, I remember waking up being confused. Was I sleeping with Gale in San Mateo or was I with Rhindy or was I staying with Azlya? It took a few minutes, but I regained myself and thankfully didn’t wake Rhindy. The voice again.

“Come back to me. . .”

I am with Anna in her house, we are in her bedroom upstairs. I look out the window and see where I started walking on the dusty road leading here. The terrain is treacherous; I was surprised I to have made it at all. Anna puts her arm around me, I notice that I am in an expensive suit and tie. She is warm, I can feel something strong within her; it is the same feeling I had on Pierce Street looking across the bay, when I was missing everything. I didn’t know then, but I feel

I know now. It is her, she feels like the Ninety-Nine I had been hoping for. But how can that be true? It can't be. She isn't real. Yes, at this moment she feels quite real, this house is solid, but it disappears when I wake and she is nowhere to be found. She kisses my ear.

"You are a great writer. Keep persevering, you'll make it. I'm sure of it."

I sigh heavily, back to the writing issue. I put my arm around her and pull her close to me. She turns me, facing a full length mirror. We seem so perfect together. She smiles peacefully, we are one.

"I know it's hard for you, I see how much you suffer. You find that you're confused a lot of the time. Maybe you think you want to destroy yourself. If you ever do, you'll be here, like me, desolate and lonely."

I close my eyes and feel her breathe. I want to ask her: why is she dead, how she died, when she lived, about her time—there are so many questions but I seem to already know the answers. No sense in asking, no sense in logically trying to figure all this out, I will drive myself crazy. I whisper to her.

"It seems as if I failed."

"No, you have done so much, don't think like that. . ."

Her voice trails off and I look at her. Her face is frozen, she is staring into the mirror. I slowly look and fear seizes me.

In the reflection I can see the window behind us, the landscape has once again changed. There are large pipes on stilts running beside the house; black dirty oil drips from their seams, seeping into the arid soil—the blackness spreading.

"What is it?"

She does not speak nor move. My only thought is how I was going to get back. I turn from the mirror and go to the window, there are no pipes or putrid oils, just dry dusty landscape. I look back to Anna and the mirror, both have vanished, her dress is hanging in a closet built

into the wall. I listen for a voice, a sign of what has happened to her. I want to hold her again, feel her warmth, have that feeling of complete happiness. Nothing is left to comfort me. I am once again alone with my thoughts, they creep on me and steal the everything I have left in me.

I wake and Rhindy has already gone to work. The apartment is cold and no sun shines through the windows. The day is overcast and melancholy.

Chapter 12

I must confess, I have not written in ages. Nearly two years to be exact. So many things have changed and I have not kept track of them. To be honest, I have not felt like writing the whole time I was in remission, the painful urge to do so never struck me. I have been living in a safe, comfortable hell. Rhindy comes home from work and gives me a kiss on the cheek and asks why I haven't been taking care of the apartment. I tell her I was busy, that I was either doing errands or looking for a particular book or maybe doing something artistic—if I can believe I still pursue such things. She would sigh, smirk, and change in the bedroom since there was no sense getting on my ass about it. She knew that if she did, I would offer nothing except an emotionless gaze.

Lately, I've been going out and staying away until very late, it drives Rhindy crazy and I feel it's justified. She's made me crazy these past two years without as much as a sentence coming out of the typewriter. Only estranged, confused strings of words spew forth. Last night, I went out with a new woman through Nick. Her name was Heather.

The more things change the more history seems to repeat itself. On Nick: the Grenadine situation turned sour and she disappeared from him. He thought she might have died but that was too dramatic—even for him. I figured she couldn't stand his tumultuous bulk and immature

bantering any longer. But now he's got a more irritating woman now, she worse than all the others put together. She doesn't really have a name; I coined the name Stress for her, seeing as that is the only feeling she can stir in me (and Nick). But he seems content with her, though. I guess they deserve each other.

"She's really nice, Chris." He told me once.

"Maybe. But she's not all that bright."

"Well, yeah, but she gives a good blow job. That's all that counts."

"Okay, I'll buy that."

I laughed at him.

On Gale: A year nearly went by before she got into contact with me. She did move back in with her parents, then moved in with her ex-boyfriend, wife beater, father of her child; and as she put it, 'lived in total hell and fear for almost six months'. I sympathized with her; no one, not even her, deserved the life she lived during that time. I promised after we lived together at Bellevue, I would never speak to her again, but seeing that she was a broken, lonely soul without anybody to talk to, I chose to renew our friendship, if it could have ever been called that. Was I making yet another mistake? Only time would tell. Now she was on the verge of getting her own place in Pacifica. She seemed happy about the idea, and we both agreed that it was for the best. She wanted me to come up and see her kid sometime. I said, "Sure", but didn't give an exact date as to when I would actually visit her.

These afternoons are nice, especially so since I've begun to write again. It gives me something to hope for, that maybe one day I may achieve my dream of becoming a writer. I suppose I am now, but it doesn't feel like it. Writers are supposed to be published before they are considered so and I haven't had as much as a word put into print since the homemade magazines in high school. And I don't count that

since it had a limited readership if it was ever read at all. I was destined for something greater.

The phone rang and someone was pounding at the window. The phone was for Rhindy; I quickly ended the conversation and found Nick at the door.

“Dude, let’s go to the beach and pound some beers.

I got my jacket and thought to leave a note. Rhindy’s arrival was only a half-hour or so away and she adamantly requested that I leave a note whenever leaving unannounced.

“Fuck it.”

The sun was nearly setting when we arrived at the beach. The sand was warm and the beers cold. Nick insisted on buying 40-ouncers of Mickey’s. He said it was a good Irish beer that had a little extra kick to it. I was astonished that the conversation between us was strained, he seemed to have something on his mind. It took to almost the bottom of the bottle before he decided to talk about it.

“Chris, I really like Stress but I want to fuck someone else too. But she’s really nice, I don’t know what to do.”

“Well, I . . .”

“Like there’s this fine redhead that works downtown. Her name is Heather and I want to fuck her, bad, but Stress might get upset.”

“Yeah, she might.”

“But it seems that she wants me to go out and fuck her so I can tell her about it. Do you think that’s weird?”

“For Stress, yes. Others, no. Rhindy, very odd.”

“Stress wants the three of us to go out, but I don’t think it’ll work. I think I’ll have to set Heather up with someone then go from there.”

He looked at me, his eyes were hazy and his mouth hung open. Tiny droplets of drool formed in the corners.

“You like redheads, don’t you?”

Rhindy was one.

“It’s been said.”

“The animation festival’s coming up, that’s usually a good place to have a first date.”

I didn’t like what was going through his head. Soon he was going to ask me if I would be game to going out with this Heather chick. I despised blind dates, especially with the types of women Nick defined as “fine”. That usually meant they had something wrong with them.

“I don’t know, Nick, maybe you should consider someone else.”

“What? Who?”

By the look on his face I saw that his train of thought had derailed and derailed hard. The passengers as his brain cells were strewn dead along the tracks.

“Never mind.”

He started talking about his car and how he wished he was a street racer. Then he wished he was living in the fifties. Then he wished he had the perfect engine in his 50s car that was fast—maybe a dual quad, 30-inch cross ram, 413 Chrysler Wedge. When he wished for the perfect woman, I wished I had done something else.

The phone was ringing as I walked into the apartment. It was Gale. She did away with the usual phone condolences and got straight to the point.

“I moved into my new place a few days ago, you should come down and see it.”

My watch read 8:40, Rhindy wasn’t home yet and I was thankful for it. I could have wondered why she was late, but I didn’t think that hard about it. The couch looked comfortable, I wanted to lay down and go to sleep. This seemed to happen every time I had a few drinks in me. I never pass out, just go to sleep.

“Well. . .come and see me.”

“I’m tired.”

“I’ll blow you.”

I wasn’t sure I heard her right.

“What?”

“I’ll blow you.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“For just coming to see you.”

“We can fuck if you like.”

“Just like the old days, huh?”

“No, I need you. I need that hard cock inside me, ramming me deep.”

I discovered that I had a hard-on. I rubbed my face, it had sand on it.

“Since you put it that way, I guess I could come down—for a little while anyway.”

“Good. Don’t hang around there. Oh, is Rhindy home? No? Good. Leave right away. Be here in a half-hour. I’ll be ready.”

I gave her a token goodbye and hung up. The hallway door opened and I pictured Rhindy coming in as I was going out. There would be questions and I, in a slight stupor, would have to come up with an excuse as to where I was going, who I was seeing, and when I would be back. Luckily, it was one of the neighbors. I breathed a sigh of relief and left as quickly as I could.

She was standing on the balcony of her apartment when I arrived. She waved as I parked my car. There was a man standing next to her, he appeared to be an older, lecherous type who probably lived in her complex. She introduced me to him, his name was Billy. I wasn’t too concerned. He looked me up and down then held out his hand for a shake. I refused it since I wasn’t in the mood to meet new people and

besides, I had the odd feeling I would be seeing a lot of his presence in the future—and not in a good way. He left and she gave me the tour of her place. It was a small two bedroom apartment, the walls a stark white with yellowed ceilings, a small inadequate kitchen, and outdated furniture (from her mother's house). It reminded me of the apartment Rhindy and I shared in the city except that our place had more character; it had hardwood floors instead of the welfare carpet she had. She offered me a drink; her kid was stumbling around screaming.

"I have a confession to make."

"What's that?"

"I went out with one of my newspaper lovers night before last. . ."

"You're still doing that?"

"Off and on, I put an ad in a few weeks ago. Anyway, we went out to dinner and I got a little drunk. Well, on the way back to my car, he invited me up to his room. He was at the Triton Hotel, you know the one? Normally I wouldn't have, but I was drunk, and he offered to get into S&M with me, so I agreed. So I lay on the bed, he tied me up, undressed me, then as I was starting to get into it, he whiffed it out and started beating off.

"'Would you be my little whore', he said. And, 'I'll be your daddy', shit like that. What is it with these forty-year-olds with their daddy complex? You were never like that."

"I'm not the fatherly type."

"He came on my chest and I felt so disgusted. I showered three times. I need you to cleanse me."

I drank from my soda and she put her kid to bed. Cleanse huh? Sounds like the same old Gale to me, but now I wasn't about to believe anything she said, I wasn't about to get involved. Why was I here? I couldn't answer. There was absolutely no reason why I should fuck her

except for the pure sake of doing so? It was that distance between us that I had to constantly be in touch with.

She came out of the bedroom, her arms wide.

“Shall we?”

She undressed before me. I tied her hands together to the bedpost; it was rickety, but it would hold. She lay on the bed, her ass facing me. Her breaths were quick as I pulled a riding crop out of her closet. This S&M thing wasn't something I was used to, I had to apply a lot of creativity to make it believable.

“I want you to do it until I cry.”

I gripped the crop hard and brought it down on her ass, she winced. I did it again, same reaction. I smiled to myself.

“So you feel you've sinned. You let somebody take advantage of you and it wasn't me. And that is wrong. You didn't even know him.”

I hit her again.

“On the first date, he treated you like a whore and how much did he give you?”

She murmured into the pillow. “Twenty bucks.”

“Then you are a cheap whore.”

I hit her again, harder.

“What am I going to do with you?”

I struck her repeatedly until I got the count up to nearly thirty before she broke down. Her skin was a deep crimson. I turned her over, and I fucked her. She was worthless and weak and could not fight me, could not say anything demeaning to me because I had the riding crop still in my hand. She tried to do her usual porno-talk but I stuffed her bra into her mouth. She squirmed.

“You must be punished. I will revile you. I will desecrate you. Only then will you be cleansed.”

I rammed myself hard into her, letting my orgasm slowly build, taking longer and longer. When I felt it knot in my balls, I yanked the bra out of her mouth and grabbed her jaw, holding her mouth open. She shook her head.

“No, no, not in my mouth. Not on my face.”

She was trying to turn her head, trying to push me out of her. But I held her fast and hard, she wasn't about to stop me from having my revenge. All those months and years of having to put up with her shit, of her timing me, making me watch the clock, only giving me five minutes to come. Well, I'm taking as long as I fucking want, bitch. I'll make you sore for a week if I feel like it and don't think I don't feel like it. I slammed into her, I was close to coming. I smiled, Cheshire, down on her.

I pulled out and shoved my dick only an inch from her open mouth. She tried to close it then tried to bite me, but I was too strong. My come shot on her tongue, on her lips and all over her face. She tried to spit it out, I grabbed her throat while still holding the back of her jaw. I shot several times into her mouth, I felt her throat move as if it was trying to push out the come.

I had soaked her, she reeked of sperm. I squeezed myself for all I was worth, placing it on her tongue. She jerked and convulsed, trying to shake herself free. I had tied her tight and made her swallow all I had put in her.

She became limp, exhausted, defeated. I heard her breathe a sigh of relief. Both she and I knew that, for now, she had done her penance.

I woke the next morning with a splitting headache. A couple of swallows of whiskey and a beer had helped me get to sleep when I got home from Gale's. They seemed the perfect celebration of my revenge against her. I had been dreaming of that moment for two years, now I could get on with my life.

I went to the bathroom in a haze. I took some aspirin and the phone rang. It was Nick.

“Dude, meet Stress and I downtown this afternoon. I have someone you have to meet.”

“Heather?”

“Yeah. How soon can you get down to Powell and Market?”

“Give me an hour.”

“Cool. . .”

I hung up and looked out the window into the offices across the way. The employees were busy running from room to room, their ant-like activity aggravating the pounding in my head.

I took the train downtown. The ride wasn't as bad as I thought it would be; the aspirin was starting to kick in. I met them in front of Blonde's Pizza on Powell, by the cable-car turnstile.

“You'll like her, man. She's tall, a redhead, and fine.”

Stress was smiling to herself. She tried to be the mischievous, bitch figure, but in her own French, mousy way, she was an inadequate as Nick was. They were the perfect match.

“Chris with a fine redhead. I can picture it.”

I rolled my eyes at her, mumbling to myself.

We walked to down Market to Stockton and smack into a huge record store, it's monolithic facade towering in black and neon above us. This was where Heather worked, and I immediately felt I was starting to get on the right track. That this gothic-modern building, dark and ominous, functioned as the gateway between one life, one reality, and the next. And once I passed through, there would be no turning back beyond this point. I knew if I did enter, I would be eventually dismantled intellectually, and then rebuilt and rewritten. What thoughts I could hold onto, what feelings, emotions, perceptions survived the process

were bound together, interwoven with fibrous strings of indecipherable logic.

We walked in and I separated from them. I leafed through selections of various music I wanted to buy, but couldn't shake the feelings I was having. What would become of me? How was this process going to take place and how much of what I knew about myself would survive? I picked up a CD I thought I wanted to buy, but lost track of it as I wandered to Nick and Stress in the video department. They were talking to a tall, blazing redhead, dressed completely in black, wearing riding boots that stretched just above her calves. She had on a suede skirt and fishnet stockings. Her shirt was loose fitting and white; she wore a leather vest over it, her name tag stuck just above her breasts. Her voice was gruff and her name screamed at me. The printed block letters screaming at me. I heard her speaking to Nick in the low, coarse tone she had. I crept up behind her and eyed Nick from over her shoulder, the white skin on her neck alabaster, her perfume intoxicating. Nick's eyes met mine, he motioned to Heather. She turned and faced me.

"This is Chris," Nick announced. We smiled at each other for a second and she turned back to them. I wandered around the aisle and stood beside Nick.

"The animation festival's coming up," he said to her. "The midnight show is the best."

"I went last year, they're a lot of fun. . ."

Nick cut her off. "When's your lunch?"

She looked at her watch. "In about ten minutes, but I have a friend meeting me."

"Okay, we asked you to lunch, but you said no."

"I would, but I already promised. . ."

"It's cool."

We stayed until her lunch and walked her out. I split from them to go to the bank. Out of the corner of my eye, I saw Heather leave her friend's car and run over to Nick. As I returned, she jumped into the friend's car. I gave Nick a confused look as we started walking back to the train station.

"Her friend's nice looking," Stress said to anybody who would listen. He looked at me and smiled.

"What?"

"She likes the Chrisman. She wanted to know if you had a girlfriend."

"What did you tell her?"

"That you did, but were breaking up."

"Oh."

They pulled away from the curb. Nick slapped me on the back and when Heather and her friend passed, they waved to us. Stress had a pseudo-devilish smile on her plain, mousy face.

So here I was in an annoyingly similar situation. Meeting someone new under the duress of having a girlfriend, it happened with Azlya, and actually with Rhindy as well—I was ending a relationship with Theresa at the time. Was this the way I went from one relationship to another? By the sign of the times I would have to say yes. But I was a self-proclaimed hedonist, a believer in free life, a subscriber to the Miller philosophy, a dabbler in the art of debauchery and prone to doing whatever I felt I was right. Well, that's a lie. Nothing I felt was either right or wrong, just different facets of my personality, which half wanted to control half on me. It was beyond me, my mind wanted no limitations, it had its fill of literary experiences and now was going to act them out to see if the theories that bounced around in it would work in what was termed "reality". Interesting work to say the least. But my mind was not quite prepped enough, it needed more. It was like a dried, greedy sponge craving more and more experience. I had to

give it what it desired or else it would turn on me making me physically sick. A prisoner to experience, a slave to the mind. But would this new Heather thing turn out like what happened with Azlya? Would it end up vanishing or disintegrating into nothing? Would the break-up be vicious and painful? Would I be obsessed with memories, downtrodden and empty? Or would this new reality I was in turn out differently? Perhaps it would all work out in the end. But that's as it usually goes. It was far too early to tell.

A couple of days passed and Nick called me. He asked if I would be available tomorrow (Friday) to go to the midnight animation festival.

"It's a little short notice. I'm going to have to come up with a serious excuse for Rhindy."

"Not like you haven't done it before."

"Yeah, I know, but I'm tired of it all. I'm sick of having to make excuses, of having to tell lies. It's wearing on me."

"But it's Heather! Look at Rhindy then at Heather and tell me what you see."

"Two redheads."

"Who's finer?"

"Well, Heather's 5'10", thin, long hair, hyper; Rhindy's medium height, good in bed, obnoxious, and sometimes gets on my nerves—only because I've been going out with her for nearly four years, so. . ."

"Heather's better, trust me. Besides you have something in common."

"What's that?"

"She's an artist. You two art fags will get along well."

"Fuck you."

"Stress talked to her. She likes you. She says she has a meeting to go to, but we can pick her up at 9:30. We'll kill some time until midnight."

“Okay, sounds good. I guess I’ll pick you guys up around 8:30 so we’ll make it on time, seeing that it’s all the way across town and all.”

“I’m having trouble with my car, you wouldn’t mind driving would you?”

I shook my head and looked out the window.

“What’s wrong with your car now?”

“It runs funny and the registration expired a couple of weeks ago.”

“How are you getting around?”

“I take my parents’ car when I can.”

“Okay. I’ll drive. I’ll see you tomorrow.”

“Cool. Later.”

I carefully set the phone in its cradle. I sat at my desk, stared at the typewriter, to my books, then to the radio and television. The silence was comforting, then a streetcar rumbling by jilted me, God did I hate living in the city. So much to do, but no time for yourself.

Rhindy came in as I finally settled down to write. She was home early and asked if I wanted to see a movie with her. I hesitantly agreed and found I had a better time than I thought I would. We held hands for the first time in weeks and I even managed to squeeze a kiss or two out of her in the depths of the theater. But I had the feeling we would be splitting up again; it wasn’t the Heather thing that made me think it, but something about the situation with her was going to cause great change and I had to be ready for it. I better get as much from Rhindy as I can right now because everything will soon be turned upside down. I was used to conflict and being alone, but survival was something I really never had to deal with. I always had things taken care of and the thought of losing everything scared the hell out of me. Maybe the Anna thing entered into my mind too, that seemed to be going somewhere but if I had to die to see her again, if that was the only way, I wasn’t sure if I could make the sacrifice. Jon warned me

years ago that Sheri would somehow be entering my life—I guess he was partially correct. It is somebody dead who is affecting me, but not somebody who is familiar. And Heather reminds me of somebody, somebody; I can't think who, I can't get my mind to put it together. It is mocking me, it won't tell me. . .or perhaps. . .it doesn't know either.

Something told me to dress well that night. I searched the closet a half-hour and finally decided on black pants, shirt and dark suit coat. A tie, nah; I liked wearing one, especially on first dates, but thinking how casual Nick would dress, I imagined it would be overkill. I showered and shaved and when I finished getting dressed, I decided I didn't look any different than I usually do. But it would have to suffice. At the last moment, as I was out the door, I decided to put on a fedora who's color matched the jacket. Rhindy was gone and wouldn't be home until very early in the morning. She had planned to go out with some people from work, she asked if I had wanted to go, but I pleasantly refused. No excuses, no lies; it worked out wonderfully. Even the car seemed to be in a good mood and with the key in hand and liberal cologne around my neck, I drove to Nick's and picked him and Stress up.

It was when we picked up Heather that the odd feeling came back. I had gone to the door to meet her and when she came out, something hit me in a flash. It was the way she dressed. She was wearing a forties' style dress, cream colored with red fringes around the jacket sleeve; maybe it was something I had imagined in the dream, then it clicked: her red hair, smooth skin, and reddish-brown, sanguine, eyes. It was her eyes. For an instant she reminded me of Anna, from the dream in the house, the landscape, the mirror, and the pipes; Heather even smiled the same—her voice was the only thing that separated the two of them. I wanted to tell her, but not now, maybe someday I would;

then again, maybe I wouldn't. I was completely enamored, sinking deeply into a gelatinous pit.

"You look nice tonight," she said, looking me straight in the eye.

I couldn't respond, only smile.

"I'm ready, are you?"

"Let's go."

I walked her out to the car and opened the door for her. She smiled longingly at me, running her finger along my chin as she got in.

About a month ago, as a joke, I wrote a pamphlet called 'Sex in the 90's'. It was a sarcastic, stolid, emotionless look at the dating scene with helpful hints how to succeed in it. It seemed to go over well with the people I gave the few copies to; everyone agreed that it wasn't to be taken seriously, but I found myself flipping thorough the pages trying to find a bit of advice as to what I should do about the situation I was now. It's a laugh following one's own advice, dangerous believing the answers lie within, but I found through all the vague metaphors and copious scenarios, a fragment that might prove noteworthy. It was grouped within a contractual clause, it said that one should know exactly what they want and find ways of going about getting it. So, if one only wanted sex, then it would be cut off after that point. If a relationship was to ensue, then it would be pursued, but always focusing on the desire aspect was of the utmost importance. Okay, I bought into it; well, I did write it, so I should already have that programming in me, but it was decidedly absent. I was looking at the print in the book through the eyes of a stranger; I became lost and hopeless to the world that had swallowed me whole.

Goddamnit, Miller never seemed to have this kind of problem—at least I haven't read where he talked about it. If he were in this situation, he would just let things go as they would without any interference from him—being the eternal casual observer. Most times I felt that way,

an outsider seeing the world whirl by, but whenever I found myself involved in something then it was very possible for me to be in trouble. As with the case of Heather, I had a good time last night—she asked if I wanted to get something to eat since we only had coffee earlier. I dropped Nick and Stress off, and we went to a Zim’s restaurant on Van Ness. Instead of talking, trying to learn more about each other, we were engaged in head games for at least an hour. Shortly after, I took her home. I thought the night a complete failure. But to save face, I would say the games were entertaining, but then again, I had my fill of them. I constantly had to do it with Gale and Rhindy, Heather was someone I didn’t want to start that up with.

Rhindy’s tearing around behind me, taking a minute or two to sigh about the condition of the apartment or tell me how I’m not keeping up with my duties. I’m ignoring her, but it’s becoming hard to work since she’s insisting on hovering over me wondering what I’m writing, what I could possibly be so absorbed with. I want to tell her I’m thinking of Heather, that although we only met a few days before, I thinking of her now, wondering how the whole thing is going to turn out, what would be gained and what would be lost. As time evaporated, I found we had hit it off better than I thought. Nick said Stress talked to her and she was intrigued with me. She wanted to know more about me. I got the message that I was to meet her after work Tuesday at eleven p.m. I told Rhindy I was going over to Nick’s and drove downtown. I arrived a little before eleven and she was already waiting outside. I got out and opened the door for her. She gave me a sly smile and sat in the seat.

“Where do you want to go?” She asked me as I pulled the door shut.

“Maybe get something to eat.”

“Okay.”

We drove to Zim's. I had a patty melt and she a grilled cheese sandwich. We smiled continuously at each other across the table.

"How long have you know Nick?"

"About three years, maybe more."

"The two of them, they seem strange. I did a Tarot reading before I decided to go out with the three of you. There's a lot of weird energy coming from them, but you seem to be okay."

"Gee, thanks."

"No, I'm serious, there's something very strange about them. Nick seems to have a lot of hate inside him and his girlfriend. . ."

"Stress."

She laughed. "Yes, Stress, she baits him. I think she's sneaky and plotting something."

"I was thinking that, but I can't place what she has in mind. Probably something sexual since she lacks any sexual mystique about her."

She laughed again. "I don't know about that, I'm not into women. Tried it once, but decided I like guys."

It was quiet between us. I let the silence rapture me.

"No sense talking about them," she said. "I don't think they deserve the effort."

"You're right."

I wanted to ask her so many questions about her life, what she wanted to do and what she already had done. But there would be time for that later, too many words ruin the mood. We finished our meals and sat staring.

"Let's get out of here." I said.

We spent the bulk of the evening driving around the city. Since it was late and she didn't drink, there was nothing much for us to do. The night waned and I could tell she was tired. She said she had a long, stressful, boring day at work; I guessed by her remarks that she

didn't want to stay out late. It was just as well since it was two in the morning and Rhindy would probably be wondering where the hell I was. She lived in a flat on Lake Street near Sixth Avenue that she shared with her parents.

As I pulled up to the curb, an air of hesitance, which had been between us most of the night, prevailed. We sat staring at each other as the car idled and idled. We laughed nervously, caught glances then quickly looked away. I wanted to lean over and kiss her. I had the feeling she wanted the same but I wasn't sure. I was focused on the Miller philosophy and what had appeared in my book,

"Know what you want and take it."

I wanted to taste her and my thoughts giving me permission didn't make it any easier. Suddenly, she let out a long sigh.

"Let's get this over with."

She reached her hand around my neck and pressed my lips to hers. We kissed softly, slowly at first, then more passionately. She knew what she was doing, knew what she wanted me to feel by the way she teased me with her tongue. My mind reeled; in a matter of seconds I had an erection, hopefully she wouldn't notice. Several minutes went by. Then she broke away from me.

"I really have to be going. If I stay here any longer, I might do something more."

"I'll let you go then. Can't have you doing anything you'll later regret."

"Do you have a pen?"

I searched my pockets and the glove box. Nothing.

"No."

She pulled out a small tube of lipstick and wrote her name on a small slip of paper. The numbers glowed red.

"Thanks."

She got out of the car, waved good-bye, and I put the paper in the glove box. I drove away with a big smile on my face and a head full of excuses for Rhindy.

It was Thursday, I let the time pass quickly. It was the end of April; time has had its way with me again, stealing away like it does. I never felt any older or wiser, only the sense of loss as my memories continue to fade. But there was comfort in time passing; after I got over the shock of the change, I realized it further distanced me from the shit that stagnated me. I felt a little freer knowing Heather, knowing there was some connection between she and Anna.

Today, Rhindy came home in a tiff; she was in a bad mood about something and I really didn't feel like getting involved since it would require almost an hour to put her straight. And I didn't have any energy today, the heat drained me; I only wished it would cool off. I only wished for the clouds to choke the sun, washing over me an inebriating grey. Letting things pass as they will is a wonderful thing, you don't have to be responsible for anything that happens. The grey seething into you, separating the conscious self from the multitude of dreamy desires.

"I'm thinking of going to Napa with my friends Saturday. You're welcome to go, but I figure you won't."

I thought about it for a minute and decided quickly.

"I have a lot of writing that I should be doing. It sounds nice, but I don't think I'll be able."

"I don't know, I'm sure you'll have some raging parties while I'm gone."

"While the cat's away. . ."

"Funny. You better not. . ."

"Look, I don't know anybody and I sure as hell don't want Nick hanging around here with that horrid girlfriend of his."

“I’ll phone you while I’m at work. I’m supposed to talk to Bob then, maybe we can get Jen to go.”

Another one of her friends. One from the college days.

“Fine. Tell me tomorrow.”

If there was to be great change, Rhindy was going to have to find things for herself to do with out the aid of me. She had to be responsible for her own entertainment.

LAST THIRTY DAYS

May 2. Rhindy said yesterday, she was going to go to Napa with some friends and spend the weekend. I phoned Heather on Friday afternoon before Rhindy came home from work to see if she could stay over Saturday night. She agreed.

The transition has begun, everything that has been said must be said again as if to remind oneself of the path he has taken to get to this point. Beyond this, everything will and will not be said, everything and nothing will be implied and immutable. Rhindy is but the past as Anna is but the past; yet Anna is also the future as Rhindy is not. Anna exists always and is not prone to logical discourse deriving itself from puerile existence; she remains pure, untainted, unburdened with aspersive duality. She is elusive and attainable; she will extirpate and instaurate you. Relive and reiterate, neglect and forget—spend your time as you will, until the ineludible climax when you will know truth from falsehood.

If it’s one thing I lack these days, it’s loyalty to Rhindy. In the past, I convinced myself that I cared for her in some deep way, but as soon as I thought it, I felt as if I were selling myself a cheap lie, and actually, more to the truth, I felt repressed around her. She was never conscious of it, but I knew she limited me, hindered my abilities as an artist and arrested my development as a writer. I had moved out once before—about two years ago now—it did some good, but I went back

to her thinking I could have a good life if I just loved her, cared for her needs, and worshipped her. But she was never deserving of that degree of respect. Yes, she had her job in the city making 38K a year; she took care of me, mothered me. I was so fucking sick of it. How could I respect someone who only saw my needs as a child's? I was a budding writer, I had been doggedly determined to make something of myself. I was making aims to see my goals through and now she appeared as a burden, a sucking leech that fed off my energy. I knew I could never make it as long as she were around.

Continue on with the future making the past and the past contributing to the future. Continue on with life before the great change comes—spew the filth and bile that wells in your throat. Continue with ill-versed thoughts and unpolished grammaticism. Continue on. . .

I picked up Heather from work, it was well after midnight. Rhindy had been gone since morning. She smiled as she got into the car, putting her overnight bag behind the seat. She leaned over and kissed me. Tonight was to be the first night we were to have sex; I was excited, looking forward to it. I wanted to possess her, be inside her feeling her warmth wrapped around me—her raw energy seeping in my bare skin. She lit a cigarette and announced laughingly with a serious tone that sex wouldn't be good right now, she had just gotten her period that morning. At first I felt upset, perhaps a little betrayed, but it wasn't her fault. I had this big plan that we could try so many things, but that could wait. Although I found I hated to wait—especially these days with so many things happening all at once—I had no choice. In order to make myself feel better, I believed that the pleasure of her company would be sufficient. At any rate, she had a fabulous way of pulling me away from my problems, making me forget about Rhindy. Heather had the kind of energy and personality that commanded respect. At times, I had the faint feeling I had known her before, nothing like a previous

life or anything, but an image from a dream—the taste of which still tingled my tongue. Maybe we had roamed the vast reaches beyond the wall of sleep, shared only as phantoms could without the burdens of physical bodies. She smiled again. I fired up the car and we went to the apartment I rarely called home.

“Thinking like that only gets you into trouble,” a faint voice said to me. “If you don’t feel comfortable with anyone or anyplace, you will never rise above the muck of an existence you deem miserable.”

I had been speaking to a friend of mine about becoming roommates. She liked the idea and suggested we go look for a place on the peninsula. Next week, on Monday, she promised we go have a look at what was available. She herself was determined to get away from the city to a place where she could feel more comfortable. We were loose allies driven to a similar goal, fighting a life-long war where battles would soon be won. We were caged and we were free; we were burdened by ourselves.

Heather and I spent the bulk of the evening watching television and a couple of movies (on Rhindy’s VCR). We talked freely about our dreams, what drove us, our ambitions, and exactly what the hell we were going to do with our lives. Not everything was crystal clear—few things are—but we knew what we wanted out of life and knew if we stuck to our goals, then we would be unstoppable. I had always been unsure of myself as a writer, oscillating between art and the typewriter—although I had been more adept at the latter. Feeling bad about everything I ever attempted to do was my forte, but I managed to hide my insecurities. Well, at least Heather thought so.

Standing before an open field, the grass swayed lazily in the cool night breeze. The smell of freshly harvested grain and jasmine hung in the air. In the distance, a great void was opening, it wasn’t a void of negative energy, but one of great change. Only a few more strides and

I would be through. But the terrain between was unfamiliar and rough, intimidating to say the least; there was enormous hesitation in me. I was safe where I was, but it didn't feel safe—it drained me to stand in such a place. I wanted to take a step, but fear held me to my spot. I knew the void was actually a gate that would take me to the next level of awareness where I would experience peace, success, and a new faith in my writing which I had not experienced before. The decision was not hard, I knew I had to trudge forward, but to do that I had to leave my load that clung to my back, and work just a little harder: find a real job, get my car repaired for the move, and prepare my psychology for the journey. As soon as I took the first step, people would get hurt (Rhindy mostly), but I couldn't let myself get sucked into feeling sorry for her and hindering myself further. I had done that years ago, in 1989, and I fucked myself good. I could have been happy; I had been in love with another woman, she cared a great deal for me and wanted me to live with her. I knew I loved her, but chose to break her heart. She was twenty-six and we knew we were perfect for each other. She was an artist, a screenwriter. Many times we spent the evenings in her room, drinking and fucking and rewriting her work. She respected me as a writer, although my development might have been conceived as immature, but none of that stopped her. We lay naked—I smoking, she with pen in hand scribbling notes on the backs of used paper—her nipples firm with excitement. She knew she could succeed and I truly believed it. We were to conquer the world and force it to submit.

The field is expansive, I see the images float by me in the air. I see her as she appeared in 1989 with her screenplay; her eyes bright and mind strong and one-tracked. Rhindy engulfs the image, before blotting it out entirely; holding in her hand a pile of hundred dollar bills and a single emerald, nestled within. She is smiling her wry, putrid smile, beckoning me, telling me how easy my life can be with her, that

I may write uninhibited. Her empty promises overtake me, all I can see is the virulent green in her hand. The artist in me is stifled and put into a deep slumber. The image of her and her screenplay melts away.

Heather is sitting cross-legged on the couch next to me, she smells sweet, her eyes remind me of 1989. The bile of my mistake wells in my throat and sickens me. I hate myself and what I have become. I want the change so badly, I think if I don't make it I will die. I dream of death, the dying need to change—to alter myself and my reality while my lack of self-assuredness grows weaker by the moment. The longer I look at Heather, the more driven I become. I will not make the same mistake twice.

May 3. I woke late in the morning and lie thinking about calling some old friends, not ones from the past three years or so, but further back. I wanted to let them know how I was doing out in California, that I was finally becoming comfortable and my life beginning. I pulled out a cigarette and sat up in bed. Rhindy hated it when I smoked in the apartment and emphatically told me she didn't want me doing it again. Heather stirred beside me. We smoked together. Life was good.

Later. After Heather went to work, I sat facing the typewriter at the desk. I spent several hours staring at the blank paper while typing very few words. Any advancement, no matter how small, was still advancement; besides, I appreciated the time I was alone without Rhindy in the house. It gave me incredible peace of mind. I smoked another cigarette.

The phone rang. It was Gale. She asked me how I was getting along living with Rhindy and when I was going to get the hell out. I told her about Janet, the woman who wanted to room with me on the peninsula. Gale knew her from years back.

"She's really nice. You guys might do okay living together."

"Besides, there's a third roommate."

“Yeah, living with two women, sounds like something out of Three’s Company.” I hated that show. “Looks like you’ll be in good. Janet says she likes you, all you need to do is have the first month’s rent and a part of the deposit and you’re set. They’ll take care of you.”

That’s exactly what I was trying to get away from.

“Oh, don’t bitch,” Gale continued. “It’s better than Rhindy, at least they won’t hound you. They have this way of worshipping someone who’s into all that romantic, candles, writing shit. You’ll like it.”

Gale and I had been on better terms recently. Since she had her kid, her mood swings seemed to have mellowed her mood swings. I found her more tolerable to talk to and started trusting her, which I thought was odd. She asked me about Heather, I didn’t want to volunteer any information; I was caught in the old habit of trying to figure a way of telling her so she wouldn’t be able to throw it in my face later. I didn’t want to keep on sleeping with her since I had been going out with Heather.

“Don’t throw away everything you have, Chris,” she said. “Things might not work out and you won’t have anything. We are so into our debauched life, you don’t want to give that up. Besides, I need you to fuck me once in a while. You don’t want me to go without, do you?”

I didn’t know how to answer or what to say. Part of me thrived on the debauchery, the many different lovers, the women at different times, their styles of love making and the look on their face when I came. I lived off each and every one of them. I was like a vampire going from one feeding ground to the next—each meal more and more enticing.

“I think the only reason for you being into this debauchery is so you can write about it.”

She pegged me.

“Well, when you get away from Rhindy things will be better.”

It was almost two, Janet hadn't phoned yet. "I'd better go, Janet and I are supposed to go apartment shopping today."

"Okay, bye."

I hung up the phone and dialed Janet. She answered on the first ring and told me she couldn't make it, she had other appointments. I was neither mad or upset, I knew I had to do everything myself if I wanted to get out—part of the sacrifice I had to perform. There were times when the stress would get to me, I wanted so badly to get out I would be anxious not doing anything about it. For example, I knew I had to wait on a job that would cinch my leaving, but I had to wait a few days to hear any news. Everything lay in wait and it seemed the slightest oversight would detonate the whole affair.

I spent the last few hours staring at my typewriter, seeing the static words on the page and the blinding sea of white behind them. I ate tortilla chips dipped in salsa, perhaps a little too spicy, and a soda. I looked at the scene before me. The chips were scattered over the desk, crumbs raining to the floor, the nearly empty bowl of salsa in the melee and the soda resting to the left of the typewriter. At any moment I could reach out and feed myself, or have a cigarette, or call a friend; or fuck Gale, Rhindy, Heather eventually, probably Janet and the roommate, anything I desired. In the chaos I was the master of my own destiny, I ruled my life here. Despite the uncontrolled downward spiraling of my life, there were times when I felt I had some control. And now is one of those times. This spew I have crouching on the paper before me, this sorry excuse of a typewriter, are at play of my every whim and desire. Like the women I knew, I could beckon and call the most radiant lie and have them believe it. Especially now. Because now I'm starting to believe the fabrications I construct. They've become my new reality; therefore, they exist as all reality for all the people I

come into contact with. I am God and I am Satan and I exist within all points in between. I am chaos, I am master. I do whatever I please.

Gale wanted me to call her later in the evening. She seemed to have something important to tell me, but it was probably another of her ploys to have me come down and see her. I could have been an interesting proposal, but I had no means by which to go. My car was not running and I didn't feel like using Rhindy's. Besides, I saw Gale a couple of nights ago, late, and fucked her good, so she should at least be satisfied with that. She claimed the more often I had sex with her the more she wanted it; she claimed she fronted the frigidity in the past and now she was over it because I "got her into sex". It wasn't as if I didn't want to fuck her, but I had the strange feeling that if I did, I would be cheating on Heather. Knowing this idea was absolutely absurd didn't help. Because no matter how much I would try to explain it away, I was compelled to find a philosophy which would justify my actions. You see, Gale had 'seniority' which means exactly as it sounds. I was obligated to do as she pleased and she in return if the relationship was to continue. We never were boyfriend/girlfriend and I had not been in such a situation for years; I would be going out with someone, but still fuck either an ex-girlfriend or friend whenever I felt like it or if the significant other was not pleasing me sufficiently or if I got bored: It was always one of the three. People I know have a hard time understanding this concept, and they attempt to chastise me for my lifestyle, but I reply that it was what made me happy. If I didn't have any money, fine, any life, fine, but I had to have several partners if I was to remain true to who I was. Pure and simply, I liked the variety. It was not as if I went out and found prostitutes, I would rather abstain; but I could never say no to a woman who was lying beneath me, mouth open, legs spread, her moist cunt begging my entrance—I wouldn't want to be the one responsible for turning her down. Life was for the

taking and if I didn't experience every possible pleasure imaginable, then I would surely be inanimate and dead. Or maybe I didn't want to be alone wishing I had more in life. Whatever petty diatribe I could cook up, it still couldn't explain my situation. I could write and write and write and have pages and pages of what would become a neatly typed manuscript, but nothing of substance ever came. At least not yet. Maybe I wasn't the writer I wanted to be and (as some would have it) I might never be. One thing for certain, pity was for fools.

I find I think of Heather nearly six hours before I would meet her. There was quite a lot to think about. First, I would think of the curve of her body—her firm breasts that perched delicate, tiny nipples. Then her back which led to her smooth ass; the same ass I can see in my mind's eye stuck up into the air—her head buried in the pillow—murmuring that I should take whatever pleased me. She said she liked to be fucked; she desired me to tie her down, both wrists and ankles, and hold her ass to me.

"Do you like seeing me this way?" She would ask. I would remain silent only letting my fingers probe her vagina—my thumb on her anus.

"You tease me so well. . ." She would pant. "I know what you want. You want me to suck on that cock of yours. Bring it to me."

I would move to her face and she had managed to prop herself on her elbows. My erection blazing, she would start by licking the head. Then, after only allowing that, she would say,

"Enough of this teasing game, give it to me."

Propping myself on my knees, I slid myself in and out of her mouth. With each thrust, I slammed myself deeper and deeper into her throat.

. . .

Her mouth was always willing to take my cock. She was one of the few women I knew (actually the only one) who enjoying blowing me. It is this immense presence of hers, this addiction for raw sex, that has be

pinning the hours away. My imagination empowered, my desires fueled, I count the hours when I can see her. Not because she can sexually gratify me like no other woman I have ever known, but because she can fill me. What I mean is, she possesses a vital essence I have been longing for. I can never place my finger on it, there is a need inside me that I have not fully realized; but whatever it is, she satisfies it in every conceivable way. I hope that one day I can figure it out. It will only be then when I can truly know what I have in my bed.

Gale asks me if I'm in love with her. I tell her I don't know. She replies that if I don't know then it must not be love. Gale is full of shit, because what she doesn't realize is that love in its purest sense takes incalculable amounts of time to understand. No real surprise, since she is one of those people who freely admit they fall in love at first sight. Not only is Gale an idealist, she is a liar.

Back on another thought, I wonder if people think badly of my promiscuity. I wonder if it were another time, would I be strung up and burned, beaten, and excised from society? In many ways, I already feel deviant, hell, I know I am; these days everything is crazy, reports of insane cults, multiple homicides, crimes of passion. They litter the papers. I think what I'm doing is tame, not even newsworthy. In fact, my writing is pretty tame as well. The subject matter and attitudes about sex couldn't compare to the violence, death, and decay that envelops our apocalyptic society. In Henry Miller's time, writing such as this was banned; even as late as the appearance of Sorme's sex diary in the late 50s, people still had an aversion to any writing that made people uncomfortable. So I wonder if my work will have any impact; will this piece or that be significant in some small way or will they be ignored? It's this dualistic insecurity, seething in every cell in my body, that makes continuing my art difficult. In the shadow of true crime, rape, incest, and explicit pornography, will such works as mine survive?

Do they have the punch to guarantee longevity? Will people read it? Will they even bother to read at all?

All this doesn't matter much, as long as I finish the work and say my piece then I have succeeded.

I couldn't resist the temptation, I called Gale. I told her I was writing about her; she asked me how much I had written. When I told her, she said,

"That's it?! I write at least three times that when I sit down for a few hours."

She lacked understanding of a few things: First, she wrote in a notebook which doesn't even compare to typewritten pages; second, she mostly babbled instead of writing; third, the work she had produced had no point, it lacked structure. And fifth, it could never stand on its own. Hearing of it bored me to tears. Telling her this would make me look like shit, but I did it anyway—just for fun. There was a long pause on the phone.

"I think I feel a Henry Miller/Anais Nin fight coming on. I don't want to deal with it."

We talked a short while longer which ended up in her wanting me to come see her. She promised she would feed me a real meal—no chips and salsa. I turned her down. As I said, I had no way to get there. The truth was that I didn't want to see her; sometimes I become consumed with relationships and I felt the time would be better spent anticipating my next encounter with Heather. I would see Gale some other time, besides, I wanted to see less of her. She does nothing but disrupt me. And right now, I didn't need that shit.

May 4. Rhindy woke me this morning, actually afternoon. She said she was concerned about me. Was I ill? No. Was I still in love with her? Yes. A lie. She asked me about my classes, if I were still attending school. I hadn't seen the inside of a classroom in over a month—going

seemed unimportant, except for the occasional counseling class I would stumble into. I had a few priorities in my life and school wasn't one of them. If asked, I couldn't say what those priorities were. . .if pressed, however, I could think of something on the fly.

Rhindy pressed on: "You have so few units left, just finish," and, "that little piece of paper can go far," shit like that. "It can do nothing but help." On that point, Madame, I must disagree. You have your MBA and it doesn't do much for you. . .outside of money. I can't say Rhindy isn't intelligent—maybe book smart, but not life smart. I know this because I had to actually tell her about my affairs and my seedy debauchery. She never caught a clue, and I made it so damn obvious too.

I have to stop staying up so late these days, I'd been coming in at five in the morning on nights I'd see Heather, and last night was another of them. And it was one of the worse ones. I really wanted to have sex with her, I mean bad; every part of me ached for her, but she looked down on me, smiled and uttered her quickly becoming annoying excuse, "I wish you lived alone".

This "living alone" thing had been an issue of late. Heather was becoming tired of sex in my car, sex in Rhindy's car, sex in the cemetery, sex in a friend's basement, and so on. She was vocal in saying that she wanted privacy and not have to bare herself in the lascivious, embarrassing places we had come to call our own. Of course I agreed with her, but I wished she wouldn't talk about it right before I wanted to fuck. I was losing patience. She was ready to put sex on hold; unless I found us a comfortable place (and not some hotel) and soon, she would be cutting me off completely. That meant, no all of the above plus no making out in her parents' house or kissing in public. She promised it was for both our goods, that way I won't be expecting anything when

I meet her, which means I won't get excited and subsequently won't get mad when my desires go unfulfilled.

This would probably only last a few days. I knew her pretty well—especially in the arena of sexual pomp and circumstance—she wouldn't hold out. We said nothing about sex, but she asked when she could see me again. I suggested Friday (I really needed to spend a night or two with Rhindy until the heat blew off), but she wanted to see me tonight. To agree to disagree, I could never do either.

It was sunny today, a rare thing in this part of the city. I felt like taking a walk to the park that was down the street, gaze up at the clear sky, and bask in the warm sun. Then I thought I should go to the bank and extract more of Rhindy's money, so I could have some lunch and cigarettes. I was out of money; I had two quarters, and several pennies. Maybe I could scrounge up a couple of dimes if I looked really hard. It was depressing to say the least.

Later. I decided to get some cigarettes, the urge to have one was too great, it was distracting me. I had to walk to the bank and raid Rhindy's account for a twenty, then to the mall. I appreciated the walk; the day was warm, a light breeze whistled in the trees, the air as clean as you could expect living in the city. I figured that since I would pass by Heather's work, I should stop in and see her. It was sometimes difficult visiting her, I didn't want it to seem that I had to see her every waking moment; I didn't want her knowing I was that dependent on her. Besides, I would see her later this evening after I got out of the counseling classes I had been going to. These classes were kind of an experiment on my part; I was looking to explore the psychology of the general populace, the "norm", so I could manipulate it. It was kind of fun although I was reaching a boredom point with it. This week the sexuality issue was on the table and this would probably be the last one I would go to.

Gale had been bugging me to tell Heather about the debauchery. I was always leary, such information might scare Heather away. But, on Gale's not-so-better advice, I decided that now, early in the relationship, was the time for honesty. So, I told her late last night, in the Zim's on Van Ness. Between bites in a patty melt, I told her the whole story, the whole theory of debauchery as authored and experienced by myself and Gale. Heather didn't react to anything I said; she was calm, and occasionally smiled.

"We take care of each other," I said. "We're there for each other and if one needs the company of the other then so be it. And if it entails having sex to make one feel better then the needs will be seen to. It's almost as if we're a family—lifelong friends in every respect of the word—without the inane jealousy and other petty bullshit games that couples usually play.

She was silent.

"I don't know if I'm saying it right, but Gale and I have been this way for quite some time now. I'd say almost two years, maybe longer. I hope you can understand without getting too weirded out about it."

She shook her head and picked up a French-fry, pointing it at me.

"I'm not weirded out, it sounds ridiculous." She tossed the fry into her mouth.

"Ridiculous?"

"Yes."

"C'mon, Chris, you expect me to believe this shit?"

"Well, I. . ."

"It was a good try, but I don't buy it. Actually, I think the two of you are all screwed up."

I set my sandwich down. She had no idea. Yes, Gale and I in tandem makes for a pretty screwy mix, but that doesn't matter right

now because as I sit here—eye to eye with Heather—the only one who is really screwed is me.

I felt as if I were going through a metamorphosis where I was shedding the pains of a treacherous life with Rhindy for a less painful, but still difficult life on my own where I could do as I pleased as long as my survival was assured. I went through a similar process in 1991 when I moved out with Gale, I found my emotions mixed, my temperament uneven, and quick to be critical of Gale or Heather or anybody else. But the truth was I cared for them, in my heart I knew I did, but I couldn't resist hurting them—performing aberrant sexual acts—doing things I knew irritated them. I figured it was just because things were so tender these days, that I was going through the most difficult transition in my life. I was sure there would be others, but at least I would be past this one. The only thing that bothered me was that I felt my deviant behavior growing in strength. Instead of acquiescing, I revolted, acting out impulses never before conceived. At first, it seemed scary, but as with each occurrence of intercourse with Rhindy got more and more vividly pornographic and utterly sick, the more I pushed the envelope. I started strapping her down to the table, bending her head over the edge, opening her mouth full, and plunging my length down her throat. If not that, then tying her arms to the closet-rod—her ass sticking full-out—and I entering her vagina, then her ass, then back again. Rhindy used to dislike the fact that I came in her face, now she waits with outstretched tongue for that which has brought out her true self.

The phone rang; it jarred me from my comfortable position at the desk—arms folded, face down. It was Nick. He and his curiosity, a.k.a. Stress, wanted to know how things were going with Heather. I was beginning to get the impression that Nick and his mousy girlfriend lived vicariously through Heather and I; which particular body part

I know not, but from time to time I catch Stress staring into my lap. And Nick has always been fond of breasts—you couldn't tell by looking at Stress, though, her size As were nothing to be proud of. Anyway, since they had introduced me to Heather, they felt that I owed them a detailed account of our life. While at first annoying, it was a game. I danced around the explanations, and he insisted on asking revealing questions. Everything, of course, in the typical Nick manner.

"So, have you fucked her yet?" He asked.

I swallowed hard. Truth was not in my soul.

"No."

"No? Nothing at all? You guys haven't done anything?"

"Other things."

"You get blown?"

"Yeah."

"Cool. Was it good?"

"Yeah, she used the hands-free approach."

"Really, that good. Hmm, she must have been with a lot of guys, had a lot of experience. You have to watch out for women like that."

I sighed heavily. Navigate carefully; lie and exaggerate only when necessary. And don't make it sound too good. Beware, another Nick psychobabble is in the works.

"Women who have been with a lot of guys are used to sleeping around. They don't know what it means to be committed to somebody. It'll be one big pain, man; you think she's with you, maybe in love, and then she'll pick up somebody else and have no trouble screwing them. She won't even think about you. Fuck her before she fucks you. Listen to me, man. I know what I'm talking about."

"Maybe she's tired of all that shit and ready to settle down."

"Maybe. But when they're attractive like Heather, they have guys hitting on them all the time. Maybe she's already fucking somebody

now and she doesn't want to get involved with you. Maybe she'll drop the friend bomb."

"A lot of maybes Nick, but I don't think she'll drop the friend bomb."

I could hear Stress coaching him in the background. She wanted him to ask me this or tell me that. I never thought much about her, but I fucking hate her. Her sad, never-land-a-serious-boyfriend looks, only invoked a violent response. If she'd ever give me the chance, I'd deck her. And Nick would sit back and laugh like a hyena. But I can't deck her because I'm on the phone and by the tone in her faint voice, I could tell she was plotting something. She was doing her best to try to have me feel insecure about Heather, so I would dump her. This was the third time I'd had a conversation like this, I could never figure the reason for it until Gale finally said something.

"Stress is jealous of you, she wants Heather for some weird woman to woman relationship. But Stress is so mousy in her disgusting French kind of way, Heather wants nothing to do with her. Now Stress is jealous of you. It's one of those, 'if I can't have her no one will' deals. I think it's sick, don't you?"

More petty bullshit. I knew there was no way she could put a wrench in the relationship; Stress was a plain, tree frog-like girl with no discernible features. Like Nick, she was immature and petty and this game she was so badly orchestrating was only a sad reminder of her empty existence. Gale professed that I was the master of head games and if this were true, then I should be able to thwart someone like Stress. And I would do it with brutal accuracy.

"Well, I don't know, man, I don't think it'll work out with you and Heather. She's not your type."

He made a serious mistake, he contradicted himself.

"A week ago, you said you thought we were perfect."

"But now that we know her, I had to change my mind."

“Yeah, well, I’ve got to go, I’m in the middle of something.”

“My mom says dinner’s ready. Later.”

I hung up the phone without saying goodbye. Hopefully, I could get back to my contemplation without any more disruption.

May 5. Janet woke me this morning telling about the new place they had found in the paper; it was in San Mateo, near to where I had lived before with Gale. She said the place was a bit pricey, but it was nice although neither Janet nor the other roommate had seen it yet. She said that she had made an appointment for 6:15 this evening, if I could make it.

These past few days have been very stressful. Heather said they would be. Lately she’s been happy that I’ve been seriously looking for my own place. And in some ways I am too. My future loomed on the horizon; yes, I would have my own place, but what of the interplay, what will be the final scene between Rhindy and I? In recent days, I’ve picked up her increasing dependence on me—she said late last night that she’s doing things sexually she has never even considered. She finds it hard to believe that she’s able to do the things I make her do. It’s as if she’s outside herself—watching—she says. But it’s what she wants, she professes, and looks forward to when she gets home from work.

“I wonder what you’re going to do next,” she says over dinner. “I particularly liked the closet scene, and being bent over this table.”

It’s all I can do to not tell her I’m thinking—trying—to leave.

“I dreamt about you tying me to the bed before I could leave for work. You left me there all day. In the morning, you came in my face. In the afternoon, you took me in my ass. I lay there, come drying on my face and seeping out my ass. In the evening, I begged you to untie me and make love to me. You tenderly cleaned me up and we made love. I never had a dream like that before.”

“It would never happen, you know.”

“I know. . .”

“You could never take a day off work, never lie in bed in the same position (on your back, I assume), or enjoy something as weird as that.”

She glared at me. “It was just a dream, asshole.”

She slammed her fork on the table and huffed to the bathroom. Throughout all the recent changes in Rhindy, one thing had remained the same—she was still too sensitive.

It doesn't really matter. It seems as if the same tensions are in the air as they were when I left back in '91, but I can't tell. Everything doesn't seem to be in balance anymore, situations unfolded at skewed pitches, nothing made much sense. If I kept in contact with Gale and Janet, then the living arrangements were assured; if I kept in close contact with Heather then a relationship was assured; if I repaired the car then a job would follow. As ridiculously simple as it sounds, these hopeful cause/effect scenarios, which in the past worked, now work multi-dimensionally. For example, keeping in contact with Heather insured nothing if not a relationship. Sex, yes, but the more we had fucked, the greater the demands. I had to be “living alone” so she could feel comfortable, I was working on that. It didn't quell her for long hearing my stories how I would see this place or that, or what job I applied to that day. Faith was something she gravely lacked. When I told her I knew some measure of financial gain was coming my way, she sighed and shook her head in the same way as when I told her about the debauchery thing. She was not amused. Oddly enough, the day after, a friend said he was going to be working on a movie where they needed an old car. I had a dilapidated Pontiac that would do. But the offer was thin, a legitimate full time job would be better. It would certainly look better anyhow, especially in Heather's eyes. There was a possible job in Redwood City. It was right up my alley, reviewing video games—the

perfect slack job for me, and it paid well. But, unfortunately, I was waiting for Rhindy to get information—which, obviously makes for a rather complex scene—especially around break-up time. Instead of worrying about it, I held onto my faith, secure in knowing that if my fate were left in my own hands, I would be okay. But until then. . .

I had a confrontation with Stress last night. Seems she was up to her old games again; she asked me to drop off some of Nick's tapes I had. As she pulled back the door, she launched into a tirade of how badly I was treating Gale and how I was using everybody. "Freeloading" was the word she used. As the stench of her spew dissipated, I stood smiling under the light of the full moon and said,

"Look who's talking about freeloading when you are living with Nick's parents doing absolutely nothing but eating their food, shitting in their toilet, and staining the sheets in their beds. You're worthless, you fucking tramp."

The silence between us lasted an eternity. With our eyes locked, my mind told her she was a tart, a hooker, a sucking leech who slurred her words together so badly, one had to wonder if she hadn't something in her mouth. And Nick doesn't think much of you either, in fact, one evening, while out for coffee, I him what I thought of you. As we talked more about you, the meaner our words became. Nick laughed as I laid insult upon insult about his live-in whore. He about fell on the floor when I said your slurring sounded as if you had Nick's come lodged in the back of your throat.

It was all in good fun, which kept me insulting her even when she was standing before me. I let her have it all in three minutes, then turned my back and strolled to my car as she broke the silence and began upon another fit. As the engine purred and the radio blasted rock and roll, I resolved that my friends had betrayed me. I didn't need them anymore, especially ones I thought too "normal" or ones

who gave too much advice when their own lives were a shambles. I knew, although Nick rips on Stress we he and I are together, he rips on me when I'm not around. It really doesn't matter. I'm fine on my own, my existence didn't require friends. Over the radio, I hear her slam the door. But who knows about anything? I don't. But, I'll be glad when I'm away from this shit.

Later. I feel tired, drained by the afternoon. I had slept well but didn't dream; my life appeared to me as existing in a sterile bubble, looking through the transparent sphere at the surrounding chaos. In here I was safe with my thoughts, my intellect, and my writing; the outsiders were trying to tear into my world, poke holes to contaminate the rich air. My first reaction was to fight, but it took too much effort; instead, I fled to my mind and built a stronger barrier—a second bubble to insulate the first in case they had gotten through. Through each construction of inner spheres and destruction of outer spheres, my world got smaller and smaller. I didn't know why the others wanted to destroy me, I couldn't account anything for it. I had tried my best to be a friend to them and they turned on me, striking back, misplacing blame. I knew it was only a matter of time when my world would be so small, I would have no choice but to fight. I was being backed into a corner.

Fog rolled in around nightfall blanketing the neighborhood; through my window only the very tops of the buildings poked through. This was the heaviest fog I had seen since winter; the moon was still full—I didn't think its light would be able to cut through. Like a beacon and coalesced with the fog itself, it illuminated the strange feeling in the air. I knew it to be a culmination of apathy and fear with a little foreboding thrown in. People are acting differently, they're less friendly than usual, they don't even offer glances as you walk past them. I've been spending the last few hours trying to figure it out, but as of yet, I haven't had

any luck—it's very odd. Upon heavy contemplation, I always get the answer I'm looking for. . .not now. I get the sense I'm witnessing the fastidious approach of something evil, manifesting itself in an impending disaster. I couldn't shake it. And when I went apartment shopping with Janet, the feeling hung about me; it was omnipresent in the eyes of the people I met in the houses. They were either unaware or unwilling to believe the omen; they mulled from one geographical space to another, chewing words and spitting phrases, eyes transfixed in the bombast proclivities that not only dictated their reality, but defined it. They were animals awaiting slaughter. Considering that this might explain their extrusive behavior toward me, it's an obvious last ditch effort to strike at me because, for some reason, they felt I was impervious to it. Yet I await the storm too. Why am I admonished with such a gift as life? Perhaps that was why Stress was behind such a whore. She really is jealous of me. Insanely jealous of not just one "freebie", but almost all of my outlooks and attributes which she craved to she herself possess. I spoke briefly with Nick and he didn't know what the hell was going on. She hadn't told him of our little exchange on the porch of his parents' house. How he could miss it. . .maybe he was out screwing someone else, or maybe he had absent-mindedly locked himself in the bathroom. Regardless, he remarked that everybody was hating me these days. And he made it sound as if a lot of everybodys were involved. It must have been the veritable chorus of everybodys crooning a singular frequency that struck a vicious, sardonic chord in my soul. So intoxicating was the wail that even I would be jealous to be the only survivor.

May 6-7. I've found myself busy these past two days. It's strange on moment things are still and I have all the time in the world and the next I'm bombarded with three things at once. It's 11:30 PM on a Thursday, Janet and I had gone to look at new places on Wednesday; she shared the

sentiment—plumbing the cosmic regions of Heather-philosophy—that I should leave Rhindy.

“She sounds hideous. I wonder how you can stand it. But it won’t be like that at the new place. We won’t treat each other so badly.”

Sounds good. Nothing I could really do but hope she were telling the truth. I needed to get out soon, the world was ready to come crashing down, either Rhindy would get on her marriage kick (it reared its ugly head last night as I climbed off her) or want me to put as much effort into loving her as I did fucking her. Oh yeah, could I be home more often? Or at the very least not stay out until five in the morning? Hard to say, my habit was solidified; since so used to being away from her, I would feel entombed if left to stay two consecutive nights. I had to be out at Gale’s or with Heather, or just out by myself; I just had to be out. I wanted to tell Rhindy there wasn’t much time left after compensating for the debauchery and the frequent, sometimes questionable, sexual encounters. Besides, allowing for the weight of the “out” adventures, she couldn’t afford to be selfish.

Earlier this evening, I had gone out with Gale. This was the first of its kind in nearly three months. Her fascination with her newspaper lovers and her recent affair with Billy had left me sour—how she could fictitiously fuss and fidget with his ever-supple penis, I could never ascertain—but the lies through that stretch blanketed by the new ones, opened a dialogue between us. For the past week or so, I had been on speaking terms with her, via the phone. Her pleading I come and see her proved, at the very least, ineffectual; however, the urgency in her voice swept aside any problems we may have had in the past. After much vocalized trepidation on my part and a lot of persuasion on hers, I agreed to go out and be seen in public with her. I met her at her parents’—the place where she and I had fucked innumerable times in the basement, her room. It had been a long time since I had seen the

house and I didn't think I would again, but fate has a way of playing cruel tricks on you. She came out and greeted me as I arrived. She smiled thickly and hugged me.

"It's been forever. I was beginning to wonder if you would ever forgive me."

"Some other time. What do you want to do?"

"Come in and see my folks."

I said the cordial hellos and made my best for small talk. We spoke of literature—of Dylan Thomas—and my classes, and my ambitions, and my writing. Her mother's color stayed its usual pallor and her father laughed between bites in his gyros. I remembered to sit up straight and smile, appearing confident in at least myself all the while. Gale called me into the kitchen as her parents were busy with her kid.

"I thought we could go out for a few drinks and then go back to my place."

I lit a cigarette and looked at her through the haze of smoke.

"Oh, will Billy be there?"

She smirked and shook her head. "No, he's gone up North."

"Convenient."

"I told you it's over between him and I, he's so old and disgusting. I can't fuck him anymore no matter how much money I get out of it."

"Despite the fact he can't get it up."

"I have to make it (his penis) dinner, give it dessert, take it out for a walk, sweet talk it. Then maybe it'll work."

"Okay."

"Funny, huh?"

"I told you how I feel about it."

"Yes and I dropped him because I didn't want to lose you. I love you, Chris."

As obviously facetious as she was, this wasn't the first time she said it half-seriously. She loved me I'm sure, in her own psychopathic fashion. I've never been the most traditional person about relationships and love—quite the contrary—but she continually did things that she knew pissed me off. And now she wanted to have sex with her again. Before the hell at the apartment, and before the hell with Colin and the gene pool, and before the kid it might have been okay. Now the thought of the old man, as wrinkled and weathered as he was, penetrating the same pathway I would be, was obscenely vulgar. I shivered as the movie in my head of them having sex rolled on reel after reel. She said she never could understand the animosity I had for her fucking him, she claimed it washed out like anything else, but I knew—and maybe it was just me—that some things remain permanently embedded. They say when you go to bed with someone, you sleep with every lover that person ever had and I in no way wanted to fuck Billy, not with her, not even in the same town. So, the decision to even go out with her was a rough one because I knew every time she looked at me, she was putting out the 'fuck me' vibes. In spite of those 'fuck me' vibes and on the other hand, well, perhaps it was time to forgive. She was quite congenial about breaking up with him and her descriptions of how disgusting he was in bed appeared to turn her stomach. Maybe it was over, but the residual effects would drone on for some time.

We went to a bar that was close to her house. It was on the highway, and while sitting at the bar, one could feel the traffic rumble by. The walls were littered with deer's heads—some with antlers, some without—and posters announcing the next country concert which had already passed several months or years ago. Most of the clientele was clad in flannel—shirts and jackets, sometimes both—jeans, boots, and either cowboy or baseball hats which read "Red Man" or "Caterpillar". Gale had a White Russian and I a Guinness. A football game was

on the television; several people just out of work (Gale's been calling them white trash lately) were glued to the screen asking the bartender repeatedly for the score although he had told them twice he didn't know. I was even asked. I only hunched my shoulders and offered no response.

"You're such an asshole." Gale laughed.

"I know." I took a long drink of the cold beer. "It's what I'm best at."

"I hope you can get over the Billy bullshit. I don't think it's very nice to keep on torturing me with it. I'm willing to make up, I'll do anything for you. Just forgive me."

She whimpered and put her head in my lap. This caught the attention of the guys sitting next to us. Facetious to the end, she was.

"I'll blow you 'till you do."

"Stop it Gale."

"Why? Are you getting a hard-on?" She sat up and put her hand between my legs.

"This is not the time or place."

"I can think of one. Would you like to go back to my place after you finish your beer and fuck me? I think you need to punish me, I want you to whip me. There are some hooks in the wall, you could tie me up. I need a good whipping, don't you think? After all I've done. . ."

"Who's torturing who?"

"C'mon, I need you to fuck me. I need to submit to your cock, your long hard cock."

Two stares had turned to four and so on, almost the whole crowd at the bar, including the bartender, were watching her intently. I nodded at them and looked at her; she was gnawing her ice. She continued.

"You probably not into the S&M scene, huh? You probably won't like it."

It was another one of the games. She began by trying to embarrass me in public (which is one of the main reasons I never liked seeing her in such places), then would become progressively louder each time I thwarted her advances. Normally, she would get the best of me. Not this time, though. I decided to play along.

“You don’t know what I like. You don’t know how sadistic I am.”

She smiled, she thought she caught me. “Yes, I know.”

“Hmm.” I nearly finished my beer in one swallow. She eyed the glass.

“Are you horny? You probably haven’t had it much lately. You’re still sleeping with Rhindy?”

I stay on the couch, she in the bedroom, and I refuse to fuck her; but if you must know how often I’m getting it, I’m getting it enough.”

She saw through the lie, but didn’t say anymore about it. She finished her drink and I mine. After sufficiently riling up the bar-crowd, we left and she drove me to her place. She had been living there almost six months now. It was a quaint place although a little too stuffy. Could have used some paint and new curtains, but I don’t know about those kind of things.

“Sit down and make yourself comfortable.”

She went to the bathroom and I waited on a Naugahyde couch. I could hear her shuffling in the bathroom: The toilet seat going up then down, the medicine cabinet being opened then closed. She came out ten minutes later.

“Let’s proceed to the chambers.”

She wasn’t kidding about the hooks in the wall. There were four eyelets—large enough to slip handcuffs through—spaced evenly so the person restrained could be tied with their limbs taught prohibiting any movement. It was a work of art.

“What do you think?”

“Interesting.” She turned her back and slipped off her dress, her mismatched bra and panties glaring at me.

“Are they big enough for you?” She cupped her hands under her breasts.

“Fine.”

“Lie down.” She lay on top of me. “I really have missed you. I don’t want anything coming between us ever again.” I hadn’t told her much about Heather, that perhaps that relationship was flourishing, that maybe this stolid, tortured, estranged rendezvous we involved ourselves in could finally be put to death. But there wasn’t time for such a discussion at present. She kissed me hard, her tongue probing my mouth. There was passion in her kiss which shocked me, I almost made her stop. It was so unlike the Gale I always knew. Definitely not time for discussion. She backed away and smiled.

“Take your pants down.” She took me in her mouth. I squirmed under her motions and arched my back to let her know she was doing it well, to encourage her to do more of the same. She stopped to look up at me, then continued. She did this three times.

“Am I blowing you well?”

“Well, if you’d kept up a continuous motion, I would say yes.”

She bit the head of my penis. “Don’t criticize my blow job technique.” She did as I suggested, she was doing it well, I was getting close.

“No coming now, you still have to fuck me.” She looked at my cock, speaking to it, “Do you want to fuck, yeah, I think he does. Yeah.”

She slid off her underwear and straddled the bed grabbing the headboard, pointing her ass toward me. I took my pants the rest of the way off, keeping my shirt and socks on.

“Fuck me, fuck me with that hard cock.”

“Is this the way you want to do it?”

She turned her head to look back at me. “You know how I love canine, I thought it was your favorite too.”

“Especially when I don’t want to look at you.” I muttered.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Then fuck me then.”

I knelt behind her, she reached around and put me inside her.

“Just fuck me.”

May 8. I broke down today and decided to call some of my old friends. I had the urge a couple of days ago and managed to suppress it. But like the cigarettes and other numerous vices I had, I couldn’t resist. Besides, sitting and staring at a humming typewriter and blank paper would only drive me more nuts. I phoned Jon in San Rafael; the last I heard, he was still living at his parents’. I dialed and was surprised to find I didn’t hang up. His father answered.

“Jon? Oh, yeah, he’s here. You want to speak with him?”

“That would be nice.”

After a long pause, Jon picked up the phone. As he started speaking, I could hear his father hanging up.

He spoke evenly and clearly; he seemed to be in a mellow mood. We talked briefly about old times and what he was doing now: His persistent but uneventful job search, his girlfriend now living in South Dakota. He was enthusiastic without the usual overkill.

“So what’s up with you?”

I didn’t tell him much, I just clammed up. I didn’t even mention my writing. I gave him a prepared emotionless diatribe—I was wondering why I had called him in the first place. The memory of our last conversation swelled in my mind, if given the chance, I would slam the phone down right now. He asked about Rhindy and then said he had to go pick up his mom in fifteen minutes. I was ready to hang up and

breathe a sigh of relief and hit myself for having phoned when he got an idea. It was as if something had hit him in the back of the head.

“Are you doing anything Sunday?”

I was supposed to go apartment shopping with Janet, but that was in the afternoon, the evening was free.

“Maybe I can come down and see you in the city around seven.”

I agreed and said it would be a great idea. I gave him directions and we said our good-byes.

I lit a cig and resumed by eye-to-eye showdown with my typewriter. From the keys to the blank white paper, the ennui and I, we wrestled and wrestled. I had it in a headlock and brought it down to the mat; then, as I were going in for the kill, it broke loose and did in turn to me. If the damned paper were only filled in with something, it wouldn't be so bad, but at the rate I was going, it would be either tomorrow or the next before I managed to get anything written. I guess you could call it classic writer's block. It sounded better than lazy son-of-a-bitch. Or worse, good for nothing pseudo-artist.

The sun was high in the sky and there wasn't a cloud to be seen. I could have gone out if there was anything worth doing. The cigarette tasted good, but my lungs were filled from the heavy smoking I had been doing for the past few weeks—I was almost to a pack a day. That scared me, because in the age of everything under the sun killing you, especially smoking and especially Camels, one had to regulate one's habits. “Never to excess,” you always hear. If not for want of death, the specter of addiction ran a close second. Now, that was worse than death, because one had to live with their addiction, not having been killed outright. I laughed at the ennui that had me incapacitated and I laughed at the thought of addiction and death. But to satisfy myself, it wasn't as if I couldn't quit smoking, I lacked to see the reason for doing

so. I wasn't suffering from any health problems. If I started coughing up any nasty shit then I would quit—that's reason enough.

My thoughts drifted to Heather. It was a little after two and she would be leaving for work soon; I suppose I could have driven to her house and offered her a ride, maybe seeing her for a bit; but then again, I lacked sufficient reason for doing so. I supposed I could do it out of pure sacrifice and moribund duty. And maybe, just maybe she would be happy to see. . .the phone rang.

It was Murray, I hadn't heard or seen him in almost a year. But Rhindy said he would be calling me. There was some inane script I had written for a class project. He wanted to film it and needed my input. I was told this two weeks ago; I was to call him. I never did. So I guess it was an expected call, not some weird sort of fate.

"Hey, Chrisman. What's up?"

"Not much."

"Did I catch you at a bad time?"

It was two in the afternoon on a Saturday, there couldn't have been a least worse time.

"No, not at all."

"I don't know if Rhindy told you, but I've been looking at the script. You remember the one? The horror film? Well, I was working at my job in the mailroom and it dawned on me that 'hey, I've just lost a year of my life, I want to be a filmmaker and I hadn't done anything to help myself'. So, I thought about doing a quick exposure, you know, 'the stupidest movie ever made' kind of thing, but then I thought again, 'no, I want to do something that'll really work', and then I thought about that script we wrote and I said, 'yeah, that's it' and I've been working on it ever since. I got a producer lined up, he thinks he can get \$20,000 together, and I've got a sound man and a friend rewriting the script as we speak. There's been a few changes. I don't know if

Rhindy told you, but I thought you'd like to take a look at it. I'd like us to talk about it."

"Um hmm."

"If you're not busy tonight, we could sit down and discuss what's going on. Have a few drinks, catch up on old times."

Rhindy had been on my ass lately about not spending any time with her. Two days ago, I promised, if she would just shut up, that I would take her out Saturday, tonight.

"Sounds like a good idea. How about around eight?"

"Eight o'clock?! That's too late!"

"Okay. . .how's six-thirty?"

"Six, yeah, that's cool."

"All right, bye."

The typewriter sat idle, I knew I couldn't write, much less rewrite anything, but maybe the thought of doing something productive might inspire me. It was a quarter after two; I decided to fire up the car and see Heather, she would appreciate the ride. I had to tear myself away from the blank paper. The ennui, death, addiction, Rhindy, Jon, and Murray. . .things could never be stranger.

Heather gave me a strange look as she answered the door, not the "I'm surprised to see you" look, but a more like "I've been up all night crying over you so why are you showing up in my life" one. I knew the last time I had seen her things hadn't gone well, but I didn't think they were that bad. We had gone out after the night with Gale. I felt sleazy doing it (fucking Gale), but I figured since Heather and I weren't having sex anyway (perhaps we never would) that it really didn't count. But anyway. . .

I asked her as we were driving why she gave me the look. She put her hand to her forehead and sighed.

"I thought you would never want to speak to me again after Friday."

“What makes you say that?”

“I was acting distant, I’m sorry.”

We had gone out to a dance club Friday; after I had almost three beers down, I discovered then she doesn’t like to drink, in fact, she despised it, especially when others did it.

“I had some bad experiences, I used to drink a lot in college. I ended up dropping out. I never went to class, I would just sit with a bottle of vodka and have sex with total strangers nearly every night. I’ve been dry for five months and I’d like to continue. I guess I felt weird watching you drink and that I couldn’t. I have a lot of old demons, I guess. I know I told you it was all right and all that, but your drinking did make me feel uncomfortable. I once went out with a guy who got all wound up that I wouldn’t have a drink with him. I tried to explain, but he only got more angry. I hate to be reminded of my old self, I want to be like I am now, in control. I will only go out with good people who understand me. And I know you understand me—at least you make like you do. I really don’t know for sure if you do or not, but I’d like to think you do. I’d also like to continue my acting and make a fresh start with my life. I’d like to go back to that club again sometime and this time I’ll be better, I promise.” She hugged my arm.

The drive was steady, the traffic heavy at times; the trees were in bloom and the sun pleasant.

“I still feel out of it today. I feel so awful. I don’t want to restrict you, I want you to do as you please. I care a lot about you, I think we could do well together.” She continued squeezing my arm, and leaned her head on my shoulder.

“Well, I guess, I’d better not drink in front of you again.” I swallowed hard. Was that the right thing to say? I think so. The day left me second-guessing myself, no matter what I thought or what I said to anybody left me feeling guilty. At that moment, this phase was

becoming very annoying. I looked over at her, her eyes blazed, her hair aglow. In spite of all that, though, things are making sense. The relationship is good, hell, better than good, amazing! I felt warm inside and the brilliant day mimicked me, I felt great! My love for her finally realized, her returning that love. No one would take the time to be upset about another if that person didn't mean something in their life. If she couldn't give a shit whether or not having hypothetically lost me, she would never have worried about it as much as she visibly had. Her reaction only reiterates the fact that she cared for me; her potential for deep devotion to me only that much deeper. I was giddy as a boy coming upon summer vacation—and that little cunt Stress, saying she was going to detonate the whole affair. She has the absolute power to do absolutely nothing, the little bitch. And Nick too, that fuck going along with her, well, for him, it's par for the course. But Heather, Heather, she is amazing; she, to date, has been the only one to make me feel as alive as I do right now. Time stood still and I hoped time would never end. I finally defeated that ennuaiatic beast, I defeated all hesitation and reluctance in Gale, Nick, Stress and whomever else chooses to smite me. Heather is the key to my completeness, the catalyst to my wholeness; with nature and with her I am myself. With her I am perfect, with her I am whole and with her I am impervious. She and I together, we are indestructible.

May 9. The afternoon came and went. I spoke to Janet and she said she was busy and couldn't go apartment shopping, I would have to do the footwork on my own and find a place.

It was such hot, scorching, strange weather for San Francisco. It almost scared me. It was earthquake weather.

The writer's block continues today; still though, I feel great because of Heather. I really wish to write—my ambition as flint—yet I can't make sense of the myriad thoughts in my brain. My head is still in the

clouds, my persona still giddy, the whole of me still as much in love as yesterday and waiting for the next encounter. Although feeling as good as I do, trepidation still lingers in me, continuing to enwrap me. Rhindy wanted to go to the beach and bask in the sun, I didn't much care for the heat, having the searing rays of the sun burn my skin. I disliked the day, night was fine. I could have put all that aside, but I sent her away. I needed to be alone with my drunken thoughts and feel a little more happy, a little more in love, a real love; I needed to be more optimistic, more inebriated with life, more of a lot of fucking things—my mind was a torrent of such thoughts, each emotion rising to the surface and embellishing itself upon my impressionable psyche. The phone rang.

It was Gale, she took advantage of Rhindy being gone to speak freely with me. She wanted to know about Jon, if he was coming down to see me and when. I told her that I had talked to his father this morning; Jon's cousin was in from St. Louis, his father described her as a "sharp girl". I had no idea exactly what that meant. Gale said it was a Billyish, old man expression that meant she was good looking, or else she was smart but lacked looks—truth was, she didn't have a clue either. Knowing if the cousin was accompanying Jon or not, I told her that he and I might go down to see her. She hadn't seen him in almost two years and from the nature of their last encounter, Jon wanted to fuck her; said he wanted to bury his member or something, but Gale didn't know it until I told her weeks later. She was pissed that she had missed the chance; I told her not to worry about it, Jon was still in one piece, cock and all, and we'd see her later.

"What about this cousin person?"

"I don't know who the hell it is. He probably won't even bring her by, probably leave her in San Rafael."

"I hope so. I wouldn't mind fucking Jon."

“You’re such a whore.”

“I know, the least I could do was charge for it, huh?” She laughed.

“I’d say you were worth a dollar thirty-seven, only if you blow me right. And that’s being generous.”

“Fuck you.”

“I’m broke, sorry.”

“So what about this cousin person?”

“I don’t know, but whoever it is, they’re definitely the Midwestern type.”

“What?”

“From my experience, people in the Midwest have this impression of Californians, they think all we do out here is fuck. . .”

“We do.”

“And that we’re into all kinds of weird shit. . .”

“We are.”

“And that fascinates them. People from the Midwest, especially those visiting, like to get the full picture, the full experience of being in California so when they get home, they can tell their friends about their exciting time. It’ll be fine. Besides, who cares what happens? What the worst? So this cousin can’t handle the jokes, the advances, the debauchery, she’ll leave and you’ll never see her again and the way Jon is, he’ll quiz me later about it and how he can get involved. It usually strikes him later the events that are going on around him at the moment. It’s hilarious.”

“Yeah, but give me a call anyway when you find out.” She paused as if she were thinking, I could almost hear the rusty wheels turning. “Bring some wine by, that usually breaks the ice. I’d like to work it out.”

“If she goes. I’ll give it my best shot.”

There was another pause, she brought up Heather.

"I'd like to meet her. Well, by the way you describe her, maybe not."

"I guess I should bring her by sometime."

"Stress and Nick say you guys are hanging all over each other."

"Not really."

"If she does come by, I don't want you rubbing it in my face that you two are fucking."

Being silly in love makes one do that. "We haven't fucked yet."

"Yeah, but you've confirmed your lust for her, you've done some things."

"Yeah. . ."

"I think you need to go out with somebody older, somebody who likes to fuck more, none of this childish shit. I want to be in love before I do it."

"Do what, exactly?" I sat back on the couch and lit a cigarette and prepared for her diatribe.

"Never mind that. By the way, my ad in the SF Weekly came out. Did you get a copy? Well, I've gotten a lot of response from it, about thirty calls, yes, my newspaper lovers—as you so fond of calling them—are calling me. When you come over, I have a list of the prospective candidates and I want to see who you approve of. You know, I should write an ad for you. You've got to drop this Heather, young women shit. I'm going to find you an older woman who likes to fuck. You're at the age when you need to fuck, not play reindeer games. Divorced women and single mothers like to fuck, they'll treat you very well, what do you think of that? It'd be good for you. I'll write the ad, make you sound like this reclusive, brooding-but-likes-to-fuck artist type. They'll see it as a challenge and they'll eat it up that you're a writer."

"Well, you wouldn't have to stretch the truth too far,"

"Who cares? You can pretend all the things I say aren't true, you're good at that. Trust me, you'll like it."

I flicked some ashes into the tray, took a long drag, and thought.

“Okay, you write the ad and I’ll pay for it. I’m game.”

“Good, you won’t be disappointed. Well, I’ve got to go, got to go to my parents’ house and do all that Mother’s Day shit. The whole family will be there, I get to chow down. Give me a call and leave a message as to what’s going on.”

“Okay, bye.”

I set the phone in its cradle and stared at the cigarette in my hand. Through Gale’s conversation I kept on getting this picture in my head. I was thinking of the time in our little apartment in San Mateo (Bellevue Street) when she first told me she was going out with these newspaper lovers. I remember her bragging about Bruce and how we would fight, well not fight so much, but how we loudly talked about it. Sometimes I get nostalgic about those days although they were the shits; I had absolutely no money and spent a good portion of my time alone—at least I got a lot of writing done. I found myself in the same position now I was in over two years ago, frantically writing with plans of leaving Rhindy and all the strife, all the pain. The lovers were in the picture again and although there was more respect between us about them (i.e., the approval process Gale came up with) I still couldn’t help feeling a little funny about it all. I had tried to hide my feelings, but Gale always insisted on asking me if it was all right. She either must have sensed my uneasiness or she wanted to start a fight. But I wouldn’t interfere, I kept my policy of noninvolvement—a survival tactic of late—she had her life and as long as we could remain friends through the whole ordeal then it would be okay. As soon as that was in jeopardy, I would say something.

At times, I wonder why I even do what I do; not the writing thing, but the whole debauched scene. It could be a one-way road to the asylum, feeling the sanity slither away and the waves of madness drowning you

washing away your identity. Gale appeared sane, she was coherent although a little psychotic, like everybody in these times. The cigarette was almost finished, it was near to the filter, at it's most depressing point. I looked at it and couldn't help strike its analogy about life. I placed our relationship about medium burn, halfway through the smoke although this was a new cig—the first one burned down to the fiberglass a long time ago. It left to stink in the ashtray, I remember the bitter taste in my mouth of trying to smoke it longer.

Another picture I had in my head was the story she had told me a long time ago. I had just rehashed it with Murray last night, about the days when she used to live with her abusive boyfriend. Apparently, there was one time when she had lost it and was ranting; it climaxed by her cutting her wrists and calling for help. She phoned her parents, telling what had happened neglecting to tell them how much she was bleeding. When the ambulance came, the paramedics were surprised that she had even survived. She was kept under observation for the remainder of the night. Her parents were wondering where she was, they even had phoned me. She was in the psyche ward, she said, they had to give her some dynamite drugs to calm her.

Murray paced around the pool table; we were in a bar, both with pints of beer in our hands. He had a silly smirk on his face.

"Gale is such a character, she belongs in a book. I believe it when they say truth is stranger than fiction, Chrisman. You just can't let her life slip away, you should write this book called, *The Complicated, Unexpurgated, Uncensored Life of Gale Tolerton*. Now, that would be interesting."

A good idea, although, I had already beat him to the punch. I told him about the book I was currently (trying to) write.

"Have you put in all the stuff about her?"

"As best as I could capture it."

“Wow. So are there any more details, anything else new with her?”

“Well, there is a crowning jewel to all of this.”

“No, no, nothing could get better than that. The hospital, this scenario with the newspaper lovers and the Billy character, he’s great.”

I spun him the whole yarn.

“One more thing. . .”

He leaned against the pool table, the balls were racked and ready to be broken.

“Through all of it, the Billy incident and the newspaper lovers, the approval process, the reason she gave me for dumping Billy was. . .you ready?”

He smiled, nodding quickly. “Yeah.”

“She told me she was in love with me.”

“No, no!!!”

He walked away from me to a corner of the bar. He had his back to me and he was shaking his head laughing hysterically. He stayed there for a few minutes, laughing, looking at the ceiling, back to me, to the floor then to the ceiling again. He finished his beer, set the glass on the jukebox, and walked over to me. He eyed the balls on the table, rubbing tears from his eyes.

“Boy, that’s something.”

I shook my head. “I’ll say.”

“That takes the cake.”

He mumbled to himself.

“She said she loves you?” He chuckled.

Our glances met, he gave me a ‘I feel sorry for you’ look.

“You’d better break.”

He picked up the cue ball and massaged it with his fingers, placing it on the table, he set up for the break. He miscued the ball three times

missing the entire rack. He was still laughing. I smirked, it was getting tiresome.

“Want me to break?”

On the fourth try he succeeded. He left the table and went to the bar. I made an uneventful shot and joined him, there were two shots of Jägermeister sitting before him. He handed me one and raised his glass to his lips. He made a gesture as if to toast.

“To Gale.”

I smiled. “Yes, to Gale. And the creative spirit.”

The liquor went down smoothly, entirely dissimilar to my current life experience, incongruous to my frame of mind for it could be said I was in turmoil. It could also be said I was reaching nirvana. The ensuing burn mimicked my existence with sickening exactness.

May 10. I woke early, the heat in the apartment was unbearable. I attempted to go back to sleep, but it proved fruitless. I had been up late the night before and the feeling of drinking too much was pounding my head. Ten o'clock could be seen as late to some; Rhindy had left for work over two hours before making certain I was awakened by her incessant thrashing around—slamming doors, tearing through the dresser for her clothes—as she was ready to leave, she climbed on the bed and asked me if I was going out tonight. I mumbled something incoherent and she asked me to repeat myself. I sighed and she kissed me. I had a frown etched into my face as she closed the door.

The sun beamed in; it must've been hot outside—the bedroom was like an oven. I asked myself if I should fix my car today, I was getting tired of using Rhindy's to pick up Heather. But I couldn't convince myself to do so, I felt as if I was making advances with my writing and any sort of diversion would be detrimental. Besides, there would always be time to repair the junk-heap and if I had my car at my disposal, then I might opt to go somewhere instead of staying here and working.

It seems I constantly have problems with this, I've always been caught between cars and writing. Whenever I didn't feel like writing, then the car would be okay; whenever the opposite, I felt like writing, then the car would never be working. I found I would be sitting in the apartment worrying about it—when I would be able to drive it again, the time I would have to spend fixing it, and so on and so on. Most of the time, I wouldn't think too much of it, but now with this proposed move away from Rhindy and the movie rental for the piece of crap car topping out at \$100 a night, I found it a little hard not to think. Perhaps next week I would try to repair it, but not today, there were too many important things to do. There was always enough time to make money. Besides, I had more fun schmoozing it.

Later. It's near two and I found that the ribbon in the typewriter is getting a little worn. I had bought one a couple of months before, at least I thought I did. But the print is becoming more and more faded, a few more pages and I won't be able to see the words at all. And I was running out of paper too. I sifted through the pack, there were only two sheets left so I supposed that if I wanted to continue this writing project then I had better get some more. Fucking figures, I finally get the dust out of my head and set my happy ass down to write. And damnit, if I'm not being productive, too. No sense worrying about it, Heather was working today and I hadn't seen or heard from her since Saturday afternoon. I also supposed that I should go see her since the stationary store was in the mall next to her work. We were still on good terms, at least I thought so.

I had all the windows open in the apartment, the air was still, the smoke from the cigarette hung lazily in the air. It was still hot—not a cloud in the sky—another earthquake day. Probably too hot for walking. It's days like this when my mind drifts back to when I lived with my parents in the valley. I had an old convertible and no matter

how fast I drove, the sun would still be too hot, no breeze could quell the heat. I was going out with Theresa then, she would come with me on the drives. She talked about what she was going to do when she went off to college to get her Master's. She hadn't even gotten her Bachelor's yet, I thought about what I was going to do with my life. Contrary to her, I didn't have my life so neatly planned out. I could barely conceive of what college I was going to much less what I was going to study. In the past, at a junior college, I studied music; finished with that stupid idea, I was steering myself toward a career as an English teacher. But who really knows? I'd like to say that it was simpler in those days, but then I would be lying. It feels that life has always been hell, a series of complex mistakes, miseries, strife, and failure; maybe when I was at my parents', it didn't affect me so much psychologically, but now that I spend the bulk of my time alone or with Gale, or with Heather; each causing me their own unique brand of stress, things bothered me more seriously. With each new caustic scenario, it was permanently engraved into my mind, simultaneously chipping away at the remnants of the not-so-bad thought that was previously there. The negative experiences were cold blades digging into the back of my skull, prying into my brain, exposing my private thoughts—distorting and disconnecting them—their propensity of import made negligible, threatening my very existence as a sane man. In 1989, life couldn't be more perfect: No head games, no animosity; I was working on a screenplay with her, if I was thinking then like I think now perhaps she could have been my ninety-nine—a cerebral vacation, that's what I needed. With her I felt good, I only wished it could be like that again. There were times when I thought I should be looking for her, but the time that separated she and I was vast. Besides, I had hurt her, dealt the final blow, the wound I inflicted would last her for the rest of her life as long as I was around to remind her. There also were times when

I thought Heather could be ninety-nine, but the further our relationship continued, the casual ups and downs becoming vicious pitches, I found it to be impossible. I was a medieval knight on an impossible quest; the true victim being my sanity, my sword resembling my intellect, my shield being my sarcasm, dark humor, and reluctance to commit. It wasn't as if I didn't want to commit to Heather, I was all for it; but the \$64,000 question was: Would the relationship be worth it if she would ever return my sentiments? I was engaged in paradox, going nowhere fast. Was there a solution forthcoming or would I collapse losing all cohesion? The radio played an old rock song, I found myself listening to it; I was trying to distract myself. It only worked momentarily. The other day, I met somebody who asked me what I did. I told him I was a writer and he replied that I must have to think all the time. I didn't say anything, I wanted to confirm the fact neither to him nor myself. Perhaps I would lose it one day; swept away by the waves of my own insane design. Impenetrable as it would be, I never would be able to return once having thrown myself into the abyss. A teacher in junior college said that writing was therapeutic, however, mine seemed to encourage only the opposite. I was not a writer, but the antithesis—I was an anti-writer. Every word I wrote echoed the shifting, almost stifling, emotions in me, if I can't keep a steady pace in my brain, then the writing which issues forth will reflect the same, which means I have to live a thousand lives, feel ten thousand emotions at once in order to make sense of the cosmic soup that assaulted me at any given time. Regardless of what I thought, I knew if I ever would finish the damn book, soon after I would soon have to review it. This meant I would be rehashing everything and reliving the whole nightmare of the writing process from beginning to end. Perhaps, I was over-thinking the whole affair; maybe when the time came for revision that it wouldn't be as bad as I was thinking. Perhaps I was being too paranoid, this seemingly

insurmountable task and the pressure of not only getting through it, but overcoming it, farcical.

I decided on the walk although the day was far too hot. I broke into a sweat near to the mall. I picked up a ribbon, (I couldn't find the one I thought I had bought) some paper and I stopped in to see Heather. She seemed pleased to see me, her eyes almost lit up when she saw me.

"How are you today?" She smiled.

"Okay, just came to pick up a few things."

She eyed the package in my hand. "Paper and ribbon, I see. Hard at work?"

"I think so."

"Are you free tonight?"

I was gazing off into the store eyeing the racks and rows of shiny cassettes and compact discs. "What?"

"Do you want to do anything tonight? It's warm outside. Maybe it'll be warm later."

"Yeah, that sounds good. What time?"

"I get off at 12:30. See you then?"

"12:30. Sure." I'd have to come up with an excuse to escape from Rhindy. Just like every other night.

"I'd better get back to work."

She sauntered off, squatting to pick up some cassettes on the floor. I smiled.

On the walk back, my thoughts drifted onto more concrete, real life things. I was thinking of the conversation Jon and I had last night. We retold all the old stories of when we were growing up and all the mischievous things we did. We had had dinner in the diner up the street, Rhindy had come along since Jon had brought his cousin—Elizabeth, I think, her name was. The cousin was nice looking, but I didn't dare hit on her in such close proximity to Rhindy. Besides, she didn't seem to

fit into my debauchery ideas—she didn't seem an appropriate cohort. I hoped our conversation would be a little more constructive, a little more opulent, but we barely touched the screenplay I had given him to read. I would have like to get him in the project with Murray, he could use the help and I could use the company. I, later, over beers and alone in the apartment, decided not to be so critical. I shouldn't be so demanding that I and everyone else should be constantly working. In the same thought I also supposed that I should call Gale today and tell her how it went. I never got around to calling her. And why? If she could have been there in the restaurant, having herself filled with cheap wine and stilted conversation, she would have been just as sick as I was now. I can't get out of this rut, the dirt is now being shoveled over me. Perhaps Gale wanted to see this debauchery thing to work out—she said she had filled her requirements, I hadn't—I was deaf and mute. I wondered if her disappointment would be apparent in her voice. God knows I couldn't bear seeing her.

I rubbed my forehead, the headache had almost vanished—still a little pain above one eye—it must've been the searing sun that was causing it. I loathed the daytime hours, not much happened and I always was in pain. The night was my playground. I would have liked to lived the life of a vampire if such a thing was possible. But this was all fantasy like so many things these days.

The apartment had cooled off a little when I returned. I opted to do something completely out of the ordinary—watch some television, maybe that would stifle the barrage of thoughts racing through my head. The images on the screen were just a bland as the story line they were attempting to portray. I hated TV. My writing suffered all the while.

May 11. I woke about one in the afternoon, since I had gotten to bed late the night before. Heather kept me out until five AM. The

night had been nice, even around two the air was still warm; it felt like late fall, such a rarity that the moments she and I shared were ripe for memory.

Before all that, however, I should preface the story. Okay. Yesterday, the 10th, just before Jon and his cousin arrived, Rhindy lay those eyes on me. So, around five in the afternoon, we had sex. It was nothing worth remembering since it wasn't sadistic or formidable in any way, shape, or form. But this is not the point. After dinner, feeling steadfastly guilty for ignoring Gale, I went to her place unannounced to try to patch things up. Well, as things go, around ten or ten-thirty, I fucked her. I figured all the while: "Hey, getting it twice in one day from two different chicks," at least I washed. And if any guilt would assail me in regard to Heather, who knew if we would ever have sex, but that doesn't matter much because: "Hey, I'm getting it from two different chicks in one day". But, as if that wasn't bad enough and as if my luck couldn't be any worse, wait until you read the following. Ignoring any negative imagery I may be prone to conveying, it is my goal to only capture the essence of the experience and all that:

Heather and I went to the beach; the night was mysterious, like something out of a dream, something I vaguely remembered happening before. At times I swore I could see a dark, peach colored house down the beach although there were no houses there. We lay on the oily sand and looked to the sky. A bright moon hung behind us, it cast long shadows.

"This couldn't be a more romantic night," she said.

I had been made to wait for a "romantic" night, only then would sex be appropriate. It was this notion she imbued that frustrated yet rewarded me. I supposed she was still young and hadn't had the hard experiences of life to jaundice her or maybe I had just let them get the

best of me. I smiled. She lay on top of me and kissed me passionately, her lips hard against mine.

I pulled her down, she ground herself into me, my excitement obvious. We rolled over and I was on top of her kissing her lips and neck determined to make this the perfect night. Perfect like the moon and the sky and the stars and the ocean. A perfection all too elusive yet soothingly enticing.

But it was this obsession with perfection, with having one hundred percent, that made it all too easy to get wrapped up in experiencing the contrary. Soon, I found that I hated playing this game, making things “perfect”; I wished for straightforwardness. She told me that she wanted to have sex with me and I told her likewise—we agreed on the ends to our means—why couldn’t we simply carry out our collective desires? Why this badgering, why this coerciveness? It must be a fault of the society in which we live—of those who say we must stifle those who go too much against the grain, of those who are hedonists. I thought about prostitutes and their “work”. There was no moral compass, no pedantic conversation to separate oneself from the intended desire. They knew what their customers wanted and the customers came to them for the reasons they would expect—there was no grey area, simple. If only the rest of life could follow this demarcation, then the world would be a hell of a better place—and a lot more rewarding. Nick told me repeatedly that I had to give up all this “Henry Miller bullshit” as he called it. He said it was poisoning my thoughts causing me to live philosophically beyond my limits. He says I should get a steady girlfriend and pursue a steady relationship and forget anything and everything that may lead beyond it. His ideas at the moment seemed puerile and naive, but I wasn’t thinking of Nick and his bullocks.

I decided to move more slowly, perhaps a little pensively since I suddenly began to think of Rhindy alone at home and Heather

was giving off the mood that she wasn't ready for us to have sex. This reserved attitude I mechanically moved myself though, hated yet, because I wasn't with my usual debauched crowd, had to lower myself into in order to do what is expected in "normal" society. I pulled away from her and she was smiling. She slid off her underwear from under her dress and I kneeled before her, worshipping her.

"I bet \$10,000 that you have a condom."

She would have been rich, I poor, but it was pure coincidence that I had one. Gale had given me it a couple of days before. At first I was pissed that she did (because she knows I won't fuck her with one), but now glad for it. I lay back down on her and slowly put myself in. She let out deep moans, three or four at first but as she got into the rhythm a few moments later, instead panted. She was mumbling incoherently and said my name once, I became lost in the passion known as Heather and knew no other.

The time slithered quickly by and although I saw no one on the shore, I had felt a presence behind me. Without stopping I looked down the beach for the house I thought I had seen. It still was not there yet I knew it had been and still was there; maybe not in the concrete sense, but in my mind it was ever-present. In a flash I had figured it out. It was like the house in the dream—a peach and white trim house—it belonged to a woman; I didn't know her name. She was here now. There were times I thought she was standing behind us, at the coastline, watching. She wasn't sad, but envious, like the dead watching the living jealous of the pleasures they could no longer experience. There was some sort of connection between us, in some way, she felt everything I did. It could have been in the Hippodrome, or in the convertible, or over Oreos. . . it mattered not, however, we were one in the same. I thrust myself harder and deeper into Heather. I wasn't only doing it for myself or Heather but for her as well. If she

could feel what I did, then I wanted more for her because she was the one and true ninety-nine.

I mistakenly called Heather that later. She smiled broadly and uttered a reserved “thank you”. She knew a little of my philosophy of ninety-nine; regardless, from the look in my eyes, she would have understood the whole idea in an instant. We sat up and she resolved not to put her underwear back on. She said sand had gotten into them; that notwithstanding, she wanted to cool off first. I took it as a compliment. We both had cigarettes which, at the time, whispered perfection. It was the perfect finality to the perfect evening. Perfect in every way—one hundred percent perfect.

I envisioned ninety-nine still on the coastline looking hard at me, smiling. I suppose she might have enjoyed it as I had. Her ninety-nine touched the one lying next to me—both sanguine, both red, and both tempestuously beautiful. A cascade effect was now in process, both our fates sealed and our lives given direction from this time forth. No longer alone to wander in the darkness, she turned, walked down the beach, and vanished.

BEGIN KEYING IN REMAINDER OF NOVEL:

Gale phoned around three and asked if I wanted to go furniture shipping with her. I had nothing else to do and the writing was slow—an amazing fact in itself since the events of the previous night. Whether or not I was a good enough writer to capture the essence of the wondrous evening, it remains the annoying fact that I didn’t worship Heather and ninety-nine with purity. Considering the fact I had slept with Rhindy and Gale only hours before, the night was solely reduced to: “Hey, I slept with three different chicks in one day”. Barring that, I had a wonderful time. If I could only live within the memory, the purity of which I existed within the moments, of the unification of body and mind and spirit within this and the extant reality, I would realize I had

come away with something people only dream of—something that they cannot readily understand or begin to hope for.

I went with Gale. As quiet as I was, she launched question after question at me. She asked if I did anything interesting after I left her place, if tonight was the night I was supposed to go with Rhindy to those pre-marital classes. I said no and yes, but told her I wasn't the least interesting since I didn't have the slightest inclination to marry her. Gale and I got into a fight later, something to do with me being mean and abrasive toward her and that I wouldn't lend her money so she could get gas. That and she knew I was holding back something important. And according to our debauchery contract, what I was doing violated the pact. I cared little, the warm memory of Heather and I and ninety-nine—of one hundred percent perfection—was my memory and my memory alone. Right now, I would share it with no one. I wouldn't fight with Gale right now; I mentioned I had no money because I only worked Saturdays at the bookstore now. I supposed they were getting ready to fire me, they had nearly cut my hours to nearly nil—and after all the time I had worked for them, nearly a year and a half. Funds were tight, I assured her; she was unaffected by my assertion. We apologized to each other a half-hour later and agreed we shouldn't fight; we were united in crime, the only ones who saw eye to eye on the debauched scene—if we weren't simply the only ones—anyway, there were plenty of others to argue with. She said I was Henry and she Anais, or maybe June or Mona—she didn't know which.

It seemed like I was primed to fight with just about everyone; Rhindy had a few words for me when I got home. She complained that because I wasn't working as much as I should that I was causing a crimp in her budget—damn the fact I was also going to school (well, sort of). I expressed concern; I had been looking for a better job—maybe not

as hard as I should, barring classes and all that—I was also trying to finish the novel. I knew that none of these excuses would suit her, she continued her ranting.

“You just don’t try hard enough at anything,” she said.

“Not true,” said I, “I have so many things going at once, it’s hard to juggle them all.”

She snorted. “Yeah, right.”

A voice in my head urged the quickness of moving out. Only through independence would I achieve true happiness; only living your life on your own terms would solve the immediate problems at hand.

But Rhindy continued. On and on she droned.

“You don’t care, you don’t care. . .”

There was only one way out of this. It was either fuck her or listen for the next hour to meaningless, pedantic banter.

I set her on the couch, I stood before her. She eyed my crotch.

“Is sex all you think about? What about our relationship? Isn’t that important too?”

“Yes, it is.” I unbuttoned my fly.

I reached down and massaged her breasts, squeezing the nipples. She started breathing her usual somewhat deep, uninspired moans of assumed pleasure. I say assumed only because of the routine and of the necessity of them.

“I can’t believe you,” she said pulling my cock out and licking the head.

I ran the back of my hand along her cheek; she with penis in hand, smiled up at me.

At times like these I wished I were somewhere else fucking some other woman.

May 12. Rhindy woke me early and apologized for the hell she put me through the night before. Seems my attentiveness to her sexual

appetites paid off; I laid her while facing her, staying in that position until I came inside her—the way she liked it. Needless to say, it took just about forever for me to come, her sex was loose and sloppy and rubbed me in all the wrong places—especially during orgasm—but no matter, my independence was only a stone's throw away. Despite her futile attempt for a morning conversation, I got myself back to sleep and when she was gone and I awoke, I rehashed a dream about Heather.

I ended up calling her in the afternoon. She said she was down with the flu and couldn't see me for a few days. She asked if I had it (the flu) and I told her I wasn't the least bit sick; in fact, I hadn't been better health. She didn't talk long, she said that she would call me tomorrow—on Thursday—and that maybe we could get together late Friday. I reminded her that I worked on Saturday delivering auto parts, and that Thursday would be better for me. She asked about the weekend, but I had to see my parents—my brother was in town. This, however, thinly disguised the real need to see my folks. Janet had found a place on the peninsula, we were to move in on the first of June. This meant I had to have almost \$500 by May 28th; since I wouldn't have any money until the 10th of June, I had no alternative but to press my parents to lend me the funds. I wasn't sure if it would work, but I had to give it a shot. Just to get away from Rhindy. . .

I had a good story cooked up. Bringing out the heavy artillery, I would tell my mother how it just wasn't working between Rhindy and I. I was suffering. I didn't know if it was her incessant bitching about work or my lack of performing chores around the apartment or my lack of having adequate finances to pay the bills—despite the fact I usually had the money for rent by the end of the month—but she always found a way to make me feel guilty that I wasn't doing enough. I wasn't working as hard as she was. This triggered depression which in turn sacrificed any hope of writing. It was obvious to me that Rhindy didn't

support my writing; I knew she could never believe in what I was doing and it was certain she was the cause of the block.

I would have to tell my parents all this and it was absolutely essential that I did; if it meant that I couldn't see Heather for a few days then so be it. Getting the hell out of this apartment was far more important than a random encounter on an oily, refuse strewn beach. Now that I think about it, Heather never once called me, she never engaged in one of those 'hi, how are you doing, just wanted to see what's up although I'm sick and can't go out' type of call. I was the one calling her. Perhaps I was asking too much of her, demanding too much of her intellect, but communication was the key to continuing our relationship. And on this day, I get the sense she doesn't give as much of a shit as I do about us. If she doesn't think we are worth the effort, then she'd better let me know—I don't want to be the naive idiot shadowing her every feminine move.

We gave the usual 'byes' and I went to the bathroom to relieve myself. I found some red pubic hairs mixed with mine in my underwear; I extracted and studied them at my desk. I set them beside my typewriter and stared at them. In the hopes they were Heather's, they were probably Rhindy's; but I made-believe that they were Heather's. I flicked on the typewriter and pecked out a few lines.

'Thinking of the beach, the night, and how she smelled. Her perfume was light and her hair soft. Oh, how I wanted to make love to her. Her skin was milky white under the light of a bright moon, her body unscarred by childbirth, her breasts firm and nipples hard under her summer dress. She runs her hands along my back, digging her nails into me, her breaths are deep and quick. She lets me rub myself against her pubis, stimulating her, she is moist and warm. With each pulse she looks at me, maybe this would be the time when I put myself inside her; I ached and throbbed every second I wasn't in her. When

she finally lifted her dress and guided me to her, the feeling of her thighs pressing tightly against me pushing me in further overtook me. Electricity raced down my spine, it swelled in me, my sex drawn tight, her legs intertwined with mine. In unregistered time we became frantic, I lay close to her, her arms on my shoulders, she kissing and biting my neck. I open her mouth with my tongue and draw her breath; our stares are transfixed. Remaining locked, our pace quickens and, in a flood of desire, I release. She squeezes me tighter, her hips reverberating with my orgasm. In a torrent of thought, I want to experience more of her, I want more time, lay with her in an apartment, caressing her body and tasting her. My desire once strong, I focus on her only to be distracted by another. In the conundrum of what I want and need to do to and with her, time steals the moment and signals the lateness of the hour. My final thought papered with myriad hopes for future time.'

That's about all I can muster. It sounds okay, I guess. The thoughts of afterwards shook me; it seems all I can think of is the negative. I didn't want to write those impure thoughts—they would only distort and disengage the paradisaical nature of my divine dreams.

While looking at the ocean, I began hating myself for being so distracted by this 'other woman'. When I was eighteen, nothing could draw my attention away from the sex act. Sometimes the ninety-nine obsession was more of a hindrance than anything else; I wanted to experience pure sex for the sake of pure sex, not for the reasons I found myself experiencing it for—some ethereal cause.

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May 13. I waited all day for Heather to call and she never did. The phone sat on the table with a dumb, heavy silence about it, the kind of silence that makes you feel mocked by an inanimate object. I smoked too much and stared at the typewriter. Rhindy came home from work

in a better mood than she had been in all week; she smiled when she saw me still there as if my mere presence in the apartment should have been construed as fidelity. I could not decide which was worse—her anger or her good humor. At least when she was furious there was no confusion.

“You stayed home tonight,” she said.

“For now.”

She put her purse on the chair, kicked off her shoes, and went to the refrigerator. “For now?” She glanced at me over the door. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

“Nothing. It means I’m here.”

“That’s not an answer.”

I lit another cigarette and stared at the curl of smoke. “I’m tired, Rhindy.”

She looked at me as if trying to decide whether I was being dramatic or just cruel. “You’re always tired.”

“Maybe because I’m tired of this.”

“This?”

I waved my hand at the walls, the couch, the dishes in the sink, the heat trapped in the little rooms, the whole absurd domestic theater of our life together. “This.”

She shut the refrigerator and stood with her back against it. “Then leave.”

There it was. Not said in rage this time or in the heat of an argument, but coolly, with the full force of practical meaning. The words sounded clean in the room. I could feel my heart beating faster—not from fear exactly, but from that awful thrill you get when something you’ve talked about so often finally steps out of abstraction.

“I’m going to.”

She laughed once, a small humorless exhalation. "No, you're not. You always say that. You say that, then you go out, then you come back, and then we do this all over again."

"I said I'm going to."

She narrowed her eyes. "Do you have somewhere to go?"

"Yes."

"With who?"

I did not answer.

Her jaw tightened. "So there is somebody."

"There is always somebody, Rhindy. Isn't that the joke?"

She moved toward me then stopped, as if she had forgotten whether she meant to slap me or hold onto me. "You bastard."

I nodded. I had been called worse by better women.

"I want you out by the first if you're serious," she said quietly. "No games. No more of this halfway bullshit. If you're leaving, then leave."

I looked at her and thought that for all my complaints about her, she was the only one in the room with any courage. She had, with one sentence, made reality out of my endless posturing.

"Fine," I said. "By the first."

She turned away and went into the bedroom. I heard drawers open and close. I remained on the couch with my cigarette, feeling neither victorious nor sad. Mostly what I felt was tired and mean and more awake than I had in months.

May 15. Heather finally called this afternoon. I had been out walking and returned to find a message on the machine. She said she was sorry she hadn't called sooner, that she had still been sick and sleeping a lot and trying to keep herself together. Keep herself together. I heard in those words the beginning of distance. A woman only says such things when she has begun withdrawing to some protected country where you are not permitted to travel.

I called her back and she answered on the second ring.

"You sound better," I said.

"A little."

"You disappeared."

"I told you I was sick."

"Yes, I know, but you vanished too."

There was a pause. I heard the faint sound of traffic behind her, then the clink of something metallic. Maybe she was standing outside work, smoking, watching people go by. For a second I could picture her clearly and that made it worse.

"I've been thinking," she said.

I hated those words.

"About what?"

"About us. About you."

"Those are not the same thing."

"No, they're not."

Another pause. I could feel the conversation slipping into one of those channels from which there is no easy recovery. I tried to force brightness into my tone.

"Why don't I come see you tonight?"

"I don't want you to."

I swallowed hard. "Because you're sick?"

"Because I don't know what you want from me."

That was almost funny. I looked around the apartment as if the answer might have been written on the furniture. "I want to see you."

"No, I mean really."

I sat on the edge of the couch and rubbed my forehead. "Really? I want to be with you."

She sighed. “That isn’t true, Chris. You want out of your life. Out of that apartment, out of Rhindy, out of whatever the hell else is dragging behind you, and you look at me like I’m the way out.”

I felt a strange coldness move through me. The sentence was so exact that for a moment I wanted to hate her for it. I wanted her to be incorrect, to be petty, confused, romantic, naive—anything but exact.

“That’s not fair.”

“It’s probably not. But it’s what I think.”

I stood and walked to the window. The street below was dull and featureless. “So what now?”

“I don’t know. I just know I can’t carry all of this.”

“All of what?”

“Your girlfriend. Your other women. The way you look at me like I’m supposed to mean everything all at once.”

I did not answer. She had seen too much, and quickly.

“I like you,” she continued, “but I can’t be the thing that gets you out of there.”

That line ended it, not officially, not with a dramatic good-bye or a door slam, but with a horrible little precision. The thing that gets you out of there. Was that what I had come down to? Was I that transparent now?

We talked another few minutes, but only on the surface of things. We did not say we were finished and we did not say we would meet soon. We simply let the conversation expire. When I hung up, I had the feeling that I had been gently refused by reality itself.

May 18. I went to see my parents over the weekend and asked them for the money. I built the speech on the drive out there, revised it on the stairs, and delivered it to my mother in the kitchen while she was drying dishes. The story was not wholly false, which I suppose is why I was able to tell it so smoothly. Rhindy and I were not working. I was

suffering. I needed out. I was trying to write. I was trying to get my life together.

My mother looked at me in the way mothers do when they are weighing the merits of a son against the evidence of his failures. She asked if this move was wise, if I had a job lined up, if I had thought it through.

“No,” I said. “Not completely.”

“Then why now?”

“Because if I don’t leave now, I won’t.”

She put the dish towel down and stared at me. “And this isn’t about another woman?”

I smiled weakly. “It’s always about another woman.”

She did not smile back.

My father said very little. He sat in the other room listening to the television and occasionally muttering something about responsibility. My brother, back in town and as useless as ever, asked whether the new roommate was attractive. I wanted to hit him with a lamp.

By evening, my mother told me she could lend me the money if I paid it back as soon as I was able. I thanked her and felt both relieved and sick. I had, by charm and half-truth and fatigue, secured the means of escape. Yet driving back into the city, I did not feel free. I felt like a thief with a full tank.

May 21. Gale called twice yesterday and three times today. I let the machine get it each time. On the last message she laughed and said she knew I was home and should stop acting like such a prima donna. She said Billy had tried calling again and she nearly threw up just hearing his voice. Then she said she missed me, then she said she hated me, and then the tape clicked off.

I did not call her back.

Rhindy and I have become eerily civil. This is worse in some ways than all the fighting. She has begun speaking to me as though I were already gone. She asks if I need a box. She asks if I'm taking the lamp. She asks if the books by the bed are mine or hers. At night we move around each other carefully, like tenants who have confused a lease with love, or maybe like a pair of actors after the show is over, still in costume but too tired to take it off.

We still had sex one final time. I suppose I should record it because it happened, although it meant nothing more than inertia. She came to me after midnight in one of her old T-shirts, stood there silently until I looked up, then sat beside me and put her hand on my thigh. Neither of us said anything. It was tender only in the sense that a funeral can be called graceful. When it was over, she rolled away and pulled the sheet up to her shoulder.

"Will you at least try to be decent to me this week?" she asked.

"I'll try."

"That's not much."

"It's what I have."

She began to cry then, very softly, which almost undid me. Not enough to stay, but enough to make me ashamed.

May 28. I got the money together, every humiliating dollar of it. What I had from work, what I borrowed, what I extracted from my parents, what I kept in envelopes and under books and in jacket pockets. I put it all on the table and counted it twice. It looked like a child's idea of a fortune.

Janet phoned in the evening and said everything was still set for the first. She sounded cheerful, almost excited, as if we were embarking on some bright collegiate adventure and not simply rearranging the scenery of another gradual collapse.

"You okay?" she asked.

“Sure.”

“You don’t sound sure.”

“I’m moving, Janet. I don’t know what sure sounds like.”

She laughed and told me not to worry, that once I was out things would be different. I had heard that phrase from too many mouths lately. Different. Better. Freer. Cleaner. As if geography could absolve the soul.

Later that night I walked alone to the beach. The air was cold and the water black. I tried to think of Heather and found I could only think of the way she had said the thing that gets you out of there. I tried to think of Rhindy and could only think of the apartment with my absence already built into it. I tried to think of Ninety-Nine and for one fleeting second I saw her again, not on the sand beside me but farther down the shoreline, motionless, as if waiting to see whether I would finally understand something.

I wanted to ask her if all this movement meant anything. If leaving counted as transformation. If changing rooms and women and coastlines and habits, or saying I would, counted as transformation. If I had done enough to justify the pain I had caused. But she did not come closer. She only remained there in my mind, made of moonlight and distance and some promise no human being had ever kept for very long.

June 1. We moved the boxes in two trips. It was overcast on the peninsula, the kind of weather that makes every house seem temporary. Janet was in good spirits, arranging books before the bed was even set up, talking about curtains and coffee and where we might put the little table by the window. I brought in the last box and set it down in what was now my room. My room. The phrase sounded theatrical, almost embarrassing.

The place was quiet. No Rhindy in the kitchen. No notes on the table. No expectation humming in the walls. I stood in the center of

the room and waited for the rush of relief that had been promised by every nerve in my body these last weeks. It did not come.

What arrived instead was a vast and measured stillness. I was out. I had done it. I had extracted myself from one life and carried my books, my typewriter, my clothes, my cigarettes, my bad habits, my fantasies, my guilt, and my mind into another room in another town. Yet there I was, intact in all the ways I least wanted to be, still myself down to the marrow, which was the one thing I had somehow hoped not to bring.

Janet knocked on the open door holding two cups of coffee.

"Well?" she said. "How does freedom feel?"

I took the cup from her and looked around at the undecorated walls, the window, the boxes still half-opened on the floor.

"Quiet," I said.

"That's all?"

"For now."

She smiled and left me alone. I set the coffee on the windowsill and sat down at the typewriter. Outside, the afternoon hung in a grey haze. There was no ocean here, at least not in sight, but I could feel the old pull of distance all the same. Somewhere Rhindy was returning from work to an apartment without me. Somewhere Heather was living her life beyond the weight of my projections. Somewhere Gale was talking herself into or out of another calamity. And somewhere beyond all of them, beyond the women and the rooms and the miles and the filth and the wanting, there was still Ninety-Nine, not as a woman I could hold but as the shape of everything I had failed to become.

I rolled a page into the machine and pressed my fingers to the keys. The room was quiet enough to hear myself think, which is not always a blessing. I no longer had any excuses, or not the old ones anyway: not Rhindy, not the apartment, not the noise of the city, not the tyranny

of needing to leave. I had my freedom, such as it was. And the terrible thing about freedom is that, once granted, it expects an answer.

I struck the first key.

For a long while I sat there listening to the single line I had made and the silence around it. Then I looked toward the window and in the reflection, for the briefest moment, I thought I saw a woman with dark red hair standing behind me, smiling not with promise but with knowing. When I turned, there was no one there.

I faced the page again.

The only thing left to do was begin.